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TAKING OFFENCE AND INCIVILITY IN THE OMANI SOCIETY

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ABSTRACT

This study investigated what causes individuals in Omani society to take offence, and the norms that govern the perception of incivility in Oman. Previous research on (im)politeness has predominantly focused on the speaker's role in causing, often overlooking the hearer's evaluative perspective in taking offence. Moreover, recent research that has focused on the hearer's perspective has investigated taking offence through a moral lens. While this approach captures an important evaluative dimension, not all instances of offence are morally anchored. Therefore, this study argues that offences also arise from perceived violations of sociocultural norms and expectations.

While the notion of taking offence has recently gained attention, incivility remains relatively underexplored within (im)politeness research. Most existing work on incivility has emerged from fields such as sociology, political science, criminology, and organisational psychology, where the focus has been on identifying and classifying uncivil behaviours and examining their consequences. These studies prioritise the act itself rather than exploring the evaluative processes through which lay individuals interpret certain behaviours as uncivil. However, more recent work in sociology and (im)politeness, particularly by Horgan (2020, 2024) has shifted the focus towards how ordinary people evaluate mundane behaviours through a moral lens, framing incivility as a form of moral transgression. This idea is beginning to have a greater impact on (im)politeness theory per se, as reflected in the works of Haugh (2022) and Parvaresh (2022). While this framing captures an important aspect of judgement, this study argues that incivility, just like taking offence, is best understood in the Omani context as a perceived transgression of sociocultural norms and expectations.

To investigate how taking offence and incivility are evaluated as perceived transgression of sociocultural norms and expectations, this study adopted an explanatory sequential mixed-methods design consisting of two phases. In the first phase, data was collected from X (formerly known as Twitter) to gain an initial understanding of the two phenomena using specific hashtags and keywords in the Arabic language, such as #offended and #uncivil. The data was first analysed using corpus analysis, which focused on identifying linguistic structures associated with the expression of taking offence and incivility using collocations, n-grams, and frequency analysis. The second phase focused on capturing individuals' personal experiences of taking offence and incivility to deepen the understanding of the phenomena.

The findings revealed that both offence and incivility in Omani society are shaped by violations of deeply embedded sociocultural norms, with evaluation rooted in the perception of unmet expectations. Notably, offence as expressed in the X data was less about individual hurt and more about collective disapproval. The corpus analysis revealed that offence was articulated using collective terms such as 'we', 'Omanis', 'our', and 'people', indicating that individuals positioned themselves as speaking on behalf of a broader social group rather than from a purely individual perspective, thereby framing offence as a shared concern. The main concern underlying these expressions was the perceived violation of social identity face, particularly through acts that were seen to disrespect and misrepresent Omanis. Diary report data, on the other hand, highlighted

offence as a more personal and relational experience, rooted in failures to meet expectations of *ma'rūf* (favour), *iḥtirām* (deference) based on social role, and equity rights.

Incivility in both X and diary reports, in contrast, was judged as a violation of sociocultural norms and those governing public behaviour, with evaluations most prominently anchored in expectations tied to social identity face, even when the acts themselves varied, ranging from littering and immodest dress to mistreating expatriates. At the same time, the analysis highlighted that a single behaviour could give rise to multiple judgements depending on the normative lens through which it was assessed. Littering; for example, was viewed as a violation of religious norms, a threat to social identity face, and a failure to uphold communal responsibility.

This study contributes to (im)politeness research and sociological research by highlighting how offence and incivility are evaluated through sociocultural norms and expectations, drawing on both online discourse and lived experiences within Omani society.

Keywords: taking offence, incivility, norms and expectations, inappropriate, uncivil, offensive

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CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction

The purpose of this thesis is to investigate taking offence and incivility in the Omani society, focusing on the underlying sociocultural norms and expectations that shape individuals' judgements. To situate this research, Section 1.2 offers both background and conceptual grounding for the study of taking offence; it reviews key literature and also identifies the existing gaps, as well as how this research seeks to address them. Section 1.3, in a similar manner, provides background to the study of incivility, outlining relevant interdisciplinary perspectives. It also identifies the existing gaps in the literature and explains how the present study contributes to filling the current gaps. After introducing the two main research focuses, the gaps associated with them in the current literature, and how the present research aims to address these gaps, the chapter proceeds to outline the research questions and their objectives in section (1.4). Then, Section 1.5 outlines the methodological approach employed, followed by the research contribution in Section 1.6. Lastly, Section 1.7 provides an overview of the thesis structure.

1.2 Background to the Study of Taking Offence

In the recent decade, attention has been drawn to the notions of *causing and taking offence* (see Haugh, 2015; Parvaresh & Tayebi 2018, 2020; Tayebi, 2016). Nevertheless, greater attention has been given to the former than the latter despite its evident importance for (im)politeness research. The notion of offence, in fact, is situated at the “core of the present models of (im)politeness” (Haugh, 2015, p.2). However, many studies have focused on the act of *causing offence*, i.e., the speaker, whose conduct is framed as a transgression and regarded as potentially offensive to the other party, thereby leaving the role of the hearer out of the bigger picture. It is recognised that being (im)polite does not always mean that one has caused offence, nor does it mean that the person has taken offence (Haugh, 2010). The fact that offence might occur whether the language used is polite or (im)polite leads us to question what makes people take offence in the first place and what is considered offensive. Weckert (2007) maintains that *offence* is “some sort of hurt or pain, displeasure” (p.26). Barrow (2005, as cited in Evans, Jeffries, O'Driscoll, 2019) refers to the word *offensive* as an action or talk that is irritating, annoying or anger-provoking. While these definitions highlight the emotional dimension of taking offence, Haugh (2015) and Culpeper (2011) expanded the understanding of offence to include an evaluative aspect whereby offence involves a judgement of perceived transgression. Building on

this broader view, Parvaresh (2022) defines offence as an “emotionally bad feeling created by what is perceived to be a transgression of (social) expectation and (moral) norms” (p.62), drawing on the work of Haugh (2015) and Culpeper (2011). In this study, however, this definition of offence is adapted to focus specifically on sociocultural norms and expectations, that is, the socially and culturally shared understanding of acceptable conduct. Therefore, taking offence as a whole is defined as the experience of feeling emotionally bad when an individual perceives that their sociocultural norms and expectations have been transgressed. The role of “moral norms” in the evaluation of perceived transgression, as emphasised in Parvaresh’s (2022, p.62) definition, is recognised in this study but is approached differently; this point will be addressed later in this chapter, specifically when discussing the evaluative judgments.

Building on this definition, *taking offence* usually involves two key acts: registering and sanctioning offence (Haugh, 2015). When registering offence, the person takes an affective stance which encompasses negative emotions like annoyance, hurt or anger (Culpeper, 2011). Sanctioning offence, on the other hand, involves taking a moral stance towards an act perceived as transgressive or an affront. In this sense, offence is more than ‘feeling bad’; it is a process of evaluating and grounding one’s moral claims that a particular action is offensive, often drawing on a range of norms, some rooted in social and cultural practices, and others anchored in morality (Tayebi, 2016; Parvaresh, 2022; Haugh, 2015). The moral claims are shaped by what is referred to as the moral order as Davis (2008) defines as “any system of obligations that defines and organises the proper-good, right, virtuous- relations among individuals and groups in a community”. Domenici and Littlejohn (2006, cited in Culpeper, 2011, p.38) similarly describe the moral order as a “socially constructed set of understandings we carry with us from situation to situation”. From a sociological perspective, Garfinkel (1964, p.225) describes the moral order as “the rule-governed activities of everyday life” including the familiar, taken for granted. The moral order thus provides the normative background against which evaluations of offence are made. However, how this moral order is instantiated can vary not only across different social and cultural groups but also within the same group, resulting in variability in perceptions of offence (Spencer-Oatey and Kádár, 2016). This variability in interpretation contributes to the inherently subjective nature of taking offence (Barrow, 2005, as cited in Evans, Jeffries, & O’Driscoll, 2019; Tayebi, 2016; Haugh, 2015). Barrow (2005) argues that feeling offended is a subjective experience, as individuals may react differently to the same act, even within the same society. As Tayebi (2016) notes, such differences can stem from varying schemata and lived

experiences, which shape how individuals perceive and evaluate behaviour. Building on this, Spencer-Oatey and Kádár (2021) explain that when individuals in interactions have significantly different cognitive schemata, formed through their unique backgrounds and experiences, there is a higher likelihood of mismatched expectations. This mismatch can influence how people behave and how they evaluate the behaviour of others, contributing further to the variability in the judgement of what is offensive. Nevertheless, this variability does not negate the presence of a shared meaning system (Fischer and Schwartz, 2011). Through socialisation and repeated exposure, individuals develop a sense of what constitutes normal or acceptable behaviour in particular contexts and then develop expectations around it (Spencer-Oatey & Žegarac, 2018). As such, while individuals may differ in how they evaluate a given behaviour, their evaluations are still shaped by broader shared patterns of meaning (Spencer-Oatey & Kádár, 2021).

Given this understanding that evaluation of offence is both inherently subjective and yet shaped by a broader system of shared meaning, a key question that has emerged in recent research is: What moral grounds do individuals invoke when evaluating certain behaviour as offensive? Several studies have sought to address this by examining perceived breaches in encounters, by focusing on interpersonal concerns such as face and sociality rights. Culpeper et al. (2011), for instance, examined how people from different countries evaluate (im)politeness in social interaction. Nonetheless, despite drawing from several countries, they did not delve into culturally specific interpretations of offence, and their focus remained limited to verbal interaction. Tayebi (2016), on the other hand, examined how interpersonal expectations shape evaluations of offence among Persian speakers, however, her work remains limited to one sociocultural context. More research is needed to understand how offence is evaluated in other Middle Eastern societies, including Oman.

While earlier studies investigated taking offence through the lens of different types of face and sociality rights and interpersonal expectations (see Culpeper et al. 2011, Tayebi, 2016), a more recent shift observed within impoliteness studies has foregrounded the role of morality in evaluative judgements. Xia (2018, p.206) refers to this shift as a “moral turn”, which refers to a growing scholarly focus on how individuals ground their evaluations in “higher-level” moral norms to frame and legitimise their judgements (Haidt & Joseph, 2004; Gouldner, 1960, p.170). More recently, research on taking offence has begun to adopt this moral perspective, emphasising how individuals appeal to shared moral values when evaluating perceived transgressions. For instance, Blitvich (2022, p.70) investigates how moral emotions underpin responses to offensive behaviour in the context of online

public shaming. Drawing on the concept of “good moral panics”, she argues that public acts of shaming on digital platforms are often framed as morally justified, particularly in cases involving racism and mistreatment of children. Her study highlights how individuals appeal to broader moral frameworks such as fairness, harm, and care to legitimise their aggressive responses. Morality is thus positioned as a central organising principle in the evaluation of perceived offences. Similarly, Parvaresh (2022) examined how individuals sanction acts they perceive as offensive by appealing to broader moral norms. Drawing on X posts featuring the hashtag #offended, he demonstrates that taking offence often involves attributing blame to others for violating higher moral-order values such as honesty and fairness. In all of these studies, the focus is on how individuals frame perceived offences through appeals to moral values, positioning morality as a key driver in evaluative judgement. As Haugh, Kádár, and Reiter (2022) highlight the importance of this line of work, they maintain that “offence strongly correlates with understandings of morality and the morally loaded feelings of the participants and observers of such incidents” (p.119). Nevertheless, while the *moral turn* has undoubtedly contributed to our understanding of how the evaluation of offence can be framed through a moral lens, this research argues here that when morality is invoked, it is not always tied to the so-called higher level moral norms. To explain, even when individuals appeal to moral values such as fairness in their responses to perceived offence, their evaluation is not necessarily grounded in universal moral principles. Instead, morality can be invoked as part of sociocultural embedded norms and expectations. In this way, morality operates less as an appeal to universal moral values and more as a reflection of locally shared values. Therefore, investigating offence primarily through the moral norms invoked may risk overlooking how the evaluation of offence can also be shaped by broader sociocultural embedded norms and expectations. Nevertheless, it is important to acknowledge that the data itself can guide the researcher in determining which evaluative grounds, whether appeals to moral norms, sociocultural norms, or both are most salient in participants evaluation of offence.

In summary, although interest in taking offence has emerged in recent years, it remains relatively new within (im)politeness research, with earlier studies focusing predominantly on the act of causing offence rather than on taking offence. Moreover, although recent studies on taking offence have provided valuable insights, there remains a need for further research. To explain, since taking offence is a subjective experience, shaped by individuals’ unique backgrounds, lived experiences, and cognitive schemata (Barrow, 2005), there is still a need to explore how different communities experience and evaluate perceived offence, while also recognising that such evaluations are situated within broader shared meaning systems (Spencer-Oatey & Žegarac, 2018; Fischer & Schwartz,

2011). To date, much of the existing research has been conducted within Western contexts, with some exceptions, such as Tayebi's (2016) study on Persian speakers. However, there remains a lack of research examining offence evaluation within Arab settings, highlighting the need for more culturally diverse investigations. Additionally, the recent emphasis on morality in taking offence research, while offering important insights, has also contributed to widening the gap by directing attention primarily towards appeals to morality. As noted earlier, these risks overlooking the influence of locally embedded sociocultural norms and expectations in shaping evaluative judgement. Furthermore, beyond the above gaps identified in the existing literature, there is also a methodological gap. Studies on taking offence have relied either on online discourse or diary reports, with more recent research predominantly relying on online data. This separation may restrict the ability to capture the full range of how offence is experienced, both as publicly communicated in social media and as privately narrated in diary reports. Therefore, there is a need for research that adopts a more integrative approach combining naturally occurring public expression of offence with personal reflective accounts to provide a comprehensive understanding of the phenomenon.

In order to address these gaps, the present study investigates how offence is evaluated within Omani society, with particular attention to the role of sociocultural norms and expectations in shaping the evaluative judgements. The study draws on two distinct sources of data, social media posts from X and diary report forms, to examine how individuals in Omani society evaluate perceived offence. By focusing on the evaluation of offence within an Arab, non-Western context, this study expands research on taking offence beyond the predominantly Western settings. Moreover, this study brings renewed attention to an earlier focus within (im)politeness research on socioculturally embedded norms and expectations, which has been underexplored in more recent studies on taking offence following the moral turn that emphasises higher level moral norms. While acknowledging the role of morality in shaping individuals' judgements, this research positions appeals to morality as part of the broader sociocultural meaning system rather than as appeals to universal moral norms. Furthermore, this study moves beyond the single-method approaches commonly used in previous studies on taking offence to collect data by combining naturally occurring online discourse with personal reflective accounts. In doing so, it offers a multidimensional perspective on how offence is experienced and evaluated in public and private contexts. Having established the background to the study of taking offence and outlined the key gaps addressed in this research, the following section turns to the phenomenon of incivility, which forms another key focus of this study.

1.3 Background to the Study of Incivility

Incivility, both as a concept and as a social phenomenon, has emerged as another important, yet often overlooked, area of inquiry. While it has received increasing attention in fields such as political science (Papacharissi, 2004; Bormann et al., 2022), sociology (Phillips & Smith, 2006), and organisational psychology (Andersson & Pearson, 1999; Cortina, 2008), its relevance within (im)politeness research remains comparatively underexplored. Sifianou (2019) draws attention to this gap, noting that the relationship between incivility and impoliteness remains a neglected area despite their conceptual overlap. Although the concept of (in)civility has not been a central focus in (im)politeness research, a small number of scholars have engaged with it over the past two decades. Lakoff (2005) describes civility as “acting according to general societal tenets of appropriateness” (p.26), while Incivility reflects a disregard for those tenets. For Lakoff, incivility reflects a breakdown in shared expectations, often surfacing during periods of cultural or political change when traditional restraints no longer hold. Her account suggests that what is labelled as “uncivil” frequently indicates a deeper discomfort with those who disrupt the status quo or challenge dominant norms. Mills (2009, 2017b) refers to Lakoff’s work as addressing “impoliteness at the cultural or societal level” arguing that contemporary judgements about (im)politeness in public discourse tends to be ideological rather than analytical (2009, p.1049). She maintains that the notion of unified “cultural norms” is in many ways “mythical” (p.1058), given the diversity of norms across communities of practice and the influence of power in shaping which norms are treated as dominant. More recently, Terkourafi et al. (2018) and Sifianou (2019) further developed this direction by examining incivility in online contexts, framing it as a discursive breach of expected communicative norms. Terkourafi et al. (2018) analyse a series of controversial tweets, demonstrating how implicated meanings can be misinterpreted or lost due to context collapse on social media. They argue that tweets, while often pragmatically complex, are evaluated in fast-paced public discourse according to surface-level cues, which increases the potential for them to be read as uncivil. Sifianou (2019), on the other hand, draws on an online Greek newspaper article and its associated reader comments to illustrate how incivility is constructed and evaluated in everyday discourse. While her analysis is brief, it highlights the public negotiation of what counts as rude or uncivil behaviour, and how such evaluations are shaped by cultural expectations, tone, and ideology. In her work, she underscores the need for more systematic investigation of incivility within (im)politeness research, particularly given its complex and context-sensitive nature.

Yet, for all its complexity, a few common denominators unite different strands of incivility research

across disciplines: scholars largely agree that incivility is mostly approached as a violation of norms, whether these are social, cultural, political, communicative or organisational in nature (e.g., Muddiman, 2017, Papacharissi, 2004; Lakoff, 2005; Phillips & Smith, 2006; Cortina, 2008; Sifianou, 2019; Bormann et al., 2022). Moreover, the widely acknowledged commonality is that incivility is highly subjective, shaped by what individuals perceive as uncivil, meaning that incivility is not an objective quality of an utterance or action but an evaluation (e.g., Phillips & Smith, 2006, Andersson & Pearson, 1999; Stryker et al., 2021; Bormann et al., 2022).

Despite these shared insights, what remains largely absent from the literature is detailed empirical research on how individuals themselves evaluate an act as uncivil, whether in online discourse, which has received the bulk of recent scholarly attention, or in mundane everyday encounters where such judgements also frequently occur (Phillips & Smith, 2006). In response to this gap, and echoing the recent *moral turn* in (im)politeness research, a similar evaluative shift has emerged in the field of urban sociology. Horgan (2020, 2024), for instance, explores how ordinary people interpret and morally judge breaches of expected conduct in public life, drawing on interview data about encounters with rude strangers in public spaces. He conceptualises these judgements as occurring within a broader “moral landscape” understood as “culturally available meanings organised around a basic sacred/profane binary” p.128. While Horgan’s account provides a valuable lens for understanding how incivility is evaluated in the public sphere, his notion of moral landscape tends to foreground the moral framework that individuals draw upon when evaluating something as uncivil. It highlights how participants often appeal to shared, seemingly universal moral values such as kindness and respect when making their judgements. However, the emphasis on morality may overlook the extent to which evaluations of incivility are shaped by sociocultural norms and context-specific expectations.

Nonetheless, despite Horgan’s (2020, 2024) emphasis on the moral dimension of the evaluative judgement, his work makes an important contribution by shifting the understanding of incivility towards the evaluative grounds upon which individuals draw to make sense of breaches in public conduct. However, while this study offers a valuable starting point, further research is needed to explore the full range of evaluative grounds individuals may draw upon to legitimise their judgements including the role of sociocultural embedded norms and expectations in shaping the judgement.

Focusing on the grounds that participants allude to goes beyond simply identifying and categorising what individuals label as uncivil or which behaviours they perceive as inappropriate, which was the

case in previous research on incivility across the disciplines (e.g. Phillips & Smith, 2006). Instead, it involves examining the normative assumptions and interpretive frameworks (Garfinkel, 1967; Goffman, 1974; Spencer-Oatey & Žegarac, 2018) that shape how individuals perceive, interpret, and evaluate social behaviour as uncivil. These frameworks are grounded in schemata, which are internalised structures of knowledge and experience that guide individuals in interpreting behaviour. They help individuals anticipate how people *ought to act* in a given context, and when these expectations are breached, such behaviours may be perceived as uncivil or inappropriate. In this way, evaluations of incivility are closely tied to what Garfinkel (1967) refers to as the moral order, the background of shared “taken-for-granted” norms that underpin everyday interaction. When these norms are disrupted, participants draw upon both personal and culturally shaped frameworks to assess the severity and meaning of the act. Understanding incivility, thus, requires paying attention to the underlying social norms, cultural norms and expectations, and in some cases, moral norms, that shape how individuals judge certain behaviours as uncivil.

To sum up what has been discussed so far, incivility has been largely neglected within the (im)politeness field. Moreover, much of the existing literature on incivility has focused on organisational or institutional settings particularly workplaces (e.g., Andersson & Pearson, 1999; Cortina, 2008) and political discourse (e.g., Papacharissi, 2004; Muddiman, 2017). These studies have tended to prioritise either the identification and classification of uncivil behaviours or the analysis of their broader implications. What remains underexplored is how ordinary individuals outside of institutional frameworks make sense of and evaluate incivility in everyday contexts. Nonetheless, earlier studies that did address everyday incivility, such as Phillips and Smith (2006), tended to focus on classifying behaviours considered uncivil. More recent research, however, has begun to explore the evaluative nature of incivility, shifting attention towards how individuals justify their judgements about what counts as uncivil. Yet, this body of work has largely focused on morality anchored grounds and has been situated within Western contexts. Further research is needed to uncover the broader range of evaluative grounds that shape these judgements across cultural settings.

In response to these gaps, the present study investigates how incivility is evaluated within Omani society, an underrepresented context in (im)politeness research. It explores the broader evaluative grounds individuals draw upon, including sociocultural norms and context-specific expectations, when judging behaviour as uncivil. In order to do that, it draws on two different sources of data, X posts and personal diary reports, to capture how incivility is evaluated in public online discourse and

in private. By employing two forms of data collection, the study offers a multidimensional understanding of how incivility is perceived and evaluated in different contexts.

Building on the discussion of the key phenomena introduced in this chapter, taking offence and incivility, the following section presents the research questions and objectives that guide these investigations.

1.4 Research Questions and Objectives

The aim of this study is to uncover the sociocultural norms and expectations that shape how individuals in Omani society judge behaviour as offensive and uncivil. To achieve this aim, the study is guided by two research questions, each addressing one of the core phenomena introduced in this chapter. To address the two questions, the study draws on two sources of data for each research question: data from X and diary reports. This combination enables an exploration of both public expressions and private reflections, allowing for a richer understanding of the evaluative grounds underpinning offence and incivility in the Omani context. The following sections introduce each question along with its focus:

1.4.1 What causes the Omani people to take offence?

This question is addressed in chapters 4 and 5. The aim is to investigate incidents that lead individuals in Omani society to feel offended and to understand the underlying norms and expectations that shape such responses. Offence is approached as a socially and culturally informed judgement rooted in a shared understanding of what is considered acceptable (Culpeper, 2011). By exploring both public discourse and personal accounts, the research seeks to uncover the ways in which individuals draw on these shared expectations when interpreting and responding to potentially offensive acts. In doing so, it highlights the dynamic relationship between individual experience and broader social norms in constructing and expressing offence.

1.4.2 What norms govern perceptions of (in)civility in the Omani society?

This question is explored in Chapters 6 and 7. The aim is to understand the norms and expectations that individuals in Omani society draw upon when judging certain behaviour as uncivil. Incivility, in this study, is approached as a perceived transgression of sociocultural norms that govern appropriate conduct in public places, often marked by emotionally charged reactions. This definition builds on the view that incivility is a socially and culturally constructed evaluation, shaped by widely held beliefs about how people ought to behave in shared spaces (Locher & Watts, 2005; Kádár & Haugh, 2013). The study examines how people describe and interpret uncivil encounters, paying attention to how

these evaluations reflect collective understandings of public conduct. While individuals may differ in what they consider uncivil, their interpretations often draw on shared cultural standards that define acceptable behaviour within a given social setting (Spencer-Oatey, 2008). By analysing both digital expressions and lived experiences of incivility, this study sheds light on how certain norms are invoked, negotiated, and sometimes contested in everyday life, revealing the dynamic and context-sensitive nature of individuals' judgements.

1.5 Methodology

To address the two research questions, this study adopts a two-phase mixed methods design. Each phase investigates taking offence and incivility separately but in parallel, using the same methodological structure for both phenomena. Phase one starts with collecting naturally occurring data from X using a set of hashtags in Arabic language that are relevant for each phenomenon such as #مسيء (offensive) for taking offence, and #غير لائق (inappropriate) for incivility. It is then analysed first quantitatively and then qualitatively. In the quantitative analysis, the study uses corpus-based techniques to identify linguistic patterns and recurring themes, which then inform the qualitative thematic analysis. The thematic analysis in Phase one examines how the identified patterns are interpreted and evaluated within their specific social and cultural contexts. In preparation for Phase Two, the findings from Phase One play a crucial role in shaping the design of this phase, particularly by guiding the wording and sequencing of the diary questions, as well as the depth of responses sought.

In Phase Two, the study focuses on the lived experiences of Omanis by collecting qualitative data through diary reports. Participants are invited to recount situations in which they, or someone they know, felt offended or witnessed behaviour they perceived as uncivil. By incorporating this phase, this study extends the inquiry from public discourse into private accounts. The collected narratives are then analysed thematically to further explore the grounds that individuals draw upon when perceiving something as offensive or uncivil and how their evaluations reflect broader sociocultural norms within Omani society. A more detailed account of the research design, data collection procedures, and analytical approaches is provided in Chapter 3.

1.6 Thesis contribution

This thesis contributes to the field of (im)politeness studies by addressing two key phenomena: taking offence and incivility. While taking offence has received some attention within the field of (im)politeness, incivility remains comparatively underexplored in this field. In fact, it has been more extensively examined in disciplines such as sociology, political science, organisational psychology

and criminology. Thus, this research addresses a significant gap in the (im)politeness research by foregrounding incivility as a noteworthy phenomenon and a concept that deserves equal scholarly attention alongside other well-established concepts in the field, such as offence, aggression, and rudeness.

Moreover, a key contribution of this study is its departure from the recent trend in (im)politeness research, particularly the *moral turn*, by refocusing the analytical attention on sociocultural norms and expectations that participants draw upon when judging behaviour as offensive or uncivil. While this study does not deny the role of morality in shaping evaluative judgements, it situates morality within a broader sociocultural understanding that guides how individuals evaluate behaviour. This perspective highlights how judgements of offence and incivility are socially and culturally mediated, grounded in locally shared norms rather than higher-level moral norms.

Furthermore, this research contributes to (im)politeness research by investigating the two phenomena from a Middle Eastern perspective, specifically Omani society, a regional context that remains significantly underrepresented in (im)politeness research. By investigating how individuals in Oman interpret and evaluate offence and incivility, this study broadens existing findings and offers new culturally situated insights to (im)politeness research.

Methodologically, this study also contributes to (im)politeness research by building an integrated, two phases mixed- methods design that can serve as a model for future studies. By combining corpus analysis and thematic analysis within the same dataset in Phase One and complementing this with thematic analysis of diary reports in Phase Two, the study demonstrates a systematic approach that can be applied to investigate similar phenomena of an evaluative nature.

1.7 Structure of the Thesis

This thesis is structured into nine chapters, each contributing to a comprehensive examination of taking offence and incivility in Oman. The current chapter, Chapter 1, introduces the study by outlining its scope and focus. It presents the gaps of the current research and how these gaps will be addressed, followed by the research questions and objectives. Additionally, it provides an overview of the methodology and highlights the potential contributions of this research.

Chapter 2 reviews the key literature and concepts underpinning this study. It begins by tracing early ideas of proper conduct in various cultural and philosophical traditions and then moves to discussing how politeness has been theorised across different waves. The chapter then examines the concept of (im)politeness in relation to offence and incivility, followed by a discussion of norms. It concludes

with a review of existing studies on taking offence and incivility.

Chapter 3 presents the methodological framework of the study. It begins by restating the research questions and outlining the philosophical underpinnings of the research. The chapter then explains the use of an explanatory sequential mixed-methods approach, combining quantitative and qualitative methods across two phases. It highlights that Phase One involves both corpus-based and thematic analyses of social media data from X, while Phase Two focuses on qualitative diary reports that capture personal narratives of offence and incivility. The chapter also critically details the data collection methods and analysis procedures for each phase, including the use of Sketch Engine and NVivo. It also discusses the strategies employed to recruit participants. It also presents the theoretical framework that guided the thematic analysis and discusses the translation process and ethical considerations associated with collecting data.

Chapter 4 answers the first research question in this research: What causes Omani people to take offence? This chapter focuses on the findings from Phase One, which involves the analysis of naturally occurring data from X. The analysis in this chapter was conducted in two layers. The first layer employed quantitative corpus-based techniques using Sketch Engine to identify frequent lexical patterns, collocations, and n-grams in relation to the hashtag. The findings were then used to inform the second layer, which was a qualitative thematic analysis. This analysis explored the specific grounds that participants allude to when evaluating behaviour as offensive. This chapter then ends with a summary of the findings from the corpus analysis and thematic analysis.

Chapter 5 continues to answer the first research question by focusing on diary reports narratives. The findings are analysed thematically providing an insight into the grounds they allude to when evaluating something as offensive.

Chapter 6 addresses the second research question: What norms govern perceptions of (in)civility in Omani society? This chapter focuses on public evaluations of incivility as expressed in digital discourse on X. Following a similar two-layered approach to that used in Chapter 4, the analysis begins with a corpus-based analysis of lexical patterns, collocations, and frequently occurring references to behaviours perceived as uncivil. These trends are then explored through thematic analysis, revealing how users frame and interpret acts of incivility in an online context. Most importantly, it highlights the grounds that participants allude to legitimise their judgements.

Chapter 7 continues the exploration of the second research question by presenting findings from the diary report data that focus on incivility. These personal narratives provide insight into how individuals

in Omani society perceive, interpret uncivil behaviour in everyday contexts. Through thematic analysis, the chapter uncovers the sociocultural norms and expectations that were violated and the underlying grounds they allude to in order to legitimise their judgements.

Chapter 8 provides a comprehensive discussion of the key research findings by interpreting them in relation to previous literature.

Chapter 9 synthesises the key findings in relation to the two research questions. It then highlights how this study contributed to the field theoretically, empirically and methodologically. Finally, it highlights the limitations of the study and provides recommendations for future research.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

This chapter reviews the key theoretical and empirical literature and concepts that inform the present study. It begins with a historical overview (Section 2.2), tracing early ideas of proper conduct in ancient China, Greece, and Renaissance Europe. Section 2.3 then outlines earlier theories and key developments in (im)politeness research, including the shift from traditional models to discursive and post-discursive approaches. Section 2.4, then connects (im)politeness to taking offence and incivility. Sections 2.5 to 2.7 then explore the role of norms and review empirical studies on offence and incivility.

2.2 Tracing Cultural and Philosophical views of Proper Conduct

The interest in appropriate conduct has long been embedded in sociocultural and philosophical discussions of social behaviour, dating back to ancient civilizations such as those in Ancient Egypt, Greece, and China, which existed more than 2,500 years ago (Terkourafi, 2011; Pan & Kadar, 2011). Although the specific terminology varied across these cultures, the idea of behaving in ways deemed ‘proper’ or ‘appropriate’ permeated their social systems, expressed through concepts that captured the essence of expected social conduct.

In ancient China, the concept of ‘*Li*’ or “ritual propriety”, outlined by Confucius, provided a comprehensive framework for behaviour that spanned both grand ceremonies and daily interactions. Described as “patterns of ritualised, ceremonially proper conduct for various social roles in different social situations, ranging from mundane everyday contexts... to major events” (Fraser, 2023, p100), *Li* encapsulated a broad spectrum of rituals. These rituals, also referred to as norms of propriety and duty, specify what should be done and how it should be carried out, including the manner of speech, dress, facial expression, gesture, and posture. They included both clearly defined rules and more nuanced, unwritten expectations that subtly guided interpersonal dynamics. For example, formal rituals might dictate specific ceremonial actions, while informal norms shape routine social interactions, such as personal space management in public settings. This system of norms served to place “measures and bounds” on individuals’ conduct based on their role in society (Yan, 2019, p. 78), thereby aiming to prevent conflicts among people. If everyone adheres to the norms of propriety and duty associated with their place in society, i.e. collective conformity, a sustainable balance is achieved. While ancient China emphasized *Li* as a framework for societal harmony, Ancient Greece

also developed its own distinct concept. The Greeks valued 'sophrosyne,' a concept that describes a sound mind and an excellent character, a combination of self-control and temperance (Rademaker, 2017). Philosophers like Socrates and Plato emphasised sophrosyne as a foundational element of the individual and, by extension, a harmonious society as noted by Annas (2013).

As time progressed, concepts related to 'proper' behaviour continued to evolve and took on new meanings in different cultural contexts. During the Renaissance in Europe, these evolving norms became closely linked with civility, a term that encapsulated the refined behaviour and manners expected in both courtly and urban life. The term 'civility' was used to characterise the behaviours and manners typical of a refined society during the Renaissance; it represented a mode of demonstrating one's social refinement and commitment to the emerging codes of conduct that defined that era. Furthermore, civility served as a crucial marker of social distinction, delineating between different social classes and groups. This distinction was evident not only in public behaviour, but also in private life highlighting the comprehensive influence of civility (Elias, Jephcott, Dunning, Goudsblom, and Mennell, 2000).

As the sixteenth century unfolded, these established notions of civility became more pronounced. This era was marked by a more rigid social hierarchy, partly due to the emergence of a new aristocracy and an increasingly diverse upper class. This diversification intensified the need for unified behavioural norms as a means of affirming one's social status and navigating the complexities of this evolving landscape. During this period, the publication of etiquette books and manuals saw a rise, such as *The Book of the Courtier* (Castiglione, 1528), and *The Rules of Polite Behaviour* (Casa, 1558). According to Elias et al "the code of behaviour became stricter, and the degree of consideration expected of others became greater. The sense of what to do and what not to do in order not to offend or shock others became more binding" (2000, p.69). Consequently, proper behaviour' transitioned from being merely about personal virtue to becoming essential for maintaining one's social standing. These books quickly became indispensable references for anyone aspiring to secure or elevate their status within society, marking the onset of the formal study of etiquette that has continued to evolve through the centuries.

However, these books and manuals neglected the everyday manners and norms of the broader population, it only emphasised norms that underpinned aristocratic life, thereby sidelining the everyday practices and manners of the broader population. The focus was so narrow that it offered little insight into the social conduct of the lower classes, who undoubtedly maintained their own sets of norms and behaviours. This oversight not only underscores a historical bias towards the affluent

but also highlights a significant gap in our understanding of past social norms across all levels of society, as these accounts fail to capture the full spectrum of societal interactions (Elias et al, 2000). Although concerns with appropriate conduct have long existed and have been discussed in social and philosophical thought, it was only in the twentieth century that such concerns began to be examined systematically through the lens of language and interaction (Culpeper et al., 2017). The following section explores this shift towards theorising (im)politeness.

2.3 Theorising politeness

The twentieth century marked the emergence of politeness as a focus of systematic inquiry. Scholars began to examine how it is constructed, negotiated, and interpreted in context, paving the way for a more dynamic understanding of social interaction. This development aligned with a broader disciplinary shift toward studying language in its social context, and by the mid-twentieth century, as sociolinguistics emerged as a distinct field, politeness came to be examined not only as a matter of linguistic form (e.g., honorifics, indirectness) but as a way of negotiating relationships, managing face, and navigating power dynamics. A key figure in this shift was Goffman (1967), whose framework of *facework* laid the conceptual foundation for later theories of politeness by highlighting the interpersonal dynamics involved in the management of face during social interaction. Central to this framework is the concept of face, which he defines as “the positive social value a person effectively claims for himself by the line others assume he has taken during a particular contact (p.213). In other words, it is the image individuals present to others and wish to have accepted and upheld in interaction. When an individual projects a particular self-image in social situations, they also feel a strong need to maintain and live up to that image (Treviño, 2003). Goffman’s work emphasised that much of everyday interaction involves efforts to preserve both one’s own face and that of others.

Building on Goffman’s sociological conception of face (1967), Brown and Levinson (1978, 1987) developed a systematic theory of politeness by extending the concept of face into a model of linguistic interaction. They redefined the concept of face as “the want to be unimpeded and the want to be approved of in certain respects” (p.63), distinguishing between negative face, the desire for autonomy and freedom from imposition, and positive face, the desire to be liked, appreciated, and approved of by others. Brown and Levinson’s (1978, 1987) argued that these two face needs are universal aspects of human interaction that shape how people manage communication across different social and cultural contexts. Their model also takes a speaker- oriented perspective, assuming that speakers strategically manage face-threatening acts by selecting from four politeness strategies based on their assessment of power, distance, and imposition.

While Brown and Levinson's (1978, 1987) politeness theory has been highly influential, it has also faced growing criticism in the decades that followed, particularly for its limited cross-cultural applicability. Matsumoto (1988) and Gu (1990), for example, argued that their model centres around the individuals' face needs and thus is more suited to individualistic cultures, such as those found in many Western societies, where personal goals, self-expression, and independence are prioritised (Hofstede, 2001; Triandis, 1995; Ting-Toomey, 2005, 2017). In such contexts, negative face, the desire for freedom from imposition, is often central to communication (Brown and Levinson, 1978, 1987). In contrast, in collectivist cultures, such as those in East Asian and Middle Eastern countries, group needs take precedence over individual needs and maintaining interpersonal relationships and fulfilling social obligations are often more important than asserting personal autonomy or individual face (Ting-Toomey, 1994 & Al Zidjaly, 2012). Additionally, critics have pointed out that their framework overlooks relational or interpersonal aspects of the face often referred to as face concerns which are especially salient in some cultures (Mao, 1994; Haugh, 2007).

Moreover, a number of scholars have identified further conceptual limitations in Brown and Levinson's model. They argue that their approach to face is overly individualistic and overlooks its relational nature (Bargiela-Chiappini, 2003, 2006; Haugh, 2005a; Ide, 1989; Lim, 2004; Mao, 1994; Matsumoto, 1988). Building on this relational view, Locher and Watts (2005) and Haugh (2007) argue that politeness is not something performed solely by the speaker but jointly constructed and interpreted in context. As a result, Brown and Levinson's (1978, 1987) model may not fully capture the diverse ways in which politeness is conceptualised and negotiated in interaction. These critiques subsequently led scholars to reconceptualise politeness as a more relational and interactionally grounded phenomenon, a shift explored further in the following section:

2.3.1 The Discursive approach to (Im)politeness

In response to the limitations of Brown and Levinson's model (1978, 1987), a speaker-oriented and strategy-based model, the discursive approach to politeness emerged as a significant shift in how politeness is conceptualised and studied. It moves away from predefined politeness strategies and universality. Instead, it reconceptualises politeness as a relational and context-sensitive phenomenon that emerges from participants' situated evaluations of communicative behaviour, emphasising a bottom-up, first-order perspective that prioritises how politeness is understood, negotiated, and talked about by lay interactants, rather than imposed through universal or analyst-driven frameworks (Eelen, 2001; Mill, 2003; Watts 2003; Locher & Watts, 2005).

Eelen's (2001) critique of Politeness Theories marked a turning point in politeness research (Mills,

2011). Although Eelen (2001) did not propose a new theory of politeness but instead offered a self-reflexive critique of previous models that encouraged researchers to go beyond Brown and Levinson's theory. By highlighting issues and unanswered questions that persisted as long as traditional models were repeated without change, his work opened the way for more critical and reflective approaches to politeness.

Eelen (2001) argued that traditional politeness theories were overly normative and analyst-driven, often imposing external judgements on what counts as polite or impolite. He pointed to the gap between theoretical models of politeness and everyday understandings of politeness by language users, laying the foundation for a more participant-focused approach centered on how politeness is experienced and evaluated in actual interaction. In this context, he called for a clear distinction between politeness¹, participants' own understanding of what constitutes polite behaviour, and politeness², theorists' analytical and academic conceptualisation of politeness. He argued that in practice, analysts frequently risked mixing the two perspectives within their analyses.

Following Eelen's (2001) argument, Watts (2003) argues that a theory of politeness must be able to "locate possible realisations of polite or impolite behaviour and offer a way of assessing how members themselves may have evaluated that behaviour" (pp.19-20). This position challenges the premise, central to Brown and Levinson's framework, that politeness can be identified through predetermined linguistic strategies. For Watts, the key task for researchers is not to ascribe politeness to linguistic forms but to understand how participants interpret and evaluate behaviour as (im)polite within situated interaction. To support his view, Watts draws on Sperber and Wilson's (1995) Relevance theory to develop a form of analysis which sees politeness as something worked out by the participants in context. He emphasises that evaluation of politeness is not encoded in linguistic forms but is inferred from participants as interactions unfold. This focus on participants' interpretive work led Watts and Locher (2005) to distinguish between first-order (im)politeness and second-order (im) politeness. First-order politeness refers to the everyday, common-sense understanding of what counts as polite within a community; second-order politeness is the theoretical construct used by researchers. They argue that politeness research should prioritise first-order evaluations, making participants' metapragmatic assessments the basis of analysis. The distinction, however, has been widely debated. Haugh (2007), for instance, questions whether analysts can fully avoid imposing their own judgements.

Alongside the distinction, Locher and Watts (2005, 2008) propose the broader concept of relational work, which refers to the ongoing negotiation of social relations during communication through

language. It encompasses a continuum of behaviours “from direct, impolite, rude, aggressive interaction to polite interaction, encompassing both appropriate and inappropriate forms of social behaviour” (Locher and Watts, 2005 p.95). They argue that evaluation of such behaviour depends on how it aligns with or deviates from the norms and expectations that individuals have developed and internalised through categorising their own past experiences in similar past situations, as well as through inferences drawn from the experiences of others (LPRG, 2011).

While Locher and Watts (2005, 2008) offer a broad discursive perspective on relational work, Spencer-Oatey (2000, 2008) contributes to this relational turn in politeness theory by proposing a more systematic and multi-dimensional account of how interpersonal relationships are managed in communication. Although her Rapport Management framework is not situated strictly within the discursive tradition, it shares with it a central concern for the contextual and evaluative nature of communicative behaviour. A key strength of Spencer-Oatey’s model lies in its delineation of three interrelated dimensions that collectively shape interpersonal rapport: the management of face, sociality rights and obligations, and interactional goals (Spencer-Oatey, 2008). Rather than treating these as isolated elements, the framework highlights their interdependence in shaping how relational meaning is constructed and interpreted in context. Moreover, her conceptualisation of face, unlike that of Brown and Levinson (1987), is not limited to the individual self. Spencer-Oatey (2007, 2008) broadens the concept to account for the self as an individual, as relationally positioned in interaction with others, and as a member of groups. This tripartite view allows for a more nuanced understanding of identity concerns in interaction, recognising that face may be tied not only to personal attributes such as competence or autonomy, but also to one’s role in a relationship and one’s status within a collective. As such, face becomes a socially embedded construct, shaped by cultural norms and interpersonal dynamics, rather than a static, universally defined notion. This expanded definition allows for a better understanding of how face is negotiated across diverse interactional settings. In this study, the rapport management framework is drawn upon to aid in understanding the evaluative grounds individuals invoke when judging an act as uncivil or offensive, particularly through examining how face concerns and sociality rights and obligations inform their judgement. Further details on the application of this framework are provided in Section 3.7 of the methodology chapter.

Another important contribution to the discursive approach comes from Mills (2003), who also frames politeness as something evaluated by participants rather than encoded in linguistic forms. She proposes a community of practice (CoP) framework for examining people’s social behaviour. She argues that “communities of practice rather than individuals negotiate and arbitrate over whether speech acts are considered polite or impolite”, noting that while gendered stereotypes may influence

these judgements, individuals can still “use such stereotypes strategically to their own advantage” (Mills, 2002, p.1). She further maintains that politeness should be analysed at discourse level rather than at the level of isolated utterances. It is important to note that Mills view of CoP is based on Wenger’s (1998) social perspective who maintains that “a community of practice consists of a loosely defined group of people who are mutually engaged in a particular task and who have a shared repertoire of negotiable resources accumulated over time (Wenger, 1998, cited in Mills, p.30). This grounding is significant because it positions politeness as socially learned and collectively negotiated practice. In other words, what counts as polite or impolite emerges from shared histories, expectations, and norms within a community.

Having discussed some of the main scholars that contributed to the development of the discursive approach, namely Eelen (2001), Watts (2003), Locher and Watts (2005, 2008), Spencer-Oatey 2008, and Mills (2003), and outlined their respective views, it is now time to consider some of key limitations that have been raised in relation to this approach. One of the limitations of the discursive approach is its lack of theoretical grounding. To explain, it does not propose a coherent framework for what constitutes impoliteness beyond the fact that it is recognised as such by interactants at the moment of interaction. In this regard, Culpeper (2011) maintains that without engagement with higher-order abstractions, discursive studies can result in fragmented accounts that lack explanatory scope beyond the immediate context of talk-in-interaction, making the approach analytically unstable and difficult to generalise. Moreover, a related concern raised by Haugh (2007) is that by highlighting that only participants’ evaluations count and excluding the role of analyst, the discursive approach risks blurring the boundary between participant and analyst perspective. Additionally, this leaves the analyst with very limited scope to offer interpretation or explanation, and makes it unclear who is actually establishing that an evaluation of impoliteness has occurred. A further limitation of the discursive approach concerns how it deals with social norms. To explain, norms are central to understanding how people judge behaviour as polite or impolite in interaction, yet the discursive approach does not provide a systematic method for determining where these norms come from, how they operate, how they are invoked by participants, or how they can be analytically captured or compared across contexts (Haugh, 2007).

To sum up, the discursive approach’s strength lies in its sensitivity to participants’ evaluative judgements, capturing how they interpret, negotiate and respond to perceived impoliteness within specific interactional contexts. Nonetheless, this very strength becomes a weakness when the approach fails to offer a clear conceptual structure. While it shows how people negotiate impoliteness in context, it does not adequately theorise what impoliteness is, or how it can be systematically

identified. As a result, several scholars have called for more integrated models that combine discursive sensitivity with theoretical rigor, allowing researchers to remain context-aware without sacrificing analytical clarity (Culpeper, 2011; Haugh, 2013).

2.3.2 Third- wave (Im)politeness research

In response to the previous limitations, a more recent line of research is commonly referred to as third-wave politeness or a post-discursive approach has developed, it refers to those who have moved beyond the discursive view. This approach emerged as a more integrative framework that bridges the gap between participants' perspectives and the theoretical grounding. Scholars such as Culpeper (2007, 2008, 2013), Haugh (2007, 2008, 2013, 2023, 2024), and Kádár and Haugh (2013) have been instrumental in shaping this movement and their ideas provide key conceptual resources for the analytical approach adopted in this study. Given the scope of the present study, it is not possible to review all post-discursive developments in detail. The discussion therefore concentrates on strands of work most relevant to the aims of this research.

Within this paradigm, Haugh's (2013) work offers a significant theoretical advancement by conceptualising (im)politeness as "social practices that are occasioned through particular social actions and pragmatic meanings in situated, talk-in-interaction" (p.24). Haugh emphasises that evaluations of (im)politeness are not simply interpretive responses but should be understood as social practices embedded within a broader moral order. To explain, he argues that people do not judge something as polite, impolite or even offensive, or uncivil based on what was said, the linguistic form of the act, or even what was done, the behaviour itself. Instead, the judgement stems from the social action, that is, what participants perceive the speaker to be doing through their words and embodied conduct, and the meaning that is interpreted as arising from the interaction. Haugh maintains that such evaluations are rooted in a broader moral order, which Davis defines as "any system of obligations that defines and organises the proper-good, right, virtuous- relations among individuals and groups in a community" (2008, p.204). It is one that is often "taken for granted" (Kádár & Haugh, p.13) and built upon the "familiar scenes of everyday affairs" (Garfinkel, 1967, p. 35). The moral order functions as a shared framework through which participants make sense of others' behaviour and evaluate it as appropriate, inappropriate, polite, impolite or offensive. Nonetheless, as Haugh (2013, p.57) points out, the moral order is "multi-faceted and multi-layered", meaning it does not operate as a single fixed set of rules. Thus, as Haugh (2013, p.59) maintains, "members who identify with different groups, or even members who identify with the same group, do

not necessarily always constitute the moral order in the same way”. This variability means that the evaluations of taking offence or incivility are not fixed or universally agreed upon but are shaped by participants’ interpretations of what they perceive to be at stake in a given moment. Thus, what one individual may view as offensive or inappropriate may be considered acceptable or unproblematic by another, depending on how each individual orients to the moral order in that specific context. In this sense, the moral order does not function as a static background for interpretation, but is actively drawn upon, negotiated and at times contested through interaction.

In contrast to earlier perspectives on politeness, whether traditional or discursive approaches, which tend to prioritise either the speaker or the hearer, the perspective of (im)politeness as a social practice does not limit itself to the evaluation of one party. Instead, it encompasses the judgements made by all participants involved in a given interaction, as well as any potential meta-participant as shown in Kádár and Haugh (2013) and Haugh (2024). Haugh (2013) argues that understanding impoliteness requires more careful theorisation of the notion of the participant. He emphasises that analysts must avoid presenting their own interpretations as if they were the participants and must remain attentive to the multiple footings from which participants themselves evaluate behaviour. For Haugh, these footings are instantiated through the moment-by-moment participation order and tracing them enables the analyst to avoid confounding their own footing as a meta-recipient with the evaluative positions adopted by participants.

Central to Kádár and Haugh’s (2013) and Haugh’s (2024) perspective is the view that understanding (Im)politeness requires drawing on multiple loci of understanding rather than relying on a single lens. To account for this plurality, Haugh (2024) proposes a prismatic model of (im)politeness, which extends beyond the traditional first-order and second-order distinction. The model identifies four loci through which understanding can be rotated or foregrounded depending on the analytic stance adopted.¹ These loci include the emic/etic perspective, participant/ multiparticipant perspective, analyst/ lay observer, and folk theoretical/ scientific. Each of these loci offers a distinctive point of insight on how evaluation of impoliteness arises (Haugh, 2024). While not all loci are relevant in every instance, they can overlap depending on the nature of interaction and the research question being asked. Consequently, the analyst task is not to select one correct perspective but to recognise how multiple understandings may co-exist, intersect or become foregrounded in particular moments. This theoretical perspective is particularly valuable for the present study, which explores the grounds that

¹ An explanation of their role and relevance to the present study is provided in the methodology chapter, Section 3.8.

participants allude to when making judgements about what they consider offensive and uncivil.

2.4 (Im)politeness in relation to taking offence and incivility.

(Im)politeness plays a central role in understanding the phenomena of taking offence and incivility. In this study, impoliteness is conceptualised as “an umbrella term” (Spencer-Oatey, 2005, p.97) that offers a theoretical foundation for exploring how individuals perceive and evaluate behaviour that is seen to violate social norms and expectations (Culpeper, 2011; Mills, 2003; Sifianou, 2019). Both taking offence and incivility are fundamentally subjective phenomena that share an evaluative core: each arises when behaviour is perceived to be out of alignment with what is expected or considered acceptable in a particular context (Locher & Watts, 2005; Culpeper et al., 2017). Although they may involve different kinds of perceived norm violations, with offense often, but not necessarily, arising in response to interpersonal transgressions (Tayebi, 2016), and incivility commonly linked to inappropriate conduct in public or shared spaces, both are shaped by individuals’ judgements of what they consider acceptable (Locher & Watts, 2005; Culpeper et al., 2017). These judgements are grounded in what Haugh (2013) describes as the moral order as explained earlier. This moral order plays a key role in determining whether behaviour is interpreted as offensive, or uncivil, and underpins the evaluative judgement involved in both taking offence and incivility.

This view aligns with Culpeper’s (2011, p. 24) definition of impoliteness as “a negative attitude towards specific behaviour occurring in a specific context”. This definition captures the evaluative and context-sensitive nature of impoliteness, emphasising that it is not an inherent property of a behaviour but a judgement made by individuals based on their expectations. As Culpeper et al. (2017) explain, behaviours are considered “impolite when they conflict with how one expects them to be, how one wants them to be, and/ or how one thinks they ought to be” (p.204). This emphasis on expectations, context, and judgement provides a useful lens for understanding how participants in this study interpret and respond to both offence and incivility.

By considering (im)politeness as the overarching concept, this study examines how people interpret both offensive and uncivil behaviour through the lens of perceived norms and expectation violations. In the case of taking offence, it is maintained that offence involves an affective stance, expressed through emotional reactions such as anger, or hurt, annoyance, and may also involve a moral stance, whereby the individual grounds their moral claim (Haugh, 2015). However, not all responses necessarily involve a moral stance; some may remain at the level of emotional discomfort i.e. negative emotions without progressing to sanctioning. This includes drawing on various sociocultural norms and expectations (Tayebi, 2016) in order to justify and legitimise one’s evaluative claims (Haugh,

2015). While Haugh's (2015) model of registering and sanctioning offence specifically outlines these stances in the context of taking offence, this distinction is also relevant to responses to incivility. Incivility, too, can evoke affective reactions such as irritation, disappointment, or frustration, and may similarly lead to moral judgements when behaviour is perceived to breach what is considered acceptable in public places.

2.5 Norms

In this study, norms are understood as the shared sociocultural standards that give rise to the expectations people rely on when evaluating behaviour as offensive or uncivil. In this study, norms are treated as active, socially constructed frameworks through which behaviour is judged as uncivil or offensive. This understanding aligns with a long standing view in (im)politeness studies that judging a person or their behaviour as polite or impolite is not intrinsic to the act itself, but rather a normative assessment grounded in socially shared expectations about what is fitting in a given context (Locher and Watts, 2005; Culpeper, 2011, Culpeper & Haugh, 2021).

Evaluating behaviour as offensive or uncivil therefore involves making a normative judgement. Such judgements may be grounded in perceived breaches of what people *ought to do* that may be grounded known as moral or injunctive norms, or in deviations from what people typically do in a given context known as descriptive norms (Cialdini, Kallgren and Reno, 1991; Lapinski and Rimal, 2005; Kallgren, Reno and Cialdini, 2000). While breaches of injunctive norms are more likely to trigger a valenced negative judgement, breaches of descriptive norms tend to be perceived as surprising rather than problematic (Burgoon and Ebesu-Hubbard, 2005; Spencer-Oatey and Kádár, 2021).

Injunctive norms operate through evaluative tendencies that arise when individuals reflect on what ought to have been done in a particular situation. As Kádár (2020) explains that injunctive norms are inherently abstract, and they only become visible when a breach prompts people to signal how things ought to be. These evaluations draw on the moral order, the shared sense of what counts as appropriate or acceptable in that situation. Thus, the presence of an injunctive norm can be pragmatically identified when it is "talked into being" through recurrent patterns of morally loaded disapproval that follow a perceived instance of inappropriateness (p.2). These post-incident reactions, what Kádár terms meta-reflective evaluation, highlight the injunctive norms at play. Nonetheless, people may evaluate the same incident differently, as they each draw on and prioritise different elements of the moral order when making their judgements. Accordingly, within this study evaluation of offence and incivility are viewed as responses to perceived violations of injunctive

norms that underpin the moral order of everyday life in Oman. The emphasis is therefore placed on injunctive norms, what is ought to rather than descriptive norms, which capture what people typically do and are therefore of secondary importance in sensitive evaluative contexts. Having said that, descriptive norms can still play a role in shaping the moral order; to explain, when certain behavioural patterns are repeated frequently enough, descriptive norms may gradually acquire social or moral significance, eventually giving rise to expectations about what people *ought* to do (Culpeper, 2011a; Spencer-Oatey and Kádár, 2021; Terkourafi, 2005a). As Terkourafi (2019) points out “ what is frequent to our experience is automatically positively evaluated simply because that’s the way we’ve always done it and seen it done and it didn’t occur to do it in any other way” (p.12). She further explains that early exposure to conventionalised behaviour shapes our sense of what is normal, making any deviation from it feel less natural and worthy of attention. This experiential familiarity, in turn, can contribute to the emergence of injunctive norms.

This point is reinforced by Spencer-Oatey and Kádár (2021), Spencer-Oatey (2008b), and Culpeper (2011a) who argue that when certain behaviour happens often enough a descriptive norm may gradually evolve into an injunctive norm, as repeated patterns of behaviour begin to carry expectations of what ought to be done. This gradual shift from what is frequent to what is expected illustrates how behavioural regularities (Burgoon and Ebesu, 2005), can become part of the moral order. That is, behaviours that are repeatedly observed may no longer be seen as merely typical; instead, they come to represent what is understood as proper, right or expected within a given context. In this way, the deviation is not simply noticed as uncommon but interpreted as a breach of shared norms and may elicit social judgement, that is an evaluative assessment.

However, not all norm violations trigger evaluation. As Spencer-Oatey and Kádár (2021) argue, individuals operate within subjective “normalcy zones” that is context-specific ranges of behaviour they perceive as acceptable (p.118). It is only when individuals perceive that these thresholds have been crossed and that the conduct falls outside the acceptability zone, that evaluative processes are likely to be triggered. Minor deviations, by contrast, often go unnoticed or are dismissed as insignificant. This reinforces the idea that (im)politeness evaluations, and by extension offence and incivility, are highly context-dependent and subjectively experienced. This is particularly relevant to the present study, which explores how individuals in Omani society judge certain behaviours as offensive or uncivil. Such judgements are not triggered by every instance of norm violation but tend to arise when certain behaviour is perceived to cross a threshold of propriety, one shaped by a localised understanding of what is acceptable, and morally binding.

The following sections examine each of these phenomena in turn. They begin with a review of recent studies on taking offence and followed in Section 2.7 by a critical exploration of incivility through a cross-disciplinary lens, drawing on insights from organisational psychology, political science, criminology, urban sociology, and a limited number of studies within (im)politeness studies.

2.6 Studies On Taking offence

The notion of offence is a relatively recent addition to the field of (im)politeness and has not yet received much attention. While the majority of existing studies have focused on the act of causing offence, particularly examining the linguistic strategies that speakers use to *cause offence* and the intentions behind their acts (Culpeper, 1996), the notion of taking offence, that how the hearers perceive and evaluate certain behaviour as offensive, has been comparatively underexplored. Nevertheless, a growing body of research has begun to shift this focus, placing greater emphasis on the hearer's perspective. This shift has paved the way for a deeper investigation into how offence is perceived and how it is evaluated in context.

Culpeper et al. (2011), drew on Spencer-Oatey's (2005) rapport management framework to examine the perceptions of (im)politeness in social interactions reported by university students across England, China, Finland, Germany, and Turkey. Their study quantified the loci on which participants based their evaluations, identifying breaches of quality face, equity rights and association rights as the most frequently cited grounds. However, although they compared the distribution of these loci across different countries, they did not engage in a detailed analysis of culturally specific interpretations or the variations in the perception of offence within these loci. Moreover, in their data collection, participants were explicitly instructed to narrate incidents involving something that was said to them, thus limiting the scope of the study to verbal interaction and excluding non-verbal behaviour, even though taking offence is not confined to spoken language alone. Nonetheless, this study provides an important foundation for understanding the evaluative dimensions of offence by showing the interpersonal concerns that people draw on when making judgements.

Haugh's (2015) seminal work offers an important contribution to the study of taking offence by examining how speakers of American and Australian English navigate moments of potential offence in initial interactions. Drawing on naturally occurring conversational data, Haugh examines how participants respond to possible transgression as a social action embedded within the interaction flow. His analysis included cases where individuals withheld expressing that they had taken offence as well as cases where offence was explicitly signalled through pauses, hesitation, or subtle shifts in tone without being explicitly verbalised. Haugh argues that taking offence is a pragmatic act shaped

by both the affordances and constraints of the interaction. To explain, in initial interaction, for instance, there is often a preference for maintaining agreeability, thus people tend to avoid confrontational or disruptive behaviour such as openly expressing that someone has taken offence. As he noted, “pointing out someone’s transgression or impropriety could itself be constructed as impolite” (p.56). Thus, while the opportunity to take offence may be present, individuals may carefully assess whether or not to express it based on the dynamics of the interaction.

Another study done by Taybei (2016) explores the expectations underlying people’s evaluation of an act as offensive in the Persian language, and the various social and cultural factors that inform these expectations. The analysis of the data showed that participants feel offended when their “interpersonal, deference, reciprocity or ritual based expectations” are broken (p.4). She also reported that not all members of the community share the same expectations, and she supported her argument by referring to cognitive and relational bases of expectations. To explain, cognitively, individuals form expectations based on the past experiences they have internalised. Relationally, expectations are shaped by the specific interpersonal histories between individuals, meaning that offense may be taken differently depending on the relationship’s context and history (Locher and Watts, 2008). As expectations and norms vary in different languages and cultures, further research is required to investigate this phenomenon.

Moreover, in a recent study by Parvaresh & Tayebi (2020), the authors attempt to explain how and why the hearer assigns offensive meaning to an utterance. They aim to elucidate the pragmatic processes at play when the hearer either assigns a particularly impolite or offensive meaning to an utterance during an interaction or adjusts the interpretation of the entire interaction in ways that are not necessarily intended by the speaker. Based on the analysis of the data taken from a reality TV show and a movie, the study found that the hearer frequently engages in an active evaluation process, a top- down process, where they assign offensive or impolite meaning to utterances beyond the immediate linguistic content. The analysis also suggested that the hearer engages in a predominantly top-down process of meaning making where they impose their own interpretation on the interaction, often overriding the immediate contextual information. While these study insights are valuable, the reliance on the data from TV shows and movies means that they may not capture everyday natural interactions, as these media often involve scripted or exaggerated behaviour.

In another recent study Zhao and Ran (2022) investigated how offence is taken and rationalised by third parties drawing on data from the mediation of conflicts between mothers-in-law and daughters

in law. Specifically, they explore how mediators justify impoliteness when daughters in law take offence at their mother-in-law's impolite behaviour. The analysis of the mediation discourse reveals that the mediator frequently uses "vicarious accounts" in their efforts to resolve conflicts, allowing them to minimise the accountability of mothers-in-law for their offensive actions. The mediators' justification of mothers-in-law's behaviour is influenced by two culture-specific moral principles in Chinese society namely filial piety" and "harmony is paramount" (p.76). The former emphasises the subordination, respect and care the younger generation owes to their elders, while the latter refers to preserving harmony, as it is seen as a key to success and fulfilment. Therefore, the mediators' rationalisation of offensive behaviour through these moral codes suggests that offensive acts are not just viewed through the lens of the individuals who have taken offence, but are filtered through broader social expectations and moral obligations. The mediators in these contexts serve to maintain social stability even if it involves downplaying or justifying offensive acts. This sheds light on how impoliteness is managed not just through direct interactions between the person who caused the offence and the person who has taken offence, but also through the intervention of others who help to interpret and rationalise the offence within a broader cultural framework.

2.7 Studies on Incivility

As outlined in the introduction chapter (see Chapter 1, section 1.2), incivility has received growing attention in fields such as political science, organisational psychology, and sociology. However, within (im)politeness research, its treatment remains limited and often under-theorised (Sifianou, 2019). To develop a more comprehensive understanding of incivility, impoliteness studies can benefit from engaging with cross-disciplinary research, where the concept has been more extensively theorised and empirically examined. However, such engagement requires a critical approach, as each discipline conceptualises incivility through the lens of its own priorities in their field. In what follows, I examine several seminal works from these disciplines and identify the common insights among them, particularly those related to how incivility is evaluated, understood and framed that can inform the study of incivility in this research.

The concept of incivility carries a wide range of meanings across academic fields, encompassing everything from minor breaches of etiquette to professional misconduct, civil unrest, and even concerns about the erosion of moral values (e.g., Carter, 1998; Johnson, 1988; Roberts, 1985). While the Oxford English Dictionary defines incivility as "rude, uncivil, or uncourteous behaviour towards others; want of civility or politeness; discourtesy, rudeness, and uncivil as "not civil or courteous, impolite; rough or lacking manners", these definitions suggest that incivility implies rudeness and disregard for others in violation of norms for respect in interpersonal relations (Brown & Levinson,

1987; Morris, 1996). In criminology literature, incivility has been described as “ low-level breaches of community standards that signal an erosion of conventionally accepted norms and values” (LaGrange, Ferraro, and Supancic, 1992), often manifested in physical signs such as graffiti, vandalism, and deteriorating buildings, as well as in social behaviours like antisocial conduct and begging (LaGrange et al., 1992; Perkins, Meeks & Taylor, 1992). Their interest in incivility has largely been shaped by its perceived link to crime and the potential escalation of criminal activity. These studies typically categorise incivility into “physical incivility” involving visible signs of disorder in the environment (e.g., littering, vandalism), and “social incivility”, referring to behaviours deemed threatening or undesirable in public spaces, such as loitering, public intoxication, or verbal altercations (Sampson & Raudenbush, 1999). However, as Phillips and Smith (2006) point out, this approach often targets specific social groups, particularly young people, marginalised communities, and minorities, who are more likely to be associated with these acts. Second, it tends to treat incivility as a decontextualised, observable condition, overlooking how judgements of incivility are socially constructed. Finally, criminological models frequently ignore interpersonal incivilities that emerge in routine face-to-face interactions, moments that while not illegal, may still deeply disrupt individuals’ experience of public life.

A different approach can be seen in organisational psychology, one of the most influential strands of incivility research, where Andersson and Pearson’s (1999) seminal work defines incivility in relation to workplace norms. They define it as “ low-intensity deviant workplace behaviour with an ambiguous intent to harm the target, in violation of workplace for mutual respect,... it is characteristically rude and discourteous, displaying a lack of regard for others” (p. 457). Their definition highlights several characteristics. First, it is proposed to be ambiguous in its intent to harm meaning it is often unclear to those involved whether the act was deliberate. This focus on ambiguity of intent contrasts with second-wave (im)politeness approaches (e.g., Culpeper, 2011; Locher & Watts, 2005), which move beyond the intention of the speaker and instead emphasise how behaviour is interpreted by the recipient. Secondly, incivility is theorised to cause harm to the recipient because uncivil behaviour conveys a lack of concern for others, leading to negative emotions. Third, uncivil behaviour is considered to be deviant in that it violates norms of respect and courtesy in organisations. To account for how such exchanges unfold, Andersson and Pearson (1999) adopt a social interactionist perspective, emphasising the interpersonal and situational dynamics that shape uncivil interactions. In this view, the uncivil act is not viewed as an isolated event but as an ongoing process shaped by contextual constraints such as power relations, prior interactions, and workplace-specific norms of respect. They observe that the starting point of incivility often lies in the perception that a norm has

been violated, which gives rise to negative feelings specifically a sense of injustice that might escalate the interaction into a cycle of uncivil behaviours. Their work provides valuable insights for this study by identifying key elements of incivility: perceived norm violations, the emotional responses they evoke such as a sense of injustice and its processual nature, whereby incivility unfolds through ongoing interaction rather than as a discrete event. However, their framework places a heavy emphasis on a singular normative foundation mutual respect norm, which while relevant, risks oversimplifying the complexity of normative expectations even within workplace settings. Moreover, it offers limited engagement with the interpretive processes through which individuals evaluate behaviour, especially in relation to the culturally and socially embedded norms that vary across contexts and shape perceptions of incivility.

Moving from workplace incivility to the public sphere, Papacharissi (2004) explores incivility in political discourse, where it is understood as a “negative collective face; that is, disrespect for the collective traditions of democracy” (p. 267). Drawing on Brown and Levinson’s (1987) concept of face, she extends it beyond the individual to frame incivility as a threat to civil identity and shared democratic values. By contrast, scholars such as Chen and Lu (2017) and Chen and Ng (2017) conceptualise incivility as a threat to an individual’s public identity in contexts of online political discourse using face and politeness theories (Brown & Levinson, 1987; Goffman, 1959; Oetzel & Ting-Toomey, 2003). In contrast to face-based models, which emphasise identity threats either at an individual level or collective level, Dishon and Ben-Porath (2018) offer a justice-oriented account of incivility. They conceptualise incivility as conduct that undermines others’ equal status within a shared community, whether through exclusion from participation or the reinforcement of social hierarchies. In their view, incivility cannot be judged by “a predominant code of conduct”; instead, it is evaluated in relation to the social context, specifically, whether a given behaviour undermines fairness, inclusion, or equal participation within a shared community (Dishon & Ben-Porath, 2018, p. 439).

Sociological approaches to incivility offer a distinct lens, emphasising the phenomenon as socially constructed and embedded in the routines of everyday public life (Phillips and Smith, 2006 & 2003; Smith, Phillips, and King, 2010). In this strand of work, Phillips and Smith (2006) examine how incivility surfaces through seemingly mundane encounters in public spaces, such as on public transport or in commercial areas. They focus on what participants themselves consider to be uncivil. However, their emphasis remains largely on categorising behaviour that people find uncivil. Although their study stresses the importance of understanding incivility as it is “defined by ordinary social actors” (Phillips & Smith, 2008, p. 88), it does not fully theorise the evaluative frameworks through

which such judgements are made. As a result, while their work provides a grounded account of everyday incivility, it does not engage with how norms are constructed, negotiated, or contested in the process of those evaluations.

To address this conceptual gap, Horgan (2020, 2024) provides a more explicitly evaluative account of everyday incivility, grounding it in how ordinary people interpret and morally judge breaches of expected conduct in public life. Horgan (2024, p.06) frames breaches as "ruptures in interactional norms that draw attention to the more broad-scale production of social order" suggesting that such moments are not merely local disruptions but also windows into the shared moral frameworks underpinning public life. He argues that the identification of incivility occurs through "in situ lay classification of conduct", guided by "culturally available meanings organised around a basic sacred/profane binary" (2020, p.128), where civility is treated as sacred and its violation as profane. This evaluative process takes place within what he describes as a moral landscape, which is marked by the coexistence of multiple, and sometimes contradictory, moral justifications. In making sense of uncivil encounters, individuals foreground certain moral meanings while backgrounding others, working to render their interpretations intelligible. Although these evaluations are shaped by specific interactions, they are not wholly determined by them; he argues that the moral landscape operates at a broader level, existing independently of any single episode and offering a shared, though flexible, framework for moral judgement in everyday public life.

While Horgan provides an account of how ordinary people morally evaluate incivility, his notion of the "moral landscape" tends to foreground a universalist orientation to morality, such as fairness and respect as key interpretive anchors (2024, p.06). While this is valid for the data he examines, his analysis underplays the extent to which social and specific factors shape. Although he acknowledges that participants on a few occasions temper universal claims by referencing personal circumstances, this complexity is not fully explored. That is, while he notes that contextual factors can influence moral evaluation, he does not develop a sustained theoretical account of how these personal and situational elements systematically shape judgements of incivility. As a result, the analysis may risk presenting incivility evaluations as grounded solely in shared moral principles, rather than as socially embedded, negotiated, and responsive to the complexities of everyday interaction. What underpins participants' evaluations, then, may go beyond moral principles alone, drawing also on social norms and context-specific expectations that shape how incivility is interpreted in real life encounters.

Moving to incivility within (im)politeness research, there have been some recent efforts to bring the concept more clearly into the field, although engagement remains limited. As noted in Chapter 1

(Section 1.2), a small number of scholars have touched on the phenomenon of incivility often in connection with broader discussions of public discourse, normative expectations, and evaluations of (im)polite behaviour (e.g., Lakoff, 2005; Mills, 2009, 2017b; O'Driscoll, 2013). While incivility is referenced in some of these works, it is not positioned as a central analytical category. However, these studies contribute to opening up space for thinking about how behaviour is judged in relation to shared norms. More explicit treatments of incivility appear in the work of Terkourafi et al. (2018) and Sifianou (2019), and Haugh (2022), all of whom examine how incivility is constructed and evaluated in online discourse. Terkourafi et al. (2018) treat incivility as a discursively constructed judgement that emerges in public responses to controversial tweets. Drawing on theories of (im)politeness and hate speech, they show how implicated meanings are reinterpreted by diverse audiences, and how certain utterances come to be framed as offensive or uncivil through re-contextualisation processes.

Sifianou (2019), drawing on data from reader comments on a Greek news article, highlights how lay evaluations of impoliteness often extend beyond verbal interaction to include behaviours such as pushing, littering, or failing to queue, which are judged against broader social and moral expectations. Her study foregrounds the significance of folk understandings in shaping perceptions of im/politeness and argues that these evaluations frequently align more closely with what she describes as “the rather broader concept of incivility” (p. 49). However, while the paper draws attention to the conceptual overlap between impoliteness and incivility, it does not provide a systematic framework for distinguishing the two, noting instead that “their exact relationship and their points of overlap and divergence remain rather unclear” (p. 49). The study is insightful in exposing the moral and ideological dimensions embedded in public evaluations, yet it remains largely descriptive and exploratory. It stops short of theorising how incivility might be analytically integrated into (im)politeness research, or what methodological tools might be necessary to capture its distinct features.

A more recent study, Haugh (2022), examines how conduct described as 'public incivilities' is framed or construed as offensive in online denunciations. Drawing on a dataset of viral social media posts in Australia and New Zealand, the study focuses on interactions between strangers in public settings that are treated as morally transgressive when shared and evaluated online. While the term 'public incivility' is used to describe such behaviour, the study does not aim to define or theorise incivility itself. Instead, it focuses on how such behaviour is discursively framed as denounceable through what Haugh calls “moral indignation devices” such as ought-statements, imperatives, assessments,

sarcasm, and negatively valenced descriptions (p. 53). These elements work together to express disapproval and position the conduct as morally blameworthy. As Haugh explains, “online public denunciations of public incivilities do not simply involve claims that the public conduct in question is transgressive, but involve discursively framing that transgression as one warranting public condemnation” (p. 55). Haugh’s (2022) analysis is particularly relevant to the present study in its attention to how ordinary behaviours become the target of public moral judgement through specific linguistic and discursive practices. However, this exclusive focus on moral framing limits the analytical scope of the study, as it does not consider how evaluations of incivility might also stem from context-specific breaches of social or cultural expectations that are not necessarily viewed through a moral lens.

Extending the focus on how public conduct is evaluated, pragmatic research has also examined situations where responses to norm violations become far more intensified and ritualised. In this regard, Kádár and Ning’s (2019) study on ritual public civil humiliation (RPCH) examines extramarital cases in which individuals who are believed to have violated a significant moral norm are subjected to public shaming. Their analysis across many different cases of RPCH shows that people repeatedly use similar interpersonal pragmatic features such as making derogatory moral verdicts, addressing the victim with derogatory terms, and appealing to public attention in order to secure ratification of punishment. These features demonstrate that the impoliteness involved in RPCH is ritual rather than ad hoc, organised around rights and obligations serving to publicly affirm the moral judgement and reinforce the underlying social norm. Unlike the mundane form of public incivility discussed earlier such as those examined by Haugh (2022), where moral appeal may be implicit or explicit depending on the context, RPCH tends to operate with explicit moral appeals as an integral part of the punitive act. Nonetheless, RPCH represents an extreme and punitive response compared to everyday incivility explored in this thesis. It highlights that evaluation of norm violation can take on a ritualised and moralising character, foregrounding the social authority that underpins judgements of inappropriate conduct.

In conclusion, the review of incivility across disciplines reveals that while the concept is interpreted in diverse ways, each field offers valuable insights that can inform a more comprehensive, norm-based evaluative framework. Criminological approaches, despite their tendency to treat incivility as an observable condition, contribute useful distinctions between physical and social forms of incivility and draw attention to how visible disorder can shape perceptions of social decline. Organisational psychology, particularly the work of Andersson and Pearson (1999), offers an interactional model of

incivility as a dynamic process grounded in perceived norm violations and emotional responses, providing a foundation for understanding how uncivil behaviour unfolds over time. Political science approaches, such as those by Papacharissi (2004) and Dishon and Ben-Porath (2018), extend the notion of incivility into the civic realm, where it is understood as a threat to either collective identity or equal participation, highlighting the political and justice-oriented implications of uncivil conduct.

Sociological perspectives, especially those of Phillips and Smith (2006), emphasise how incivility is constructed in everyday public encounters, drawing attention to how ordinary people identify and respond to norm violations in routine contexts. Horgan's (2020, 2024) contribution lies in foregrounding the interpretive processes involved in these evaluations, showing how judgements of incivility are shaped by broader moral frameworks what he terms the 'moral landscape'—while also revealing the layered and sometimes conflicting meanings behind those judgements.

Within (im)politeness research, engagement with incivility remains relatively limited, though recent work by Terkourafi et al. (2018), Sifianou (2019), and Haugh (2022) signals an important shift. These studies highlight how incivility is discursively framed in online discourse and how folk evaluations reflect broader normative and ideological concerns. However, many of these contributions either remain exploratory or implicitly moral, without offering sustained theoretical engagement with how incivility is judged in relation to context-specific norms. The value of this cross-disciplinary review lies in demonstrating the need for an approach that combines the interpersonal, discursive, and socially grounded dimensions of incivility. The present study builds on these insights by proposing a framework that treats incivility as an evaluative act anchored in locally shared norms and expectations, where morality may be evoked but part of broader sociocultural framework.

2.8 Conclusion

This chapter has traced the development of politeness from its early historical roots in ancient moral and social codes to contemporary theories of (im)politeness, and it has argued that impoliteness offers a valuable overarching framework for understanding how individuals evaluate behaviour as offensive or uncivil. Both taking offence and incivility were shown to involve subjective judgements grounded in perceived violations of norms and expectations, shaped by orientations to a broader moral order. This conceptual foundation informs the study's focus on how such evaluations are experienced and articulated in everyday interactions. This chapter also reviewed recent studies on taking offence and incivility and identified gaps in the literature in greater depth.

CHAPTER 3: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter provides a comprehensive account of the methodological framework employed to investigate the phenomena of taking offence and incivility within Omani society. It begins by restating the research questions that underpin this study, establishing a clear focus for the methodological approaches that follow. The chapter then delves into the philosophical foundation of the research, positioning phenomenology as the central perspective. It highlights how meaning is co-constructed through the dynamic interplay between individual subjective experiences and the social-objective dimension of reality, shaping the understanding of taking offence and incivility.

Building on this foundation, the research design and methodological execution are detailed, with a particular emphasis on the explanatory sequential mixed-methods design, followed by an exploratory qualitative layer. It combines quantitative and qualitative methodologies to achieve a multidimension understanding of the phenomena under investigation. Phase One integrates quantitative corpus analysis and qualitative thematic analysis of X data, while Phase Two employs qualitative diary reports to capture detailed personal narratives. The transition from mixed methods in Phase One to the qualitative focus in Phase Two is discussed, demonstrating how these phases complement each other to provide a comprehensive exploration of the phenomena under investigation.

The chapter elaborates on the specific data collection methods utilised in each phase. For Phase One, the process of collecting X data is explained, followed by an account of its analysis, which involved two layers: quantitative corpus analysis using Sketch Engine and qualitative thematic analysis. For Phase Two, the focus shifts to diary reports as the data source, detailing the construction and distribution methods with versions tailored to examine “taking offence” and the “incivility” respectively. The processes of participant selection and the dual distribution strategies, online via WhatsApp and paper-based distribution in public spaces, are also examined along with the preparation and cleaning of the diary report. Subsequently, the data analysis methods for each phase are discussed in depth, with particular attention given to the application of thematic analysis and the theoretical framework that guided this process.

This chapter also details important elements of the research process such as data translation and concludes with a discussion of the ethical measures taken to ensure participant confidentiality.

3.2 Research Questions

The methodological approach outlined in this chapter is guided by two central research questions which reflect the broader aim of the study: is to explore the grounds that Omani individuals invoke to legitimise their judgements of offence and incivility. These questions are as follows:

1. What makes Omani people take offence?
2. What are the norms that govern the perception of incivility in the Omani society?

Building on the research questions, the next section introduces the philosophical foundation that shapes the study's approach and analytical framework.

3.4 Overview of Research Design

This study adopts a two-phase sequential research design, beginning with a preliminary mixed methods phase followed by a qualitative phase. Phase One draws on data from X collected using hashtags associated with offence and incivility, and applies quantitative corpus analysis first, followed by a qualitative thematic analysis of the same dataset. Insights gained from the quantitative analysis inform the subsequent qualitative strand, allowing the study to first identify linguistic patterns in how offence and incivility are expressed online, and then explore the meanings underlying these patterns.

Phase Two builds on the insights developed in Phase One by employing diary reports to capture individuals lived experiences of offence and incivility. The diary report questions were informed by the communicative patterns identified in Phase One, allowing this phase to offer depth and detail that could not be obtained from X data alone.

This section provides a brief outline of the overall design; a detailed account of research procedures is presented in Section 3.5. The next section discusses the philosophical foundation that guides this study.

3.5 Philosophical Foundation of Research

This research adopts a phenomenological epistemological stance, which positions offence and incivility as phenomena that are understood through the ways people experience them and make sense of them in daily life. Underlying this stance is a social constructionist ontological view in which offence and incivility are not treated as objective properties inherent in behaviour, but as socially and culturally mediated interpretations that emerge through individuals' lived experiences with others. In this sense, reality is viewed as intersubjective and shaped by the meaning people attribute to events within their social world.

This stance directs attention to how individuals interpret behaviour within the context of their lived realities. Husserl's (1970) account of the lifeworld informs this approach by emphasising that people come to understand the world through the lived experiences that shape how meaning is formed. In addition, Schutz's (1945) view of the lifeworld as a social realm, a world that is "self-evident, "pre-scientific", "taken-for-granted", "public" and the "common to all of us" (p. 534), highlights that these interpretations are shaped by shared assumptions. In other words, as also viewed in this research, people do not make sense of events in a vacuum; rather, participants' evaluations of offensive or uncivil behaviour are shaped by what they assume to be shared understandings within their social world.

These taken-for-granted understanding that guide these evaluations are drawn from individuals' "stock of knowledge" (Schutz, 1945 p.137). This stock is an accumulated reservoir of experiences that individuals have acquired throughout their lives; it includes cultural information, personal past experiences and general expectations about the world. Thus, the knowledge generated in this study emerges from the ways participants draw on this reservoir when interpreting and evaluating behaviours as offensive or uncivil, relying on what they already know, expect, and assume to be shared within their sociocultural environment. Drawing on this stock, individuals develop typifications by identifying recurring patterns in their interactions and organising them into social categories.

This notion of typifications offers a useful lens for understanding this process in this research, as typifications act as interpretive tools that allow individuals to quickly classify situations, judge their meaning, and anticipate how others are likely to behave. In doing so, they operate as a common frame of reference and provide a foundation for mutual understanding within social groups. However, when they are challenged, such as by events or behaviours that fail to align with the established patterns of meaning, individuals may experience disruption, prompting them to revisit their taken-for-granted knowledge and reassess their existing assumptions. In this study, these moments of disruption, when a behaviour no longer fits an expected typification, are precisely where participants articulate why an action is experienced as offensive or uncivil, making visible the interpretive resources through which knowledge is formed.

This philosophical position aligns directly with the methodological design of the research. It draws on data from X in Phase One and diary reports in Phase Two to access how participants themselves interpret and evaluate these moments of disruption. The accounts gathered in this research enable the study to trace the underlying assumptions that guide participants' judgements of offence and incivility. In doing so, the methodological approach reflects the study's phenomenological foundation,

ensuring that the knowledge produced remains grounded in participants' own meaning-making and socioculturally situated evaluations.

As a researcher, my positionality forms an important part of this philosophical stance. I hold insider knowledge in this research, as an Oman researcher familiar with the social environment from which participants' accounts emerge. At the same time, I also occupy an analyst perspective, applying theoretical frameworks and systematic analytical procedures to interpret the data. This dual position requires ongoing reflexivity to ensure that the analysis remains grounded in participants' accounts.

3.6 Research Design and Methodological Execution

Drawing on the phenomenological foundations outlined in Section 3.3, particularly Schutz's concept of typifications and Vargas's dynamic view of intersubjectivity, the research design is structured to explore how individuals in Omani society draw on the shared sociocultural norms to interpret and evaluate behaviour they consider offensive or uncivil. Having said that, this study is divided into two primary sections: one exploring the phenomenon of taking offence and the other exploring incivility. Both sections follow an identical methodological process to address their research questions and involve two phases.

This study employed an adapted explanatory sequential mixed-methods design followed by a qualitative layer (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2018), structured to explore the norms and expectations underlying offence and incivility in Omani society. Creswell and Plano Clark (2007) describe an explanatory sequential mixed-methods design as a method where researchers first collect and analyse quantitative data, followed by qualitative data collection and analysis to provide deeper insights and explanations for the quantitative findings.

While the general structure of the explanatory sequential mixed methods design, beginning with a quantitative phase followed by a qualitative phase remains consistent with Creswell and Plano Clark's (2007) design, this study introduced key adaptations (see Figure 3.1).

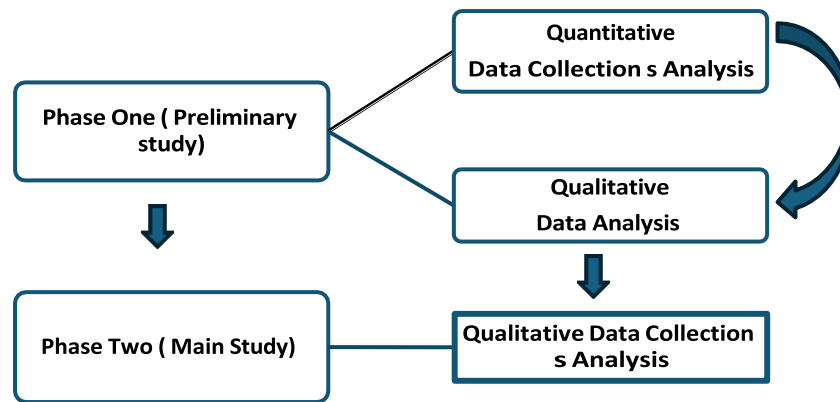


Figure 3.1: An adapted explanatory sequential mixed-methods design with an additional qualitative layer

Rather than following the conventional approach of collecting a new qualitative dataset in the second strand of Phase One, the analysis instead incorporated the same dataset used in the first strand. The second strand (qualitative data analysis) was directly informed by the patterns and insights identified in the quantitative findings. This approach enabled a deeper and more integrated exploration of the same dataset, offering richer insights into the identified patterns. By combining these methods in this way, the study retained the sequential nature of the design while adapting it to provide a richer understanding of offence and incivility (see Section Chapter 4 section 4.3).

In Phase Two, the study adopted an additional qualitative phase to further explore the phenomena of taking offence and incivility. As I noted in chapter One (see Section 1.2 & 1.3), previous research in both taking offence and incivility has often relied on a single method of data collection, which limits the depth and does not capture the whole perspective. It is important to note that Phase One informed the design of Phase Two, as indicated by the directional flow in Figure 3.1. Specifically, insights from the initial phase helped shape the development of the second, particularly by identifying how offence and incivility were discussed, including the specific wording, sequencing and framing used by individuals when commenting online. This will be discussed in detail in Section 3.6.2. Phase Two complemented the findings from Phase One by providing a more detailed and a personal account of how individuals interpret and evaluate behaviours in their social world. It must be highlighted that relying only on Phase One would have provided a limited perspective as it primarily captured online public expression of offence and incivility. Phase Two was therefore essential for gaining multidimensional insights and deeper understanding of the phenomena.

The following sections briefly discuss each strand within the two phases of study, along with the rationale underpinning each strand, illustrating how these strands are systematically applied to uncover the layers of meaning behind taking offence and incivility within Omani society.

3.6.1 Phase 1: Quantitative and Qualitative strands

The quantitative strand was used in the first part of the preliminary study to generate a broad understanding of the phenomenon. Therefore, a large number of tweets were analysed to identify statistical patterns that recurred across many users, offering insights into the general trends of what Omani people find offensive and uncivil in Oman. For instance, analysing the frequency of specific words such as “*country*” in the context of taking offence, or “*rubbish*” in discussions of incivility, revealed how certain topics and behaviours consistently trigger offence or are deemed inappropriate by Omani society. This method offered a bird’s eye view of how offence and incivility manifest across a wide cross-section of the Omani population on X, highlighting common triggers and behaviours perceived as offensive or uncivil.

While this strand offered valuable insight into general trends, it lacked the depth required to fully understand the underlying norms and expectations that shape perceptions of offence and incivility. As Creswell and Tashakkori (2007) noted, quantitative methods often fall short of capturing the depth that is sometimes needed for a fuller understanding. To address the limitations of quantitative analysis, a qualitative strand was incorporated into the preliminary study. This strand involved conducting a thematic analysis on the same dataset, which had been analysed quantitatively, building upon the patterns identified during the quantitative analysis. The intent of this qualitative strand was to provide a deeper understanding and contextual insights into the patterns and trends revealed by the quantitative analysis. It uncovered the expectations that were infringed that led to taking offence, and the norms that were violated that made the X users consider an act as uncivil.

By integrating these two strands, quantitative strand to identify trends and qualitative strand to explore the underlying meaning, a comprehensive initial understanding of the dynamics of taking offence and incivility was uncovered within the context of Omani X users.

3.6.2 Phase 2: Qualitative Strand

Building on the findings from Phase One, which provided an initial understanding of the dynamics of taking offence and incivility within the context of Omani X users, Phase Two was designed to deepen this understanding by capturing personal accounts of these phenomena. It was built on the developmental role of Phase One. In other words, insights from both quantitative and qualitative

analysis of X data in Phase one informed the design and formulation of the diary reports in Phase Two. As Greene et al. (1989, p. 259) note, "results from one method help develop or inform the other method". This sequential integration enabled Phase Two to build on the broader understanding gained from Phase One, transitioning from a broad overview to an in-depth investigation of individuals' experiences.

While the X data provided valuable initial insights into the perceptions of taking offence and incivility, it only captured a specific demographic group, primarily X users, who are males. Although the exact figure on X users in Oman from the period when data was retrieved (2011-2020) does not exist, recent data indicates that as of early 2024, 62% of X users in Oman were male, while 37.5% were females, reflecting a broader trend of male-dominated X usage in the country (DataReportal, 2024). This gender imbalance means that the data predominantly reflects male perspectives, limiting the representation of female voices on offence and incivility. Additionally, the use of X data primarily reflects the perspectives of platform users, which may not fully capture the experiences of those who do not engage with X. While this provides valuable insights into public discussions on offence and incivility, it is important to acknowledge that perspectives from individuals who do not use X might be unrepresented.

Additionally, the character limit on X posts during the period from which the data was retrieved imposed constraints on the depth of users' expressions. To explain, until 2017, posts were restricted to 140 characters per post, and although this limit was later expanded to 280 characters, the brevity still limited users from providing detailed accounts and sufficient context (Rosen & Ihara, 2017). These constraints, coupled with demographic limitations of X users, underscored the necessity of incorporating additional data collection methods to achieve a more comprehensive understanding of these phenomena.

Thus, Phase Two served a dual purpose: addressing the inherent limitations of Phase One while capturing the personal narratives and contextual insights necessary for a holistic understanding of offence and incivility in Omani society. Together, the two phases created a layered and comprehensive exploration, integrating the quantitative and qualitative insights from Phase One, where broad patterns in language use and themes were identified, with the detailed, context-rich accounts captured in Phase Two.

The next sections outline the methods employed in Phase One, detailing the data collection tools, the process of gathering the data, and the subsequent data cleaning procedures. This is followed by a discussion of analysis process, starting with quantitative corpus analysis then transitioning to

qualitative thematic analysis.

3.7 Phase One: Data Collection and Analysis

3.7.1 Date Collection: X as Data Source

In Phase One of the study, X was used to locate written texts that reflect acts of taking offence and incivility. As a widely used online platform, X allows users to share their thoughts and opinions in short posts limited to 280 characters. The nature of the text content that the users post may include personal updates, thoughts and opinions, and it may include images, links and hashtags to participate in broader conversations or categorise content effectively (Weller et al., 2014).

X was selected as a data source for several compelling reasons. One of these is that unlike traditional surveys where responses are guided, X offers a naturally occurring dataset that captures users' spontaneous behaviour and unfiltered thoughts. This aligns with McCormick, Lee, Cesare, Shojaie, and Spiro's (2017, p.96) observation that "this source of organically created and automatically archived human data allow researchers to see what people are doing, what they are saying, and how they feel about a particular issue as these actions and thoughts arise". This highlights the value of X data as authentic data source for capturing individuals' perspectives.

What is more, X is considered a "locative platform" as it allows users to attach location data as well as timestamps to their tweets. This optional feature significantly enhances the platform's value for research purposes by enabling the identification of geographical locations and timeframes, allowing researchers to find data based on where and when events occur (Weller, Bruns, Burgess, Mahrt, and Puschmann, 2014, p.155).

It is important to note, however, that X posts do not represent natural, real-time interaction. To explain, posts are written after an event has occurred, meaning that the platform captures people's recalled perceptions rather than the full unfolding of the situation itself. However, X posts are considered spontaneous, unprompted expressions produced without researcher influence, allowing individuals to articulate their evaluations freely. Thus, they provide valuable insights into how offence and incivility are publicly expressed which aligns with the aims of this study.

Having established the rationale behind using X as a data collection platform, hashtags and keywords were therefore employed to efficiently locate relevant tweets related to taking offence and incivility within Oman. As Weller et al. (2014, p.74) note, X users use hashtags to "explicitly mark tweets as relevant to a specific theme", making them easily researchable. A hashtag is created by placing the symbol # directly before a keyword, enabling the categorisation of content and facilitating

its discovery. Keywords, on the other hand, are words or phrases that can appear anywhere within the text of a tweet and are used to identify content related to a particular topic. They are used in research queries to locate relevant material without requiring the use of a specific symbol.

Having said that, hashtags were employed as a primary method for identifying tweets explicitly tagged with specific terms such as #مسي (translated as #offensive) and or #غير حضاري (translated as #uncivil). These hashtags enabled efficient organisation of posts and conversations directly linked to the topic of interest (Efron, 2011). Nevertheless, relying solely on hashtags to locate relevant posts posed several limitations. To explain, “hashtags datasets do not contain all relevant tweets, but only those whose authors knew of and felt motivated enough to include the hashtag in the tweet”. Furthermore, not all relevant posts are “marked with an appropriate hashtag” (p.24). In other words, some people might talk about taking offence or incivility without using hashtag. This means that relevant content could remain hidden within posts not explicitly tagged with the # symbol, making it more challenging to collect or identify through hashtag searches alone.

Therefore, to address this limitation, keyword searches were employed alongside hashtag searches. This combined approach ensured that relevant but untagged posts could also be captured, thereby enhancing the comprehensiveness and accuracy of the data collection process.

3.7.2 The Process of Collecting X Data:

To locate written texts involving the act of taking offence and incivility, the selection of hashtags and keywords was a crucial step in the data collection process. This process was informed by consultations with subject matter experts, input from Omani friends with firsthand knowledge of the country social and cultural context, and review of existing research on taking offence and incivility.

The subject matter experts provided valuable academic insights, using their academic expertise to identify commonly used words and phrases relevant to discussions of taking offence and incivility. Their input ensured that the selected terms were theoretically grounded and aligned with broader research on these topics. Complementing this academic perspective, Omani friends offered crucial local knowledge, including nuances in language used on the platform. Their contribution included identifying slang, idiomatic expressions, and culturally specific terms that might not be easily recognised by those unfamiliar with the local context.

Additionally, reviewing previous studies that utilised hashtags to investigate taking offence and incivility such as Tayebi (2016) and others, contributed to informing the selection of hashtags by shedding light on common terminology used to discuss these phenomena. While these studies were

conducted in different contexts, they highlighted specific terms and phrases frequently associated with taking offence and incivility. This provided clear guidance on the language and expressions to consider when identifying appropriate hashtags for this research.

By the combining the academic expertise, local insight from Omani friends, and a review of previous studies, the selection of hashtags was thoughtfully crafted to ensure it was both culturally relevant and academically grounded. This collaborative approach resulted in a carefully crafted list of hashtags and keywords in Arabic that best represent the terms associated with the discussion of taking offence and incivility within Omani X community.

The following tables present this comprehensive and representative list of terms tailored to the context of this research. Table 3.1 focuses on terms associated with taking offence, while Table 3.2 highlights terms related to incivility. Each table includes the Arabic hashtags and keywords which were originally used in the search, their English translations, and phonetic transcriptions for accessibility to non-Arabic speakers. Together, these tables form the foundation for identifying the relevant posts.

Hashtags	Translation	Transcription
#مسيئة	offensive	/musi:jh/
#إهانة	Insult	/a:h nh/
#مستاء	upset	/mwst?/
#إساءة	offence	/a:sa:ʔ/

Table 3.1: Taking offence

Hashtags	Translation	Transcription
#غير حضاري	uncivil	/ʔe:r ħa'dʕa:ri:/
#غير لائق	Inappropriate	/ʔe:r la:ʔiq/

Table 3.2: Incivility

After identifying relevant hashtags and keywords, additional sampling criteria were applied to ensure that the dataset was geographically and culturally specific to the Omani society. The first sampling criterion was geolocation; given that this study focuses on the Omani society, it was vital to ensure that the tweets were generated from within Oman. To achieve this, a geolocation filter was applied, targeting tweets were explicitly tied to an Omani geographical location. While “most tweets are not associated with geographic location” (Davis et al., 2011, p.739), meaning they do not explicitly indicate the location from which they were posted, their geographic origin can often be determined through the metadata embedded within them. To find the embedded location, geoparsing was employed; a process described as “automated place-name recognition within text strings which converts these names into longitude/latitude coordinates” (Janowicz & Kebler, 2008, p.1129). However, clear location cues are not always present in tweets due to the use of textual abbreviations and non-standard vocabulary (Cheng et al, 2010). This limitation can result in compiling a dataset that may not accurately reflect the intended geolocation. This issue was specifically addressed and resolved during the data cleaning process.

The second sampling criterion applied was language. Since this research focuses on Omani X users, the dataset was filtered to include tweets written in the Arabic language. This decision was based on the fact that Arabic is the primary language of communication in Oman. This criterion is particularly significant because language is not merely a means of communication but also a carrier of cultural expectations and norms as will be demonstrated in the results chapters (4,5,6 and 7). As Schieffelin, Woolard, and Kroskrity (1998) highlight, language plays a crucial role in shaping and reflecting societal values, making the decision to filter for Arabic essential to accurately represent Omanis.

To retrieve tweets using the predefined hashtags and keywords listed above (see table 3.1 & table 3.2), along with geolocation and language criteria, Vicinitas was employed . Vicinitas is an online analytics tool designed for tracking hashtags, keywords, accounts and websites. The request to Vicinities was submitted on 16 October 2020 to collect tweets spanning from 2011 to 2020, capturing nearly a decade of discussion on offence and incivility within Omani society. The retrieved data was provided in a single Excel file containing links to the original tweets, along with metadata such as timestamps and geolocations (see figure 3.2). The dataset included approximately 1,500 tweets under hashtags related to taking offence and around 400 tweets under hashtags relevant to incivility. These tweets were organised in reverse chronological order, reflecting their timeline. While the dataset was extensive, it required a thorough cleaning process to ensure accuracy and relevance.

utc_date	dc_time	source	favorites	retweets	replies	quotes	lang	tweet_type	text	country_code	place	latitude	longitude
2014-04-14	4/14/2014	Twitter for	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	تذكر يا عزيزي أن الاعتذار تربية وليس إهانة	OM	Oman	23.29659	56.55445
2014-04-14	4/11/2014	Twitter for	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	في مجتمعنا فقط إهانة الابن تعني لهم الرجولة و نسوان من ريتهم	OM	Oman	23.62006	58.23881
2014-04-04	4/9/2014	Twitter for	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	تذكر يا عزيزي أن الاعتذار تربية وليس إهانة ..	OM	Oman	23.42339	56.72528
2014-04-04	4/7/2014	Twitter for	0	1	0	0	ar	tweet	أمارة هندية تتحرق حرقاً وذلك بعد قيام المحكمة بالطلب من معتصم	OM	Oman	24.21885	56.81703
2014-04-04	4/7/2014	Twitter for	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	إهانة الشخص بال عبارات اللطيفة وينيرة ساخرة أشد تأثيراً من الكلام	OM	Oman	23.64054	58.22418
2014-04-04	4/7/2014	Twitter for	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	إهانة الشخص بال عبارات اللطيفة وينيرة ساخرة أشد تأثيراً من الكلام	OM	Oman	23.63628	58.22764
2014-04-04	4/7/2014	Twitter for	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	تذكر يا عزيزي أن الاعتذار تربية وليس إهانة	OM	Oman	17.01498	54.0853
2014-04-04	4/7/2014	Twitter for	1	2	0	0	ar	tweet	تذكر يا عزيزي أن الاعتذار تربية وليس إهانة	OM	Oman	23.96007	57.07083
2014-04-04	4/7/2014	Twitter for	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	التيارات القانونية لنا علينا بالاستخدام الأمثل ثقافة_ إلكترونية_ آمنة	OM	Oman	23.60023	58.20827
2014-04-04	4/6/2014	Twitter for	2	1	1	0	ar	reply	في عندي. لكن هل حقاً هي ظاهرة مشهورة كثير @FataEndam	OM	Oman	23.58887	58.1376
2014-04-04	4/5/2014	Twitter for	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	في مجتمعنا فقط إهانة الابن تعني لهم الرجولة و نسوان من ريتهم	OM	Oman	22.91183	57.53294
2014-04-04	4/2/2014	Twitter for	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	لا الاعتذار تربية وليس إهانة حقاً اعتذر# .. دون ان اتبه	OM	Oman	23.01803	57.32408
2014-03-3	3/30/2014	Twitter for	4	4	0	0	ar	tweet	الإعلام ثقافة راقية ... يعتقدونها الجاهل إهانة لنفس .	OM	Oman	23.60648	58.2217
2014-03-3	3/29/2014	Twitter for	1	4	0	0	ar	tweet	الاعتذار ثقافة راقية يعتقد البعض أنها إهانة لنفس . كم أفسدت الـ	OM	Oman	23.7626	57.5319
2012-09-19	9/19/2012	Twitter W	0	0	1	0	ar	tweet	//t.co/ho3ld7Vx الهند من أكثر الدول إساءة إلى النساء في العالم	OM	Oman	21.51402	55.91576
2012-08-3	8/29/2012	Twitter W	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	الحزن المفرط على الوفاة جونه فهو إهانة للأحياء ولا تعلمه الأمو	OM	Oman	21.51402	55.91576
2012-07-1	7/19/2012	Twitter W	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	أحقر البشر : هو الذي يهينك إهانة شديدة أمام الناس وعندما ينفرد	OM	Oman	21.51402	55.91576
2012-06-0	6/2/2012	Twitter W	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	أعظم الأسباب لدفع إساءة المسيء غفلك، أن تسمى إساءته إليك	OM	Oman	21.51402	55.91576
2012-02-0	2/6/2012	Twitter W	0	0	0	0	ar	tweet	مستاء جداً .. مجلس الجيل والجار باسم الدين #EgyParliament	OM	Oman	21.51402	55.91576

Figure 3.2: Snapshot of retrieved X data with metadata

The following section details the steps taken to prepare the data for analysis process.

3.7.3 X Data Cleaning

The first version of the file obtained from Vicintas was not ideal for use immediately in building the corpora; thus, additional steps had to be followed to clean, refine, and standardise the data. Firstly, once confronted with the raw data, information about the users' accounts and names was removed from the dataset to protect their identity, aligning with ethical guidelines for research involving social media data (Townsend & Wallace, 2016). Furthermore, unwanted metadata such as HTML tags, links, and images were removed, as these elements do not contribute to text analysis and can interfere with the tools used for quantitative analysis.

Moreover, standardising the spelling of keywords and hashtags used in the tweets was an essential step in preparing the corpus for the quantitative analysis. Terms associated with taking offence (e.g., #مستاء, #مسيئة, إهانة, #إساءة) and incivility (e.g., #غير حضاري, #غير لائق) were carefully standardised to ensure consistency. Spelling variations, such as the difference between "إساءة" and "إساءة", which were prevalent in the data received, could result in inaccurate analysis outcomes, especially when using text analysis tools such as Sketch Engine. For example, frequency counts might treat these variations as entirely different words, despite them being the same but simply misspelled. This discrepancy would reduce the reliability of frequency data and impede pattern recognition (Baroni & Bernardini, 2004). Furthermore, beyond word frequency, analytical methods like collocation and

concordance rely on consistent word forms to identify accurate patterns. Without standardised spelling, the analysis tools may fail to detect significant collocations, resulting in incomplete insights.

After standardising the spelling, the data was separated into six different Word documents, with each document containing tweets corresponding to one of the six keywords. This organisation ensured that all tweets related to specific keywords were grouped together, making the data easier to manage.

Upon closer inspection of the data, decisions had to be made regarding which tweets to include in the corpus. While retaining all contributions might initially seem ideal, it soon became apparent that some contributions were problematic. One major challenge was that many of the original tweets associated with the hashtags had been deleted, rendering them unavailable and making it difficult to fully understand the context of certain tweets that were linked to the hashtag. Additionally, some of the tweets linked to the hashtags were irrelevant to the research; for example, some contained poems that included the keywords but were unrelated to the subjects being studied. These tweets were excluded to maintain the relevance and focus of the corpus.

Moreover, despite applying geolocation filters designed to capture tweets originating from Oman, some tweets from neighbouring countries, such as the UAE and Saudi Arabia, were included due to the proximity of locations. A significant amount of time was spent manually identifying and removing these tweets to ensure the dataset's accuracy. Additionally, some of the tweets containing the keywords were unrelated to Oman and were written by non-Omanis, despite having an Omani geolocation tag; these tweets were also excluded to maintain the relevance of the corpus. Furthermore, many tweets in the dataset were duplicated, either as identical posts or retweets shared multiple times by different users. Retweets, which are simply reposts of existing content, were deemed of no value for this research as their frequency does not add any additional insight to the content itself; therefore, they were removed. With the dataset now refined and organised, the next section will outline the data analysis process.

3.7.4 Data Analysis in Phase One

The data analysis in Phase One for both *Taking Offence* and *Incivility*, involved two integrated layers of analysis: quantitative and qualitative approaches. The first layer employed quantitative corpus analysis conducted with the help of Sketch Engine, which offered key linguistic insights and patterns. These findings informed the second layer, a qualitative thematic analysis. These two layers were designed to complement each other, with the findings from the quantitative analysis shaping and guiding the focus of the qualitative analysis.

This integrated approach ensured a more comprehensive understanding of the data by combining the strengths of both methodologies.

3.7.4.1 First Layer: Quantitative Corpus Analysis Using Sketch Engine

The first layer of analysis was conducted with the help of Sketch Engine on the cleaned and organised corpus. Sketch Engine is an advanced corpus analysis tool specifically designed for processing and analysing large volumes of textual data.

It offers a range of features for exploring linguistic patterns, including word frequency, collocations, concordances, and N-grams (Kilgarrieff, Baisa, Bušta, Jakubíček, Kovář, Michelfeit, Rychlý and Suchomel, 2014). These tools were instrumental in analysing both *Taking Offence* and *Incivility* corpora. Each hashtag corpus was analysed individually to allow a focused exploration of the specific linguistic patterns and features associated with each hashtag or keyword. This individualised approach ensured that the distinct contexts and characteristics of each corpus were thoroughly examined, providing a nuanced understanding of the linguistic structure, recurring patterns, and themes linked to each hashtag.

Starting with *Taking Offence* corpora, two types of analysis were conducted: N-gram analysis and frequency analysis. N-gram refers to a sequence of words where n signifies the number of words in the sequence. For instance, a 1-gram consists of a single word, and a 2-gram consists of two consecutive words, and a 3-gram consists of three consecutive words. In this research, N-gram analysis was employed to identify words that appear before and /or after the hashtag. This focus helped reveal how Omani people construct narratives when discussing taking offence, offering a detailed perspective on the underlying linguistic structures. For instance, the keyword “إهانة” (“insult”) was consistently followed by “لـ” (“to”), indicating that the expression typically introduces the recipient of the insult. In the corpus associated with #insult, analysing bigrams (combinations of 1-grams and 2-grams) provided insights into the common targets of offence in Omani society.

Moreover, frequency analysis was also employed in this corpus. Frequency analysis examines how often a particular word or phrase appears within a text or a collection of texts. In the taking offence corpora, the frequency of N-grams was explored in relation to the base word, which served as the anchor for the analysis. The base word refers to the keyword or hashtag around which N-grams were analysed and acted as the starting point for this exploration.

For example, consider the bigram “insult to Oman”, where the base word is “insult”, the 1-gram is “to”, and the 2-gram is “Oman”. By investigating the frequency with which this bigram appeared in

the corpus, it became evident that Omani X users often discussed insults in connection with the nation.

Moving to the analysis of *Incivility* corpora, N-gram and frequency analysis were also employed along with concordance analysis. These methods allowed for the identification of dominant patterns as well as the contextual nuances in how incivility was described, offering valuable insights into the linguistic and the dynamics of incivility reflected in the corpora.

The analysis of incivility began with a 1-gram analysis, focusing on identifying what comes before the base word, which in this case is the keyword. This step helped uncover linguistic patterns that provide context to the base word, shedding light on how users frame discussions of uncivil behaviour. To illustrate this, in the phrase “منظر غير لائق”, (“inappropriate view”), the 1-gram “منظر”, (“view”) precedes the base word “غير لائق”, (“inappropriate”) (see figure 3.3). This pattern highlights that the discussions of incivility that often emphasise visual elements, suggesting that societal concerns around appearance play a significant role in defining what is deemed inappropriate.

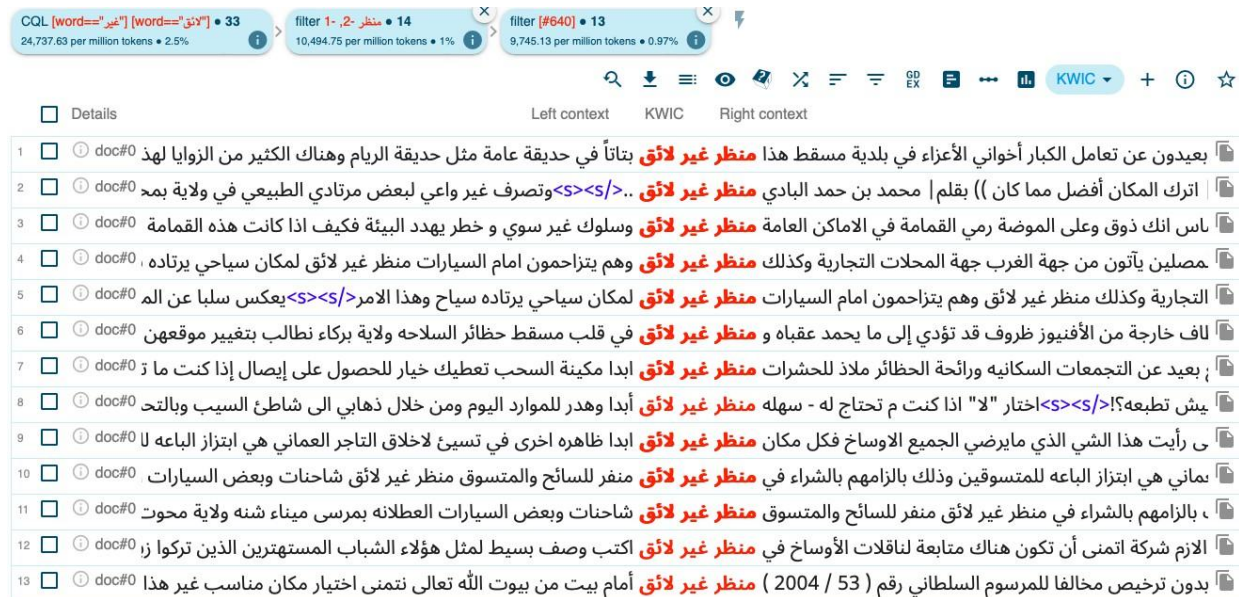


Figure 3.3 : Highlighted 1-gram pattern for “منظر غير لائق” (“inappropriate view”)

To further support this N-gram findings, the frequency of the 1-gram was examined. Counting the frequency of “منظر” preceding “غير لائق” provided additional evidence of the prominence of visual references in the discourse. By quantifying how often this 1-gram appears, the analysis validated the observed linguistic pattern and reinforces the conclusion that concerns related to visual appropriateness are central to discussions of incivility.

This systematic approach ensures that the N-gram findings are not only identified but also supported by measurable data, offering a more robust understanding of themes emerging from the corpora. In addition to n-gram analysis and its frequency, further analysis was conducted to delve deeper into the incivility corpora. This included running a concordance analysis to examine the textual context surrounding the keywords. Concordance, as defined by Kübler (2014, p.197), refers to “a list displaying all occurrences of a word in a text with its context”.

The decision to utilise concordance analysis, rather than relying solely on N-gram analysis as was done with the *Taking offence* corpora, was driven by the limitations of N-gram analysis. N-gram is restricted to examining short sequences of words (e.g., 1-gram, 2-gram, or 3-gram), which proved inadequate for capturing the broader context of what X users considered uncivil. During the initial review of the incivility data, it was observed that users often articulated their perceptions in extended sequences, frequently exceeding 6-grams. This limitation made concordance analysis essential to uncover what the users perceived as uncivil behaviour (see figure 3.4).

CONCORDANCE

simple غير حضاري • 65
34,156.59 per million tokens • 3.4%

KWIC

	Left context	KWIC	Right context
21	doc#0	غير حضارية	ظاهرة
22	doc#0	غير حضارية	ظاهرة
23	doc#0	غير حضارية	ظاهرة
24	doc#0	غير حضارية	ظاهرة
25	doc#0	غير حضارية	ظاهرة
26	doc#0	غير حضارية	ظاهرة
27	doc#0	غير حضارية	ظاهرة
28	doc#0	غير حضارية	ظاهرة
29	doc#0	غير حضارية	ظاهرة
30	doc#0	غير حضارية	ظاهرة
31	doc#0	غير حضاري	ظاهرة
32	doc#0	غير حضاري	ظاهرة
33	doc#0	غير حضاري	ظاهرة
34	doc#0	غير حضاري	ظاهرة
35	doc#0	غير حضاري	ظاهرة
36	doc#0	غير حضاري	ظاهرة
37	doc#0	غير حضاري	ظاهرة
38	doc#0	غير حضاري	ظاهرة

Figure 3.4: Sample concordance lines generated for the keyword “ حضاري غير ”
 (“uncivil”) from incivility corpora

After generating the concordance list, the analysis focused on extracting specific segments that were directly related to what the users considered غير حضاري (uncivil), that is the phrase highlighted in red in Figure 3.4 rather than analysing the entire posts. The concordance list provided a detailed view of the contextual usage of the keywords. This selective approach ensured that the focus remained on elements most relevant to understanding what X users considered uncivil. By isolating these key elements, the analysis prioritised capturing the instances within the concordance lines where uncivil acts or behaviours were described. These lines served to highlight examples of incivility, which were later explored in greater depth during the thematic analysis phase to understand the underlying norms associated with the behaviour.

One of these segments was extracted from the concordance list; the analysis proceeded by counting the occurrence of these segments. This additional step allowed for the identification of patterns in the frequency and distribution of uncivil acts or behaviours as described in the data. The counting process involved systematically reviewing the extracted concordance segments to determine how often particular phrases or descriptions of uncivil acts appeared within the data. This process was conducted manually because the phrasing used to describe uncivil behaviour varied across the dataset. Users expressed similar ideas in different ways, making it essential to account for semantic variations, where conceptually similar acts were described using different words or expressions.

The automated frequency count in Sketch Engine was not used because such tools rely on exact word matches and are limited in their ability to identify semantic variations or account for linguistic nuances. Conducting the counting manually ensured that all meaningful expressions of incivility, regardless of how they were phrased, were captured. Moreover, single-occurrence instances where a description appeared only once were also included in the analysis. While these segments may seem insignificant at first glance, many of them reflected the same underlying semantic meaning as more frequent patterns but were expressed using different phrases. Less common expressions of incivility were also included to ensure that the analysis captured the full range of ways in which users perceived and described behaviour as uncivil. This approach allowed the analysis to account for both common patterns and less frequent, yet equally relevant instances of what is considered uncivil, providing a more comprehensive understanding of the data. Once the concordance frequencies were identified, further contextual details were explored.

Recent research in incivility has emphasised that understanding the situational environment in which the act occurs is important, and overlooking it can lead to misinterpretation of communicative behaviour (Litvinenko, 2023). In light of this argument, identifying the setting in which the

described acts occurred was a necessary step toward understanding perceptions of incivility. This process involved a manual review of the concordance result to look for locations connected with the previously extracted segments.

To summarise the first layer of analysis, quantitative methods, including N-gram, frequency, and concordance analysis, were employed to systematically examine the X corpus. These methods were instrumental in identifying key linguistic patterns, and recurring themes, and the triggers associated with discussions of offence and incivility. While this quantitative analysis provided valuable insights into prominent patterns, it laid the groundwork for a deeper exploration of the phenomena.

Building on this foundation, the next section introduces the second layer of analysis, which employed thematic analysis to delve deeper into the results highlighted by the quantitative analysis. The transition from quantitative-driven analysis to qualitative analysis was not merely a methodological shift but a progression necessary to achieve a comprehensive understanding of taking offence and incivility. The themes explored in the second layer through thematic analysis were grounded in the language and discourse previously analysed.

3.7.4.2 Second Layer: Qualitative Thematic Analysis

The second layer of the analysis involved a qualitative thematic analysis of the X data, informed by the patterns identified during the first layer of quantitative analysis. This phase aimed to delve deeper into the expectations and norms that were violated by closely examining tweets and uncovering their underlying meaning within their specific contexts.

Thematic analysis as defined by Braun and Clarke (2006, p.8) is a method for “identifying, analysing and reporting patterns (themes) within data”. It goes beyond simply counting explicit words or phrases and instead focuses on identifying and interpreting both explicit and implicit ideas within the data, referred to as themes (Guest, MacQueen, and Namey, 2012). The explicit ideas are examined at the semantic level, which involves analysing the surface content of the data. This includes interpreting the direct language used in the tweets, specific words, phrases, and expressions to understand what is overtly communicated. By focusing on the semantic content, the study identifies how users articulate their experiences in relation to taking offence and incivility.

In contrast, the implicit ideas are explored at the latent level, where analysis goes beyond the participant-expressed meanings to uncover the underlying norms and expectations that inform the semantic expression. At this level, the analysis “tends to bring analyst’s framework to bear on the data and are built around concepts that help explain the data” (Willig & Rogers, 2017, p.23).

3.7.4.3 Conducting thematic analysis

To analyse the qualitative X data, this study adapted Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-step framework for thematic analysis, ensuring a rigorous and systematic approach. Given that quantitative analysis had already been conducted on the same X dataset during Phase One, the findings from Phase One provided a solid foundation for guiding the thematic analysis. These insights informed the coding process and guided the themes' identification, enabling a more focused and comprehensive exploration of the data.

While the X dataset contained a rich and extensive body of data, its volume became manageable after the quantitative analysis. Consequently, manual coding was chosen for the analysis, as the patterns identified in Phase One made this approach both feasible and effective. The following table 3.3 summarises all the steps undertaken, and each step involved:

Thematic analysis phases	How it was implanted in my thematic analysis
Familiarising yourself with data	• Re-reading the tweets and grasping the context in which frequently occurring words, phrases and patterns occurred. • Understanding the tweets at two levels: surface level by looking at the explicit meaning of the phrases and words to understand and note what people reported to be offensive or uncivil and how they described specific events. While the second level focused on understanding the tweets at a deeper level; it aimed at understanding the underlying expectations and norms that influenced the decision to consider an act to be offensive or uncivil.
Generating initial codes	• The coding process was influenced by both the explicit content and the latent meaning identified during the familiarisation step. • Codes were generated using a combined approach: 1. Deductive approach: Guided by the quantitative findings from Phase one, allowing the analysis to focus on pre-identified patterns. 2. Inductive approach: allowing for additional more codes that were not immediately evident in the quantitative phase.

	• Each segment of the data was labelled with a code that captured its key meaning. • Subsequently, the codes were organised into groups and subgroups based on their relevance to specific data segments.
Searching for themes	• This step involved grouping related codes into broader themes that captured behaviours perceived as offensive or uncivil. • Both semantic (explicit) and latent (underlying) themes were identified. • This process aimed to uncover not only what actions were considered offensive or uncivil but also the implicit norms and expectations influencing these perceptions.
Reviewing themes	• The themes were systematically reviewed to ensure they accurately reflected the data. • Themes that were not sufficiently supported by the data were either discarded or adjusted to improve their relevance and coherence. • Overlapping or closely related themes were merged to form more robust categories, ensuring they captured the essence of the data. • This iterative process involved revisiting the coded data to confirm to confirm that each theme was distinct, internally consistent, and meaningfully representative.
Defining and naming themes	• This process involved articulating the core meaning of each theme to ensure that it accurately represented the patterns identified in the data. • The names of the themes were carefully chosen to encapsulate their essence, capturing the underlying norms and expectations that defined the theme rather than merely reflecting surface- level patterns. • Each theme was defined with a focus on its connection to the main research questions, ensuring that the themes not only represented the data but also contributed meaningfully to addressing the research questions.

Producing the report	• The phase involved writing up the findings and writing up the themes in relation to the two main research questions. • Each theme was explained in detail, accompanied by supporting excerpts from the tweets that exemplified the theme’s meaning and significance. The excerpts were carefully chosen ensuring they supported the analysis. • The analysis seamlessly integrated multiple perspectives, embedding them within the thematic analysis to ensure a holistic understanding of the data as explained in the framework section (3.7). These perspectives included X users’ experiences (meta participant), cultural insights derived from both insider and outsider perspectives (emic- etic), the observations and interpretation of a analyst observer (lay observer- professional analyst), and theoretical insights balanced with everyday understandings (folk-theoretic and scientific- theoretic).
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Table 3.3: Summary of the implementation of Braun and Clarke’s (2006) six-step thematic analysis

Following the completion of the thematic analysis in Phase One, which provided foundational insight into the expectations and norms surrounding *Taking Offence* and *Incivility*, this study transitions to Phase Two in the following section. Phase Two begins with introducing diary reports as a data source and discussing how they were constructed to explore the two phenomena separately. It then discusses the participant selection, methods of diary report distribution and the process of cleaning the data to prepare it for analysis. Finally, the thematic analysis of the diary report data is discussed using Braun and Clarke’s six-step framework to identify key themes and patterns.

3.8 Phase two: Data Collection and Analysis

3.8.1 Diary Report as a Source of Data

In Phase Two of the study, a diary report was used to collect written accounts of individuals narrating incidents where they felt offended or encountered behaviour they considered uncivil in public spaces. Designed to capture the “little experiences of everyday life” (Wheeler & Reis, 1991,

p.340), the diary report allowed participants to document these moments as they recalled them, providing deeper insight into how they interpreted and evaluated such occurrences.

The fundamental benefit of using a diary in this research is that it allows the investigation of narrated events and experiences in their natural and spontaneous context (Reis, 1994). While the participants were guided by carefully formulated questions, they still had the freedom and flexibility to describe incidents in their own words, emphasising aspects they found most relevant, striking, or emotionally significant. Additionally, it facilitates the collection of “reliable person-level information” (Bolger, Davis and Rafaeli, 2003, p.581). This reliability stems from the fact that the participants are directly recounting incidents they experienced or witnessed, providing a firsthand or closely observed account of how offence and incivility are perceived in real-life contexts. By capturing these narratives, the diary report provided rich, personal accounts that reflect individuals’ interpretations and evaluations. Therefore, the diary report was employed as a key data collection tool in Phase Two to gather detailed, personal narratives from the participants about their experiences with taking offence and incivility.

It is important to acknowledge that although diary reports offer valuable access to participants’ evaluations of offence and incivility, they do not capture events as they occurred in the moment. Ideally, phenomena such as offence and incivility are best studied as they unfold in real life. However, this was not feasible, as these incidents usually occur unexpectedly sometimes in private or even in sensitive settings, and even when they happen in public, observing enough relevant cases would require a considerable amount of time. For this reason, the diary report relies on participants’ retrospective accounts rather than real-time observation. Nevertheless, participants were given the freedom to describe incidents in their own words and highlight what they found meaningful or significant, providing rich insight into how they understood and evaluated the incidents.

3.8.2 The Construction of Diary Reports

In this research, two diary reports were constructed based on respectively based on the broader understanding of offence and incivility developed in Phase One (see Appendix A). The findings from Phase One played a crucial role in guiding the design of the diary report. They guided the wording of the questions, their sequence, and the depth of responses required.

The analysis of X data provided insights into how offence and incivility were discussed, including the language people used and how they framed their experiences. This ensured that the diary report questions were phrased in a way that matched how people naturally talked about these experiences.

Instead of using general theoretical wording such as “what makes you take offence,” which focuses on an abstract concept and may lead to generalised or opinion-based responses, the diary report questions were designed to elicit experience-driven responses (see section 3.6.2).

Additionally, the sequence of questions in the diary report were guided by patterns observed in Phase One. The X data often showed that when discussing offence, people first described the event itself before reflecting, sometimes on why they found it offensive. This informed the logical progression of the diary report questions, which first asked participants to recount the incidents, then encouraged them to reflect on their feelings and reasoning.

Beyond the wording and sequence of the questions, the findings from Phase One also influenced how much detail participants were encouraged to provide in their responses. The analysis of X data revealed that discussions of offence and incivility was often brief and lacked personal and contextual depth, highlighting a need for more elaborate and reflective accounts. This insight directly informed the diary report by shaping how responses were elicited, ensuring that participants were encouraged to expand on their experiences rather than providing brief answers.

While both reports followed a similar structure, they were tailored to address distinct research questions. Each question was carefully crafted to guide participants in narrating incidents, ensuring the collection of meaningful and detailed responses. The two diary reports consisted of two parts to facilitate the collection of both structured and open-ended responses. The following section outlines the construction of each diary report, beginning with the *Taking Offence* report and followed by the *Incivility* report.

3.8.2.1 Diary Report 1: Taking offence

Part one consisted of a simple Yes/No question: ‘*Have you ever been offended, or has anyone you know been offended?*’ This question served multiple purposes. Firstly, it aimed to establish whether the participant had relevant experiences to share. Secondly, it was designed to prompt reflection on either personal experiences or second-hand accounts of offence, fostering a sense of openness.

By giving the participants, the option to narrate either their own experience or someone else’s, the question fulfilled two key purposes. First, it reduced the pressure participants might feel when sharing personal and sensitive experiences. Second, it allowed for the collection of diverse perspectives on offence, whether participants were directly involved in the event or recounting the experience of someone they know.

Part two included two open-ended questions for participants who answered ‘Yes’ in Part One. The

first prompt asked, “*tell us more about it (where did it happen or the person you know? and what exactly happened)*”? This question invited participants to reconstruct the incident in detail, allowing for an in-depth exploration of the context and the circumstances surrounding the act. By asking ‘*where*’ and ‘*what happened*’, the question aimed to gather critical details that contribute to the understanding of the perceived offence. To explain in detail, ‘Where’ provided insight into the setting which could influence social norms and expectations, while ‘what happened’ captured the specific actions or words that triggered the offence revealing the behaviour that was evaluated as offensive.

The final question in the diary report was “*How did this situation make you feel, and why?*” This question aimed to explore both the emotional and interpretative aspects of the participant’s experience. By asking “how,” it examined the participants’ emotional reactions, shedding light on the nature of their feelings, such as anger, shame or disappointment. These emotions are significant because individuals tend to react strongly when something they care deeply about is violated (Miller, 1993). The “why” component complemented this by delving deeper into the reasoning behind these emotional responses, uncovering the underlying expectations that were breached. This aspect was critical in this study because it provided insight into the participants’ interpretations of the incidents and expectations they believed were violated. Understanding *why* participants felt the way they did allowed the research to move beyond the trigger which is available at the surface-level to trigger to explore the broader expectations that informed their perceptions of offence. See a copy of the Taking Offence diary report (the original Arabic version) Appendix [A] and English version Appendix [E]

3.8.2.2 Diary Report 2: Incivility

Part One consisted of a single Yes/No question which stated, “*In your daily life, have you ever encountered or witnessed behaviour that you consider inappropriate or unacceptable in public spaces?*” This question served as a filter to identify participants with relevant experiences of *incivility*, ensuring that only those with such experience proceeded to the open-ended questions in *Part Two*. The inclusion of ‘*public spaces*’ narrowed the scope of the inquiry to behaviours observed or experienced in a public environment, which aligns with what this study focuses on.

Part Two, consisted of two open-ended questions for participants who answered ‘Yes’ in the first part of the diary report. Participants were asked “where and what exactly happened”. The ‘where’ aspect of the question was particularly significant in the context of incivility as the location provided context for understanding why certain behaviours were perceived as uncivil in specific environments. Identifying the “where” offered a clearer understanding of the expectations of behaviour tied to the location.

It was followed by the question “*How did you feel at that moment, and why?*” This question served a dual purpose. First, it aimed to explore the participants’ immediate emotional reaction to the uncivil behaviour. Secondly, the follow up query “*why*” was particularly crucial in this study, especially when considered alongside the previous questions. It encouraged participants to reflect more deeply on the incidents, guiding them through this question to articulate the reasons behind their feelings. This reasoning offered valuable insights into the specific norms participants believed had been violated. See a copy of the Incivility diary report (the original Arabic version) Appendix [A] and English version Appendix [F].

3.8.3 Selection of Participants:

The participants of the diary report were carefully selected to ensure a diverse range of perspectives on offence and incivility within Omani society. The recruitment process was designed to capture a broad cross-section of the Omani population, emphasising participants’ lived experiences and perceptions rather than specific demographics characteristics such as age, gender, social role or educational background. The decision not to collect demographic information was intentional and aligned with the study’s objective. Collecting demographic data might have shifted the emphasis towards analysing how demographics might shape perception, potentially detracting from the core aim of uncovering shared norms, and expectations. While demographic differences in evaluating the perceived offence and incivility might be important in future research, this study prioritised an inclusive and exploratory framework to capture the complexity of these phenomena across Omani society.

To achieve this, the participants for this study were selected strategically using two primary sampling methods: snowball sampling for online recruitment and purposive sampling for in-person recruitment. These methods were employed to ensure the inclusion of participants from diverse walks of life while achieving both depth and breadth in the data collection (Teddlie & Yu, 2009). The practical implementation of these strategies is detailed in the diary report distribution section. It is important to note that the participants for the diary report on *Taking Offence* and *Incivility* were intentionally selected as separate groups. This approach was adopted to avoid any potential confusion between offensive behaviour and uncivil acts. By using distinct samples for each study, the research ensured that the participants could focus exclusively on the specific concept being explored, enhancing the reliability and clarity of the data collected.

3.8.4 Diary Report Distribution

To operationalise the sampling strategies outlined in the previous section, this study used both online and paper-based diary reports to collect data from Omani participants. Online diary reports were distributed via WhatsApp, leveraging snowball sampling to reach a broad network of participants. In contrast, the paper-based diary reports were shared in public spaces through purposive sampling to engage participants from diverse backgrounds. This combined approach allowed for a wide range of participants to share their experiences. The details of each distribution method are provided in the following subsection:

3.8.4.1 Online Distribution via WhatsApp

Online diary reports were initially distributed via WhatsApp using a snowball sampling method. This is a recruitment strategy that relies on recruiting participants through existing social networks (Dattalo, 2008), making it particularly useful for identifying participants who are otherwise difficult to locate (Biernacki & Waldorf, 1981). Since this research was conducted in the UK, while the target participants were based in Oman, snowball sampling was chosen as a practical approach to bridge geographical and logistical challenges and to effectively reach participants who might not have been accessible through traditional recruitment methods. This method relied on referrals, leveraging the social networks of initial participants to connect with a broader pool of relevant individuals. To begin the process, the diary report link, hosted on the Online Surveys platform, was shared via WhatsApp with a small group of participants who met the study's criteria- Omani individuals. While this approach facilitated access to a broader pool of participants through referrals, it is recognised that the contacts within the initial circle of participants may lack the diversity required, as individuals within the same social network might often exhibit shared characteristics, such as educational level, socioeconomic status, or personal values.

However, efforts were made to encourage participants to share the link across diverse social groups, thereby mitigating this limitation and enhancing the diversity of the sample. Each participant provided referrals to additional participants which created a chain of contacts. This process expanded the network of participants allowing the study to access a broader and more diverse pool of individuals.

WhatsApp was selected as the platform for distributing the online diary report link because it is the most widely used social media application in Oman. According to data shared by the Ministry of Transport, Communication and Information Technology (2020), approximately 92% of individuals over the age of 18 in Oman use WhatsApp. Unlike platforms dominated by specific age groups or educational levels, WhatsApp is used by a broad cross-section of society, making it an ideal tool for

reaching a diverse range of participants. Additionally, WhatsApp provided participants with a convenient way to access the diary report, allowing them to complete it at a time and place that suited their schedules.

Furthermore, WhatsApp was also chosen for its functionality, which allowed the researcher to share the diary report link effectively beyond her immediate network. Using a friends-of-friends approach, the link reached participants across different regions of Oman, enabling the study to include a more diverse range of experiences. In addition to its reach, WhatsApp offered participants a private and convenient way to access the diary report. Receiving the link in a personal and comfortable environment likely encouraged participants to respond more openly. They completed the diary report at their own pace, free from the pressures of time constraints or the need for immediate submission. However, despite these advantages, challenges arose during the data collection process when reviewing the results midway. It became evident that some participants skipped questions or provided limited responses.

The absence of direct engagement appeared to reduce the participants' motivation to fully answer the questions or reflect deeply on the incidents they experienced. This observation underscored a key drawback of relying solely on an online method, as participants might not engage thoroughly when completing the report independently. Consequently, the need for a more interactive and supportive method became clear.

3.8.4.2 Paper-Based Diary report Distribution

To address the limitations observed in the online reports results, paper-based diary reports were immediately incorporated. The distribution of these reports followed a purposive sampling strategy targeting public spaces in Muscat such as cafes, parks and markets.

These locations were selected for their potential to attract a diverse mix of Omani people, offering an ideal environment for collecting varied perspectives on offence and incivility within Omani society. Purposive sampling is particularly suited for this study in which participants are chosen based on their relevance to the research topic, as it allows researchers to focus on individuals likely to provide rich and meaningful data (Etikan, Musa & Alkassim, 2016). This approach also accounted for practical considerations, such as the access to these public spaces and the need for an efficient, cost-effective recruitment process. Public space required minimal logistical arrangement and allowed for timely recruitment of participants, making them a suitable choice.

The participants were approached directly by the assistants of the researcher who lived in Oman, my

sisters, after being thoroughly briefed about the project and its objectives. Their presence during the distribution allowed for more direct engagement with participants, encouraging participants to complete the diary report while addressing any uncertainties. This interaction reduced the likelihood of skipped questions and contributed to more thoughtful responses. Additionally, the assistants' presence fostered a sense of accountability; knowing that someone would follow up or return to collect the completed report reinforced the importance of their participation and encouraged them to complete the diary report conscientiously.

Participants who agreed to complete the diary report were given time to do so, with flexibility built into the process. While some participants completed the diary report on the spot, others requested additional time. In such cases, the assistants accommodated their preferences by exchanging contact numbers, allowing participants to send a picture of the completed report via WhatsApp later. Additionally, some participants requested the assistant to return at a specified time to collect the completed diary report in person. This flexible and participant-centred approach was instrumental in maintaining engagement and ensuring high quality responses. Participants were not rushed, creating an environment where they could reflect thoughtfully on their experiences.

At the same time, they were encouraged to answer all questions, resulting in richer and more complete data. Moreover, the personal follow-up for those who chose to send their responses later via WhatsApp significantly improved response rates, underscoring the value of direct interaction and personalised support in the data collection process. The integration of both online and paper-based diary reports was pivotal in this study. The online distribution via WhatsApp ensured wide reach and accessibility, capturing a diverse range of participants, while the paper-based method fostered deeper engagement, resulting in more detailed and thoughtful responses. This complementary use of methods enabled a comprehensive exploration of the phenomena of *Taking Offence* and *Incivility*. The next section delves into the process of cleaning the diary report preparing it for the analysis.

3.8.5 Cleaning the Diary Report Data

In Phase Two of the research, data cleaning was a crucial step before conducting thematic analysis. Since the data was collected through two methods, paper-based and online, several key tasks were involved in the cleaning process. It is important to note that the diary reports related to the topics *Taking Offence* and *Incivility* were cleaned separately. However, the cleaning process for both topics has a similar approach.

Firstly, the responses from the paper-based diary reports were manually transcribed into a digital

format to prepare them for the analysis phase. This step involved typing all the responses carefully into a Word document, ensuring that no data was omitted during transcription. However, one challenge encountered during this process was occasional difficulty in reading some handwriting. To address this, I consulted my assistants several times to clarify the content, ensuring the data remained as accurate and complete as possible.

Furthermore, the inconsistencies in the data were addressed. These inconsistencies included skipped questions, lack of detail in responses, and occasional spelling errors. Skipped questions were more prevalent in the online diary reports. For instance, in the *Taking Offence* diary report, some participants did not answer the follow-up question (Part Two), which asked, “How did this situation make you feel, and why?”. This omission created a gap in understanding the data, as the question was essential for understanding the expectations that were violated rather than merely identifying the act of violation itself. Similarly, in the *Incivility* diary report, some participants provided partial answers. For example, participants often answered questions about the location and nature of the uncivil act but left the follow-up question, “*How did you feel at that moment, and why?*” unanswered or provided minimal information. To address these issues, I implemented a structured approach. To explain, skipped or incomplete responses were reviewed on a case-by-case basis. Entries that provided meaningful insights, even with minor omissions, were retained, while those lacking substantive information were excluded.

Another issue addressed during the data cleaning process was spelling errors, which were particularly relevant because the diary reports were written in a mix of colloquial and standard Arabic. Colloquial Arabic, being primarily spoken and lacking formal spelling rules, often led to inconsistencies in how words were written. Meanwhile, errors in standard Arabic reflected challenges in switching between the two forms of the language. During the digitisation process, I corrected obvious spelling mistakes for clarity while ensuring the authenticity of the participants’ language was maintained. Preserving the original linguistic expression was crucial, as both colloquial and standard Arabic convey important contextual and cultural meaning that is central to understanding *Taking Offence* and *Incivility*.

3.8.6 Phase 2: Diary Report Data Analysis

Similar to the analysis of Twitter data in section (3.5.4.3), thematic analysis was employed in phase 2 to identify, analyse, and interpret patterns within the diary reports collected for both *Taking Offence* and *Incivility*. However, unlike the X data analysis, where thematic analysis was informed by prior quantitative findings, the thematic analysis in this phase was purely qualitative and grounded in the

raw data and uninfluenced by previous analysis. To analyse the diary report data, Braun and Clarke's six-phase framework as outlined in table (3.3) was applied, ensuring a systematic approach to identifying patterns and themes. NVivo software was utilised to manage and organise the data, streamlining the coding process. The software allowed efficient categorisation of the data at multiple levels, including organisation according to the structure of the diary report questions, and a deeper organisation at the level of themes within the responses. This structured approach facilitated a thorough analysis allowing for the identification of meaningful patterns and insights.

3.8.6.1 Conducting the thematic analysis

The thematic analysis began with familiarising myself with the data. At this initial stage, the diary report data, which had been cleaned and organised in Word files, was imported into Nvivo. I immersed myself in the data by reading through the diary entries multiple times to gain a thorough understanding of their content. This familiarisation process was crucial for identifying initial recurring ideas, and initial impressions that informed subsequent stages of the analysis.

After becoming familiar with the data, I proceeded to generate initial codes in NVivo, the coding process was guided by the structure of the diary report, with each question serving as a framework for organising the responses (see Figure 3.5). I highlighted relevant portions of the text and assigned a descriptive label to them. Each diary entry was analysed line by line, ensuring no significant detail was overlooked.

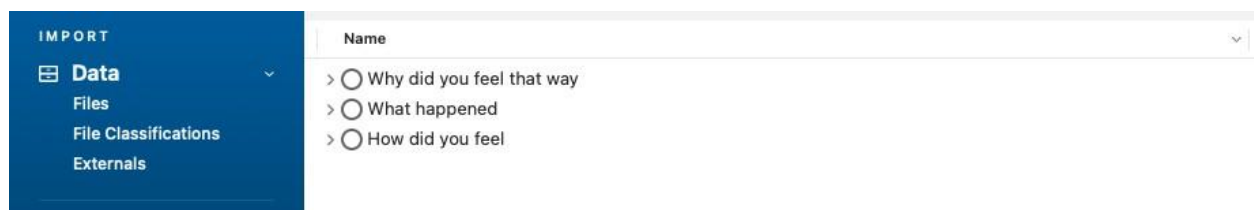


Figure 3.5: The initial guiding structure to code the responses

The initial codes for the diary entry question "what happened?" reflected actions described by the participants that had made them take offence and were considered uncivil. At this point, the focus was on identifying and categorising the explicit behaviours or events mentioned in the responses, such as specific actions, words, or gestures that participants highlighted as problematic. These codes were grounded in the semantic content of the data, emphasising a detailed descriptive presentation of the participants' experiences without delving into deeper interpretation. This approach ensured that the coding process captured the participants as they were expressed, providing a clear structured foundation for the later stages of the analysis where patterns and broader themes code

could be identified. By systematically coding these behaviours, the analysis began to reveal recurring actions that contributed to feelings of offence and perceptions of incivility. As the analysis progressed, I began grouping related codes into broader categories that captured common ideas (see Figure 3.6 for taking offence and Figure 3.7 for incivility).

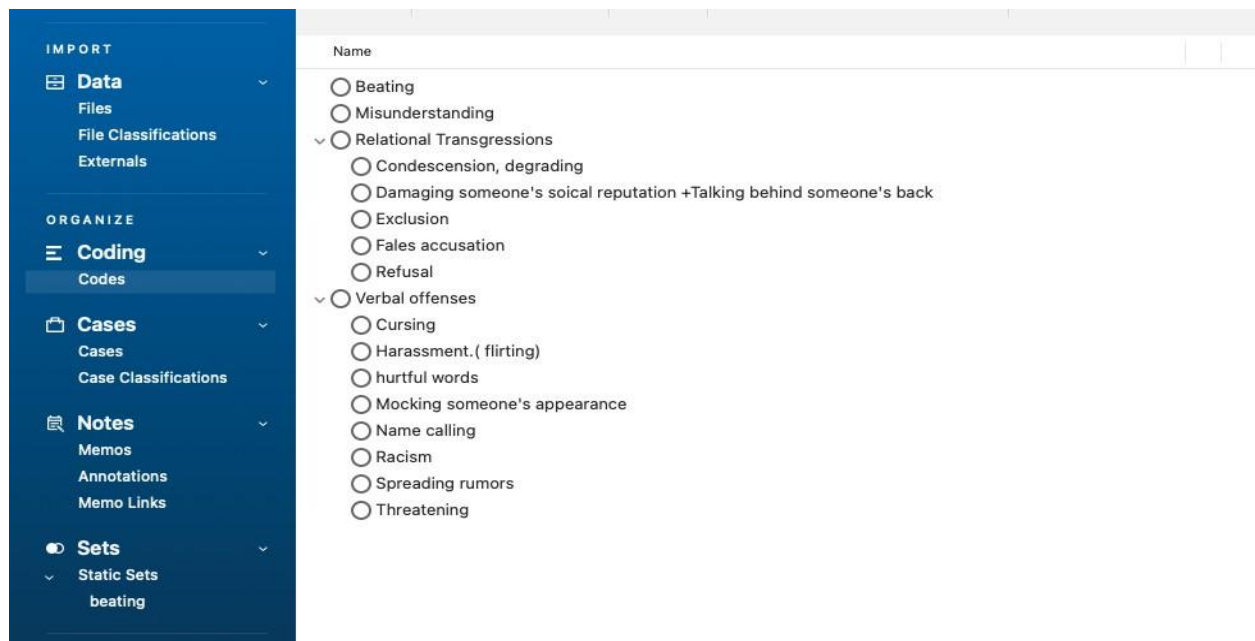


Figure 3.6: Coding of taking offence

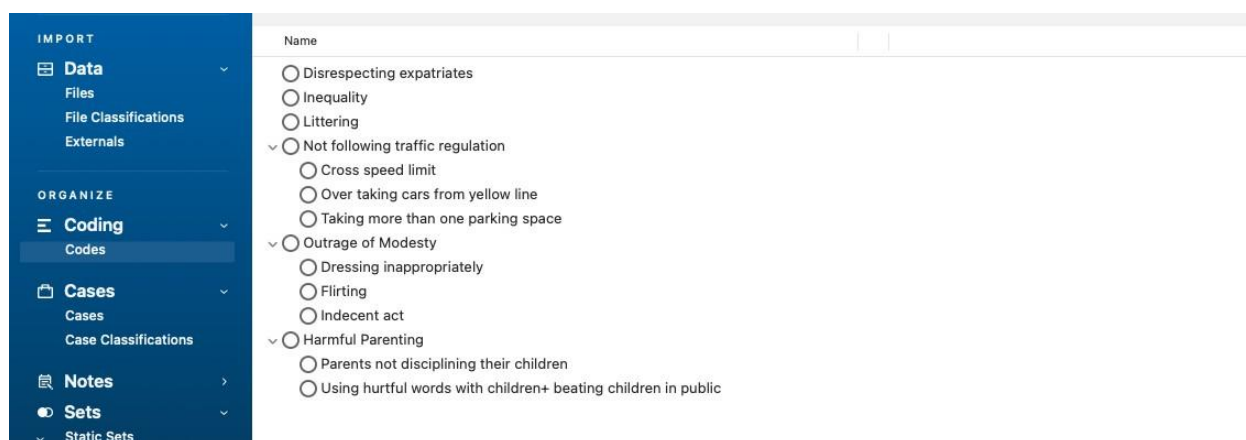


Figure 3.7: Coding of incivility

For example, codes such as “false accusation” and “exclusion” were grouped under the category “Relational Transgression” reflecting behaviours that explicitly violated interpersonal expectations. Similarly, with incivility, codes like “crossing speed limit”, “overtaking cars from yellow line” and “taking more than one parking space” were categorised under “Not Following Traffic Regulations” which encompassed behaviours that explicitly broke societal rules of traffic.

While these categories were meaningful and captured the semantic content of participants’ experiences, they remained descriptive in nature, focusing on what was explicitly stated in the data. To achieve a deeper understanding, it was essential to go beyond the surface-level description and analyse the latent meaning embedded within the accounts. This required exploring both the implicit and explicit assumptions, expectations, and social norms that influenced how the behaviours were perceived and evaluated. According to Braun and Clarke (2006, p.82), a theme “captures something important about the data in relation to the research question and represents some level of patterned response or meaning within the data set”. This perspective guided the analysis towards identifying broader themes that reflected underlying norms and expectations shaping participants’ responses. The process moved beyond the trigger, the behaviour itself, to explore the reasons why certain behaviours were considered offensive or uncivil, and to uncover the deeper personal, social, and cultural principles at play.

The themes were then further refined to ensure they accurately represented the underlying norms and expectations. This involved a careful examination to confirm that each theme captured the essence of the participants’ responses and was well-supported by the data. The refinement process also ensured that the themes were distinct from one another while collectively contributing to a cohesive narrative.

Themes that initially appeared overlapping were clarified and subdivided to better reflect the data. For example, themes such as “Traffic Regulation Norms” and “Respecting Public Spaces Norms” were initially grouped under one theme. However, upon further refinement, it became evident that these themes addressed distinct aspects of violated norms. Separating them ensured that each theme distinctly captured a type of broken norm. This refinement process enhanced both the clarity and the focus of the analysis.

Following this, themes were named and defined to ensure they represented the core idea and aligned closely with the research questions. For instance, the theme “Adhering to Public Decency” was defined as the societal expectation to maintain appropriate behaviour in public spaces. This theme

encompassed incidents such as dressing inappropriately or engaging in behaviours considered obscene in public.

In the final step of thematic analysis, the themes were synthesised into a coherent narrative, ensuring that they reflected the participants' experiences and perceptions of taking offence and incivility in Oman. The examples provided by participants were used to illustrate the various ways norms and expectations were violated and how such violations shaped their understanding of perceived offence and incivility. Each theme was supported by data extracts that provided rich, detailed insights into how and why certain behaviours were considered offensive or uncivil. This comprehensive approach ensured that the analysis was deeply rooted in the participants' lived experiences, providing a thorough representation of what makes Omani people take offence and the norms that shape their understanding of incivility within Omani society. The next section focuses on the theoretical framework that informed the analysis of this research.

3.9 Conceptual Framework

This study adapted the prismatic model of (im)politeness- as- perspective (Haugh, 2024) as the overarching conceptual structure for exploring the norms and expectations underlying perceptions of offence and incivility. The prismatic model provides a dynamic and multidimensional framework that moves beyond the typical binary distinction between first-order politeness and second-order politeness perspectives to capture the interplay between multiple layers of understanding (see Figure 3.8)

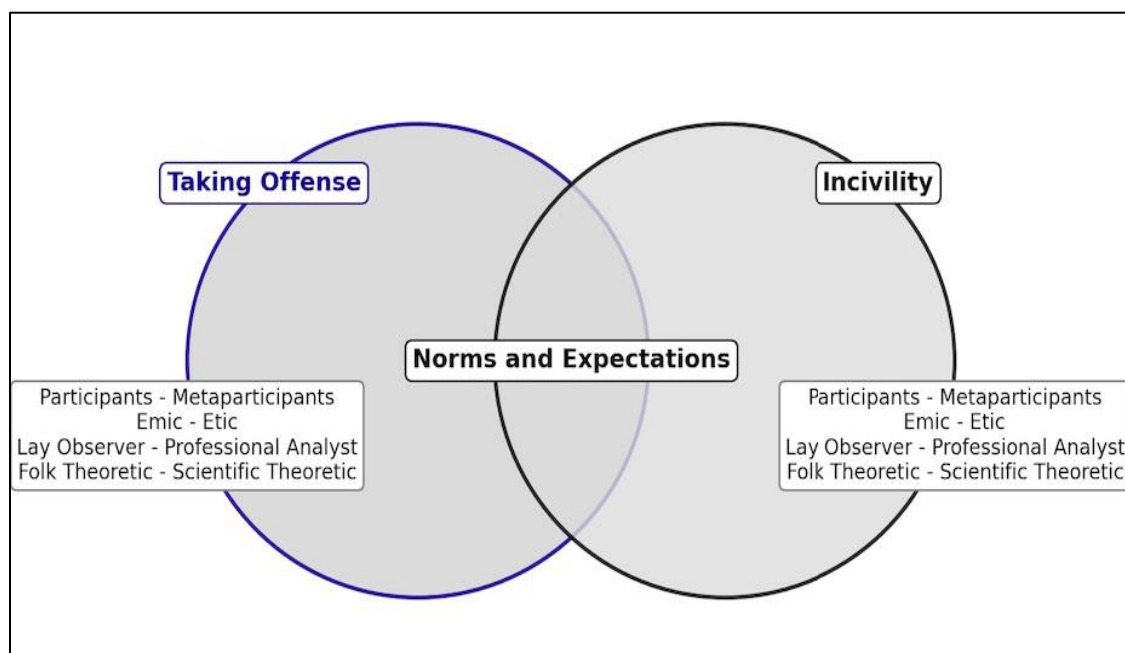


Figure 3.8: Impoliteness as perspective (Haugh, 2024): integrating multiple perspectives for taking offence and incivility.

Its model purpose by encompasses four different loci of understanding:

1. **Participant- meta-participant:** The viewpoint of those directly engaged in an interaction; they are the (participants) narrating their personal experiences in the diary reports. Whereas (meta-participants) represent an understanding of individuals who are not directly involved in an event but engage with it through the actions or experiences of others, typically by observing, narrating, or commenting on it (Kadar & Haugh, 2013). They include some of the diary report narrators and X commenters.
2. **Emic-etic:** The emic perspective refers to the understanding of the insider, how members of a culture or community perceive, categorise, and interpret their own world (Kadar & Haugh, 2013). The way to elicit the emic perspective is to ask people about what they think and feel to uncover how they make sense of their experiences. In this research, the emic perspective is accessed through the narratives of Omani participants in X and the diary report, which reveal how culturally specific expectations and norms influence their judgements of what is considered offensive or uncivil.

Understanding the emic perspective involves identifying culturally specific judgements about what is considered “constructive” and “nonconstructive” and exploring how thoughts and behaviours are evaluated as “appropriate or inappropriate” within their social context based on the assumption that individuals have internalised cultural norms and expectations that guide these evaluations. Through these insights, emic analysis seeks to describe the underlying “program” that shapes native judgements of contrast and appropriateness (Harris, 1976, p.8). Whereas (etic) is “an understanding formulated in terms of conceptual schemes and categories regarded as meaningful and appropriate to outsiders, that is those who are treated as lying outside the relational network in question” (Kadar & Haugh, 2013, p.102). The etic perspective in this research is the researcher bringing her own structure and system and her observations of the inside view, interpreting the inside in reference to the outside starting point.
3. **Lay observer-professional analyst:** It is an understanding that emerges from non-expert individuals who describe behaviours based on everyday understanding, without formal theoretical grounding. In my research, the lay observers were the meta-participants in X and the participants in the diary reports who described their experiences of offence and incivility based

on their everyday understanding. In contrast, the professional analyst perspective involves my role as the researcher, where I systematically interpret these evaluative moments using evidence-based interpretation methods such as corpus analysis and thematic analysis.

4. **Folk theoretic- scientific theoretic:** Understanding is derived from personal experiences, cultural beliefs, and social interactions rather than from scientific reasoning. In this research, the folk theoretic perspective was reflected in the participants' diary reports, where their understanding of what they consider offensive and uncivil was derived from personal experiences, cultural beliefs, and social interactions. These narratives provide insights into everyday, intuitive evaluations. Whereas (scientific-theoretic) refers to an understanding that involves systematically defined and formalised interpretations of interpersonal phenomena, developed and shared among scientific researchers. In this research, I adapted a theoretical framework and employed certain analysis methods such as corpus analysis and thematic analysis to formalise the intuitive narratives provided by the participants.

Having established how this study adapted the prismatic model of (im)politeness- as- perspective (Haugh, 2024) and how each perspective informed the analysis of the phenomena of taking offence and incivility, the discussion now turns to the scientific-theoretical dimension in more detail, where the analytical framework guiding this study is explained.

3.7.1 Adapting Spencer-Oatey's framework

Within the scientific-theoretic dimension of the prismatic model that was introduced in the previous section (see Section 3.7), this research developed a working theoretical framework informed by Spencer-Oatey's (2000) bases of rapport management framework to further analyse the phenomena of taking offence and incivility (see Figure 3.9). The decision to adapt Spencer-Oatey's framework was not predetermined; rather, it emerged from the inductive analysis (see Section 3.1 for detailed explanation of the inductive and deductive analytic approach). Consequently, the framework is not applied as a fixed model but rather evolved through engagement with the data. In the early stages of thematic analysis, the inductive processes of categorisation and coding revealed recurrent patterns that reflected a strong concern with how individuals wished to be perceived as individuals and as members of wider community and in relation to others. These concerns mapped closely onto Spencer-Oatey's notions of face sensitivities, and sociality rights and obligations, which provided a lens for understanding the underlying norms and expectations evident in the data. These emergent patterns, therefore, informed the decision to integrate and adapt Spencer' Oatey's framework for this study.

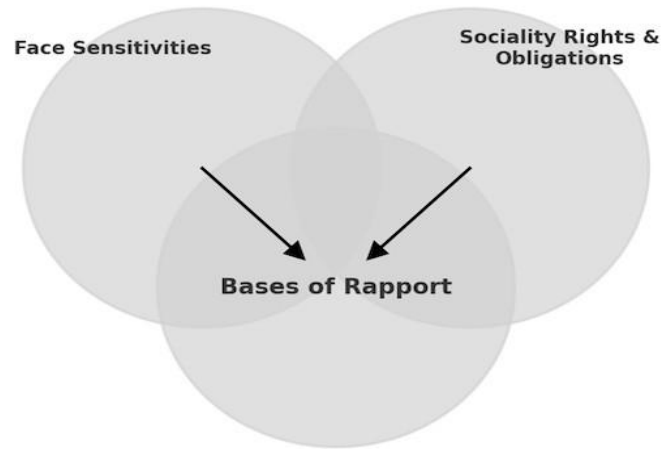


Figure 3.9: Adapted version of bases of management rapport
(Spencer- Oatey, 2008)

While Spencer-Oatey's model aligned closely with the concerns emerging from the data, it was also important to recognise that this model is considered a Western model, grounded in a predominantly Western scholarly tradition, and developed through analyses of Western sociocultural contexts. Its use in this study was therefore not prescriptive but reflexive, meaning that the framework was adapted critically with attention to both my insider understanding of Omani cultural norms and to the meanings and evaluative patterns expressed by participants. The need for this adaptation also arose from the fact that Omani data showed patterns of judgement that extended beyond what the original Western model was designed to accommodate. Therefore, this reflexive adaptation ensured that the framework reflected the cultural priorities and normative expectations evident in the Omani data, allowing the analysis to remain aligned with the lived realities and the evaluative judgements articulated by participants.

The decision to adapt this model was also driven by the need for a solid analytical tool for this research. Although the model originates in Western contexts and does not fully capture all aspects of offence and incivility in the Omani context, it nonetheless provides a robust foundation to support the analysis. This choice was further shaped by the fact that existing models grounded in Arab societies do not currently offer a fully developed analytical framework suitable for the type of analysis conducted in this research. There are, however, many contributions ranging from early studies to more recent studies, such as Feghail (1997) and Al Zidjaly (2009, 2017) that offer culturally distinctive patterns in Arabic speaking contexts. While these works enrich understanding and help to inform research in the region, they do not extend to an analytical model that can be systematically applied to the type of analysis

undertaken here. Having established the justification for adapting Spencer-Oatey's model, the following section will outline the core elements of the framework to show how it informs the analysis presented in this study.

One of the central components of this model is the notion of face sensitivities, as outlined in Spencer-Oatey's (2008) rapport management framework. In this research, face sensitivities act as a rationale for understanding people's evaluative judgements of perceived offence and incivility. They provide a lens for understanding how individuals assess behaviour in relation to their sense of worth, dignity, and socially valued attributes such as respect, honour, status, and reputation, and competence. The concept of face in Spencer's model (2008) is understood through three dimensions of identity, the self as an individual, the self as a member of a group and the self in relationship with others. Table 3.4 below summarises how face is understood in this research, drawing on Goffman's foundational definition and Spencer-Oatey's distinction between quality face and social identity face. In this study, these dimensions were adapted as analytic guides for interpreting the face related concerns evident in the data. This adaptation provided a structured way of examining how participants anchored their evaluation in different aspects of self.

Face is defined with reference to Goffman (1967,p.5): "the positive social <i>value</i> a person effectively claims for himself [<i>sic</i>] by the line others assume he has taken during a particular contact" (2008, p.13)	Quality face (related to the self as an individual): "We have a fundamental desire for people to evaluate us positively in terms of our personal qualities, e.g. our confidence, abilities, appearance, etc." (2002, p. 540)
	Social identity face (related to the self as a group member): "We have a fundamental desire for people to acknowledge and uphold our social identities or roles" (2002, p.540); "[social identity face involves] any group that a person is a member of and is concerned about. This can include small groups like one's family, and larger groups like one's ethnic group, religious group, or nationality group" (2005,p.106).

Sociality Rights and Obligations are defined as “rights are the things that people feel entitled to expect from others and obligations are the things they feel others should do”(Spencer-Oatey& Kádár, 2021, p.138).	Equity rights: "We have a fundamental belief that we are entitled to personal consideration from others, so that we are treated fairly: that we are not unduly imposed upon that we are not unfairly ordered about, and that we are not taken advantage of or exploited" (2008, p.16)
	Association rights: "We have a fundamental belief that we are entitled to social involvement with others, in keeping with the type of relationship that we have with them." (2008, p. 16)

Table 3.4: Categories in rapport management

The second component of the model concerns sociality rights and obligations, which provide a basis for interpreting participants' evaluations of behaviours they described as offensive or uncivil (Spencer-Oatey & Kadar, 2021). Sociality rights are used to identify the expectations participants hold regarding what they believe they are entitled to receive from others in everyday life, while sociality obligations are used to capture what they believe others are obligated to do or refrain from doing (Spencer-Oatey & Kadar, 2021). In this research, sociality rights and obligations guide the analysis by directing attention to moments in participants' accounts where they refer to expectations they feel have not been met and to duties, they believe others should either carry out or avoid breaching. However, it must be noted that Spencer-Oatey's framework model, as outlined in Table 3.4, specifies only two types of sociality rights, equity rights and association rights, and describes sociality obligations in broad terms. These rights categories are drawn on in this study because they align with the expectations reflected in participants' accounts, although they do not encompass the full range of sociocultural expectations and norms evident in the data. Likewise, the model's broad description of obligations provides a useful reference point but does not account for the types of obligations participants alluded to. Therefore, while Spencer-Oatey's conceptualisation of sociality rights and obligations remains analytically valuable for this study, the model's existing subcategories do not fully capture the breadth of expectations evident in participants' accounts. The analysis in this study therefore builds on these two main categories by identifying additional context-specific forms

of rights and obligations that emerged inductively from the data. These further rights and obligations are presented and discussed in detail in the data analysis chapters.

3.10 Data Analysis Approach: inductive and deductive analysis

Building on the theoretical framework discussed in the previous section, this study adopted a hybrid thematic analysis approach to analyse the data in both research phases, where it incorporated inductive and deductive analysis. The process primarily started with inductive analysis, as it focused on identifying patterns that emerged from participants' evaluations. However, the analysis was also guided by deductive analysis, drawing on pre-existing concepts and the theoretical framework underpinning the study. This hybrid approach ensured that the analysis was rooted in the data while being supported by the theoretical lens, allowing for a robust exploration of the phenomena.

The inductive aspect of the hybrid analysis was essential for ensuring that the findings were rooted in participants' lived experiences and narratives. An inductive approach to thematic analysis, as described by Braun and Clarke (2006), involves generating codes and themes directly from the raw data, without being constrained by pre-existing theoretical categories. This process enabled the recognition of patterns that emerged from participants' accounts, capturing both personal experiences and perspectives shaped by indirect engagement through witnessing events or recounting others' experiences of offence and incivility. It also facilitated an understanding of how individuals, as members of their own cultural and social environments, made sense of offence and incivility, revealing recurring themes in how behaviours were interpreted. It also brought to light culturally specific context-sensitive patterns shedding light on social and cultural dimensions shaping these patterns. This approach further uncovered unexpected findings, including subtle norms that were particularly significant in shaping participants' evaluations of offence and incivility. These insights, which might otherwise have been overlooked, offered a deeper understanding of what participants considered offensive and uncivil within their specific social contexts.

Simultaneously, the deductive aspect of the analysis served as a guiding lens throughout the entire analysis process, alternating between operating in the background and moving into the foreground. In the early stages of the analysis, the deductive approach primarily operated in the background, serving as a subtle yet active guide. Although the analysis at this stage focused on data-driven exploration, the deductive approach subtly influenced the focus of the coding process. To explain, by aligning the coding process with the study's core constructs of offence and incivility, the deductive approach provided structure and focus. It ensured that the coding did not simply categorise behaviours labelled as 'offensive' and 'uncivil' but systematically captured key details about these incidents. This

included identifying the specific behaviours described (e.g., accusing someone, dressing immodestly), the context in which they occurred (e.g., road, park), and participants' evaluations of why these behaviours were offensive or uncivil. In this way, the deductive framework provided direction and coherence to the analysis, even in the early stages, by ensuring that attention was systematically guided toward relevant aspects of the data, thereby laying the foundation for deeper exploration of norms and expectations in the later stages of the analysis.

As the analysis advanced, the deductive approach moved into the foreground, where it played a more explicit role in naming and refining the themes and synthesising them into narratives. While the analysis was initially guided by participants' explicit and implicit evaluations of taking offence and incivility, the patterns that emerged from the data highlighted recurring structures in how these behaviours were interpreted and evaluated. These structures revealed stable patterns in the reasoning participants used to make sense of their experiences, reflecting shared social norms and expectations. As these patterns became more evident, a systematic theoretical interpretation was required to refine and contextualise the findings.

This shift emphasised the integration of theoretical grounding, ensuring that patterns were supported by broader analytical frameworks while remaining informed by participants' perspectives. To achieve this, the analysis adapted the bases of Rapport Management framework which was modified to align with the dynamics revealed in the data. By adapting this framework, the analysis systematically connected participants' evaluations to broader constructs that underpin them, such as face sensitivities and sociality rights and obligations.

For instance, one recurring pattern in the data involved participants expressing feeling offended because they were not allowed to express themselves. This was initially coded inductively as being silenced. However, as these patterns became more evident, these instances were interpreted through the lens of association rights. It reflected an unfulfilment of association rights, which concerns individuals' expectations to be included in interaction. The combination of inductive and deductive framing thus helped clarify not just what was offensive but *why* the participants evaluated it as offensive.

By integrating inductive and deductive analysis, this study provided a comprehensive understanding of taking offence and incivility, bridging participant- driven insights with established theoretical structures. The inductive phase led the analysis, allowing patterns to be identified from participants' evaluations, while deductive analysis remained in the background. As the analysis progressed,

deductive analysis took on a more prominent role, structuring these insights within broader theoretical perspectives. This interplay ensured that theoretical perspectives supported rather than overshadowed participant perspectives, reinforcing the hybrid analysis as essential for capturing both lived experiences and the underlying normative structures shaping the evaluations.

3.11 Translation of Data

In this research, the source language of the data gathered from X and the diary report was Arabic, while the target language used for reporting in this thesis was English. The decision to translate was essential to ensure the accessibility of the findings to an English-speaking academic audience and to align with the requirements of the thesis. This study required translating data that involved both colloquial Arabic and standard Arabic. Respondents used these forms of Arabic to narrate their stories, using the language they most preferred for sharing their experiences. Translation, as defined by Temple and Yong (2004), is “the process of transferring the meaning contained in one set of linguistic symbols to another across languages and cultures” (p.164). This highlights the complexity of translation, which extends beyond linguistic equivalence to include cultural understanding and contextual accuracy.

One of the primary challenges I encountered during the translation process was ensuring that the cultural meaning of the expressions was retained. As Simon (1996) notes “translators must constantly make decisions about the cultural meanings which language carries and evaluates the degree to which the two different worlds they inhabit are the same” (p.8). This required careful assessment of whether specific expressions or terms in Arabic had an equivalent in English and determining the best way to present the original meaning without compromising its cultural significance. For instance, in some cases, literal translation risked losing the original intent, while overly interpretive translation risked altering the meaning altogether. My insider role as both researcher and translator enabled me to navigate these complexities effectively, drawing on my familiarity with the cultural and linguistic nuances of the participants’ language.

The translation process was a critical component of this research, as the reliability of the findings depended on the accuracy and integrity of the translated material. Twinn (1997) emphasises that inaccuracies in translation can distort the meaning of the data and compromise the validity of research outcomes. Recognising this, the research employed a rigorous translation approach that aimed to preserve both the linguistic and cultural integrity of the original data. To further enhance accuracy, I collaborated with a certified translator who was also Omani and deeply familiar with the cultural and linguistic context of the participants. This collaboration complemented my insider

knowledge, allowing us to address cultural subtleties and linguistic ambiguities more effectively.

3.12 Ethical Consideration

The ethical considerations were a fundamental aspect of this research and were addressed at every stage of the study. Before any data collection commenced, this study received ethical approval from the Faculty Research Panel at Anglia Ruskin University. Given that two data collection methods were employed in this study, X and diary reports forms, the ethical considerations for each will be discussed separately. The ethics of using data collected from X has been, and continues to be, a topic of debate across disciplines, including the humanities and social sciences (Taylor & Pagliari, 2017). A central issue in this debate is whether the consent of social media users is required for research purposes (Samuel & Buchanan, 2020). Samuel, Ahmed, Kara, Jessop, Quinton, and Sanger, (2018) and Zimmer (2020) argue that the mere fact that data is publicly available does not automatically make its use in research ethical, as some content, despite being accessible, may still be in some way private.

Nevertheless, X's policy explicitly states that "By publicly posting content when you tweet, you are directing us to disclose that information as broadly as possible...to make that information available to websites, apps, and others for their use - for example, displaying tweets on a news website or analysing what people say on Twitter" ¹. This policy makes it clear that users who choose to post publicly are made aware upon registration, that their content can be used beyond the platform. Therefore, unless X revises its policies, the use of publicly available posts in research remains ethically permissible.

In addition to the aforementioned ethical concerns, anonymity is a critical aspect that must be carefully considered in research involving publicly available social media data. While X's policy permits the use of publicly accessible information, including usernames, ethical guidelines for research mandate the protection of user identities, requiring that all identifying details, such as usernames, profile pictures, and account handles, be anonymised or removed in accordance with established ethical guidelines (GSR, 2006).

While the ethical considerations for X focused on issues related to consent and data usage policies, the diary report required a different ethical approach due to the direct involvement of participants. Unlike X, where data was publicly available, the diary report involved individuals sharing personal experiences, necessitating strict adherence to ethical guidelines to protect their anonymity, ensure voluntary participation, and safeguard their well-being.

Before participation, individuals were fully informed about the purpose and objectives of the study through a detailed participant information sheet and informed consent was obtained. Participants were made aware of how their responses would be used and their right to withdraw at any stage before data analysis without providing a reason. Participation was entirely voluntary, with no obligation to complete the report. Copies of the consent form and participants' information are provided in the Appendix [B].

To maintain anonymity and confidentiality, no personal information was intentionally collected; however, any identifying details that participants voluntarily included in their responses, such as names, were removed during data cleaning. In line with these measures, all responses were securely stored in a protected file, ensuring compliance with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and the Data Protection Act (2018). Access to the data was strictly limited, with only the researcher having permission to view the files, further safeguarding participants' confidentiality. Moreover, given that the diary report involved narrating personal experiences of offence and incivility, ethical considerations also focused on minimising potential distress. Participants were informed of potential emotional discomfort and were given the option to withdraw from the study at any time.

The ethical considerations in this study were tailored to the different challenges posed by the use of X data and the diary report. While X data required handling publicly available content while ensuring anonymity, the diary report required informed consent, voluntary participation, and precautions to minimise potential distress. These measures, along with the university's ethical approval, ensured that the study upheld ethical research standards and maintained integrity throughout.

3.13 Conclusion

This chapter has outlined and critically discussed the methodological foundations and procedures adopted in this study. It detailed the philosophical orientation, research design, data collection methods and the challenges that I faced when collecting the data. It also highlighted the analytical approaches used to explore the two phenomena. At the end of the chapter, attention was also given to the ethical considerations and the translation process that were essential in ensuring the contextual accuracy and integrity of the research.

¹ Twitter Statement on Information You Share with Us, section 1.3: Public Information.

CHAPTER 4: RESULTS - PHASE 1 (A)

4.1 Introduction

This chapter presents the findings of Phase 1 of the study, which investigates how the offence is expressed, constructed, and evaluated within online discourse, specifically on X in the Omani context. As outlined in Chapter 3, the data for this phase were collected using four hashtags (see Section 4.2, Table 4.1) in the Arabic language. These hashtags were selected to capture a wide range of written expressions reflecting moments in which users expressed taking offence. This phase aims to offer an initial understanding of the nature of taking offence as it is reflected in everyday online interactions.

The analysis undertaken in this chapter is structured in two layers. The first layer draws on a corpus-driven approach to examine the collected texts to identify dominant lexical patterns and collocational relationships and their frequencies in the dataset, particularly around the selected hashtags. Building on the corpus findings, the second layer of analysis applies thematic analysis to explore the meanings and expectations embedded within these expressions of offence. While the corpus analysis sheds light on salient lexical patterns, the thematic analysis focuses on interpreting how these patterns reflect unfulfilled expectations. These expectations are examined through the lens of Spencer-Oatey's rapport management framework, which provides insight into how perceived threats to face, and sociality rights and obligations contribute to the construction and expression of offence in the data (Spencer-Oatey, 2008, 2011).

This chapter is divided into two main sections. Section 4.2 presents the corpus-based analysis of four selected hashtags. Each of the subsections (4.2.1 to 4.2.4) focuses on a different hashtag, examining its lexical context. Following this, Section 4.3 presents the thematic analysis, which discusses two key themes. Finally, the chapter concludes with a summary of the main insights from both layers of analysis and their relevance to the next phase of the study.

4.2 Corpus-based Analysis of the Hashtag

Hashtags	Translation	Transcription
#مسيئة	offensive	/musi:jh/
#إهانة	Insult	/a:h nh/
#مستاء	upset	/mwst?/
#إساءة	offence	/a:sa:ʔ/

Table 4.1: Hashtags

Given that four hashtags were selected for this study (see Table 4.1), four separate corpora were constructed accordingly. To analyse how offence is expressed in relation to each hashtag, attention was paid to the immediate textual context in which the hashtag appeared. This involved identifying and extracting words/phrases that occurred directly before and after each hashtag across the dataset.

The process was guided by the following questions:

- What comes before the hashtag? (referred to as -1 Gram)
- What comes immediately after the hashtag? (referred to as +1 Gram)
- What comes immediately one unit after the hashtag? (referred to as +2 Gram)
- How frequent are words/phrases used one unit after the hashtag?

Focusing on the words immediately surrounding each hashtag enabled the identification of recurring lexical patterns that shed light on how offence was framed within each corpus. The following section presents the analysis of each hashtag, individually, highlighting the key patterns observed in their immediate lexical contexts.

4.2.1 Hashtag 1: Corpus

Frequency	+2 Gram	+1 Gram	Hashtag	-1 Gram
2	من هذي الخدمة [the service]	من [with]	مستاء + [upset] /mwst?/	بصراحة [honestly]
2	طريقه معاملته [the way of treatment]			اللاعب [the player]
4	طيران [flight]			الشعب [the people]
3	عدم احترام المواعيد [not respecting time]			الجميع [all]

Table 4.2: the corpus analysis of hashtag1 (#مستاء – ‘Upset’)

Table 4.2 presents the results of the Word Sketch analysis of the hashtag /mwst?/, [upset] taken from a corpus of 861 words. The words that come before the hashtag are listed under -1 Gram; they are included in this table to understand who is *upset*, whereas +2 Gram describes what they are upset about. The frequency list is generated for words that are repeated more than once, while less

one was eliminated from the table. Below The following points briefly summaries the table:

1. The hashtag /mwstʔ/, [upset] collocates with the word /men/ in all occasions; /mən/ is a preposition that is used in Arabic to initiate an action from one thing to another.
2. The users tend to use /mwstʔ/ mostly to show their dissatisfaction with *service, flight, not respecting time* and *the way of treatment*.
3. An interesting pattern is noted in (- 1 Gram) is that users tend to use the plural inclusive form of a noun rather than a singular form of a noun. To explain, they use phrases like /alla'eb/, /alkl/, /aljmy'e/, /aghlb alnas/, which are translated to [people], [most of the people], and [all], to express the fact that it is not only an individual who is *upset* but rather it is the collective “*we are upset*” as a cohesive whole nation.

4.2.2 Hashtag 2: Corpus

Table 4.3 presents a corpus of the hashtag /musi:jh/, [offensive] derived from a corpus of 1628 words.

-1 Gram represents phrases that the commenters used *before* the hashtag to refer to the act that they deemed [offensive] while +2 N-gram refers to words that come after *offensive + preposition*, indicating to whom the act is offensive. A summary of the findings of the table is presented below:

Frequency	+2 Gram	+1 Gram	Hashtag	-1 Gram
6	الرسول [Prophet]	لي [to]	# مسيئة مسي Offensive /musi:jh/	حملة [campaign]
3	اخواننا المسلمين [Muslim brothers]			صور [pictures]
2	كرامه الإنسانية [human dignity]			للتعامل مع الآخرين بصورة dealing with others in
2	الانسان [human]			مصطلحات [terms]
3	الوطن [homeland]			حسابات [accounts]
5	العمانيين [Omanis]			تصرفات [behaviour]
3	لولاة أمورن/ بلدك [leaders/ country]			تغريدات [tweets]
2	المجتمع [society]			أي شخص [hashtags]

Table 4.3: the corpus analysis of hashtag 2 (#مسيئة/مسي – ‘offensive’)

1. The word with the highest frequency is associated with religion specifically [prophet]. A large number of users used the word [offensive] to refer to the campaign that was against the prophet. They also used [Muslim brothers] to refer to pictures that they consider *offensive* to Muslims.
2. Also, words that are related to collective identity, which act as direct objects, seem to occur very often such as [Omanis, homeland, country, and society] which indicates that the offensive acts are perceived as harmful to collective identities.
3. Moreover, in several cases, words like “human dignity” “human”, “dealing with others” and “terms”, the presence of such phrases indicates a sensitivity to how individuals are treated in, particularly in relation to dignity.

4.2.3 Hashtag 3: Corpus

Frequency	+2 Gram	+1 Gram	Hashtag
4	الطفل [child]	لام [for] or null	إساءة [offence] /a:sa:ʔ/
2	القيم الإنسانية [Human values]		
5	وخدش الحياء [and outraging modesty]		
5	المرأة [woman]		
3	الحكومة [the government]		
8	شعب [people]		
5	شخص [individual]		
2	الدين [religion]		
4	الادب [manner]		
4	الوطن [homeland]		
9	بلد [county]		
3	سمعه الوطن/ عمان [home reputation / Oman]		
9	دولة [country]		

Table 4.4: Corpus analysis of hashtag 3 (#إساءة – ‘offence’)

Table 4.4 represents the results of the analysis of the hashtag /a:sa:ʔ/, [offence] taken from a corpus of 6517 words. Single units that come immediately after the hashtag are included such as the following pattern [offence] + *preposition*. Also, words/phrases that occur one unit after the hashtag (+ 2 gram) are included along with their frequency, as they indicate the target of the perceived [offence]. The following provides a brief interpretive remark on the pattern observed:

1. The most frequent words in the corpus involve offences directed to /ba:la:d/ and /dwa:lh/, both of which are equivalent to [country], and each is mentioned nine times. This indicates a significant concern with offences perceived as targeting the [country]. Closely following are offences involving /ʃa:ʕb/, which is equivalent to “people”. In this context, this term does not refer to individuals in a general sense, but rather to the collective body of citizens, the people of the nation. Its use suggests that the perceived offence extends beyond personal insult and is instead directed at the national community as a whole, reflecting sensitivity toward collective identity.
2. Further, the frequent mention of [homeland, Oman, home reputation], does not only reflect Omanis’ concern about the offences directed to Oman but also a profound sense of patriotism and a strong national identity.
3. Lastly, offences related to “خدش الحياء” [outraging modesty] and “الادب” [manners] are amongst the most prominent expressions in the corpus, with frequencies of five and four respectively. Their repeated use highlights a noticeable sensitivity within the community toward breaches of modesty and manners.

4.2.4 Hashtag 4: Corpus

Frequency	+2 Gram	+1 Gram	Hashtag
2	راعي الباص [the bus owner]		
3	وتجريح [and hurting]		
4	تمس بالأخلاق [touches on moral]		
3	فله حياء [indecenty]		
18	الكرامة [dignity]		

3	حقك [your right]	ل [to] or في [on] or [null]	إهانة + [insult]
2	فقير أو محتاج [poor or in need]		
3	مسلم [Muslim]		
9	عمان [Oman]		
2	الموظفين [staff]		
6	العرب [Arabs]		
2	المواطن [citizen]		
2	العلم والمعرفة [science and knowledge]		
6	الزوجة [wife]		
3	الجامعة [university]		
2	العلماء [scholars]		
3	حقي [my right]		
2	العلم الوطني [national flag]		
2	استصغار لشعبي/العماني [look down upon my people]		
2	شخصيه عمانية [Omani figure]		
4	المرأة [woman]		
2	الرجل [man]		
3	الشعب العماني [the Omani nation]		
7	دول الخليج [gulf countries]		
5	شخص [person]		
2	دينية [religiously]		
3	الادب [manner]		
8	الوطن [motherland]		
9	أي بلد / بلد [county/any country]		

16	العمانيين / العماني [the Omanis /the Omani]		
2	دوله [country]		

Table 4.5: the corpus analysis of hashtag 3 (# إهانة – ‘insult)

Table 4.4 displays the results of a word sketch analysis of the hashtag /a:hə nh/ taken from a corpus of 6968 words. An interpretive observation of the results found is provided below. It should be acknowledged that some of (+2 Gram) units are identical in meaning but are treated as separate entities in the table for some reasons that will be explained.

1. From the table, it appears that there are two prepositions used by the commenters after the hashtag which are /la:/ & /fi:/. Their main function in this context is referral. Thus, what comes after the preposition, i.e. (+2 Gram) is crucial to understand what the commenters refer to when using *offending*.
2. The word “الكرامة” [dignity] appears most frequently in this corpus, with a total of 18 occurrences, its repeated use suggests a heightened sensitivity to insults perceived to undermine or disregard [dignity].
3. The most common theme revolves around national identity with significant emphasis on insults directed at Omanis and broader regional identities such as [Arabs] and [Gulf countries]. The high frequency of mentions related to national identity such as [Oman], [nation], [homeland], [country], and [national flag] suggests a strong sensitivity and response to perceived offences against national identity and pride and a strong protective sentiment towards national dignity.
4. The frequent mention of terms such as “Omanis” and “Oman” reflects a strong focus on how Omanis, both as individuals and as a collective national identity, are represented and treated. This points to a heightened sensitivity around perceived insults to national identity, whether occurring within Oman or in international contexts. It is also worth noting that references to “the Omanis” appear in the corpus through a range of expressions, including “the citizen,” “Omani figure,” and “the Omani nation”.
5. In several instances across the corpus, the insult is strongly tied to perceived violations of [dignity], [morality] and [manners]. The data suggests a strong sensitivity toward actions that are seen to undermine moral values indicating that such domains are central to how insults are evaluated in public discourse. The frequency of these words, although lower compared to those related to national identity, still indicates an active discourse around concepts such as dignity,

morality, and manners, which appear to carry evaluative weight in how certain behaviours are described.

4.3 Thematic Analysis of the Corpus

Building on the findings of the corpus analysis presented in Section 4.2, this section offers a deeper examination of how frequently occurring patterns in the data reflect shared but often implicit expectations that shape evaluations of offence. This analysis aims to uncover the underlying expectations that trigger such reactions by examining specific instances of the recurring patterns in how X users express offence. The analysis is grounded in the understanding that such evaluations are socially constructed and negotiated through discourse (Culpeper, 2011). Expressions of offence often point to violated expectations, even when those expectations are not made explicit, a point emphasised by Tayebi (2021), who highlights how underlying assumptions are discursively signalled. To systematically identify and understand the nature of the expectations being violated based on the most common pattern identified in Section 4.2, this study employs Spencer-Oatey's (2002, 2008) rapport management framework. This framework offers a useful lens for interpreting the types of expectations at stake, whether related to face sensitivities, obligations, or sociality rights, which provides deeper insight into what triggers evaluations of offence in the data. The thematic analysis, therefore, moves beyond surface-level lexical patterns to explore how users construct offence in relation to broader sociocultural norms and expectations.

4.3.1 Unfulfilled expectations of portraying Omanis and Oman's national identity and the regional identity in a positive and dignified way.

The first prominent theme reflects an unfulfilled expectation regarding how Omanis and their national and regional identity are portrayed. A recurring pattern in the corpus indicates that users express offence when representations are perceived as inaccurate, disrespectful, or diminishing to the collective image of Oman.

As evidenced by the repeated use of country- and people-related lexical items such as [Oman], [nation], [homeland], [country], [national flag], [Omanis], and [citizens], which frequently appear in close proximity to evaluative terms like “إساءة” (offence) and “إهانة” (insult) (see Sections 4.2.2–4.2.4). The frequency and distribution of these terms suggest that users construct the offence not simply as individual discontent but as a broader concern for how the country and its collective identity are positioned and represented in public discourse.

This pattern reflects what Spencer-Oatey (2002, p. 540) defines as social identity face; it involves any group that a member is concerned with and is described as “we have a fundamental desire for people to acknowledge and uphold our social identities or roles”. In this context, the data show that offence is often constructed in response to representations that are seen as misaligned with core cultural values or that undermine how Omanis perceive their national character. The expectation that the country and its people should be portrayed in a dignified, accurate, and positive way appears to be deeply embedded in the discourse, particularly when such representations are circulated in visible, public-facing contexts such as X. The following analysis focuses on selected posts in which these expectations are made explicit or strongly implied. These posts provide insight into the kinds of portrayals that trigger offence, the values being defended, and how users frame these violations as threats to the collective identity of Oman and its people.

(1)

" هذا الشخص صاحب مقاطع مهينه وفيها انتعاص للشخصية العمانيه وهذا من المقاطع التي أحس فيها بكمية إهانة
للعمانيين"

"This person has offending clips that is derogatory to the Omani character, and this is one of the clips where I feel a great amount of insult to Omanis".

Post (1) expresses a sense of anger towards a video clip made by an Omani social media influencer who approached men in public telling them that an egg has fallen from them as they walked, implying that they had laid an egg. The post implies an expectation that public content involving Omanis should uphold a certain standard of respect towards Omanis; however, what was done in the video clip was “derogatory to the Omani character”. In other words, it is disparaging towards the traits, values or qualities that are typically associated with the core of the community’s self-image.

As a result of this, the commenter viewed this clip as to have made him feel “a great amount of insult to Omanis”. The use of the phrase “a great amount of insult” reflects that the level of insult is not minor but rather substantial and significant to the collective image of the community.

(2)

"إعلان منشور اليوم لشركة نسيان يشكل إهانة للمواطن العماني حيث يطل الشاب العماني من حفرة بالوعة...لابد من اعتذار رسمي"

"Today's advertisement by Nissan is an insult to the Omani citizen, showing a young Omani man peering out from a sewer hole... an official apology is necessary".

Additionally, post (2) was made to comment on an advertisement² from Nissan claiming it is "an insult" to Omanis by depicting an Omani man emerging from a manhole. The use of the term "إهانة", which is translated to "insult", implies that the content of the advertisement is perceived as demeaning towards the Omani citizens, as it portrays Omani men in a manner that conflicts with the dignified expected representation of the Omani citizens. Such a portrayal can be seen as reducing the individual's and, by extension, the nation's image, projecting a negative image that is not in alignment with how Omanis view themselves or wish to be viewed by others. As a result, the commenter insisted on getting "an official apology". The call for an "official apology" further indicates that an insult has been taken, and therefore, a corrective action is "necessary".

(3)

"من متى كنتوا تشغلون العمانيين عندكم خدم!!!!!! ما لقيتو لهذه الدور الا عماني!! شو القصد؟ وشو الي تيون تقولونه؟؟هذي "إهانة ما نرضي به".

" ***Since when you have been employing Omanis as your servants?!!!!!!*** Didn't you find anyone but an Omani for this role?!! What's the meaning of this? What are you trying to say?? ***This is an insult we don't accept it***".

Moreover, post (3) expresses a strong reaction to a Kuwaiti TV drama where an Omani was portrayed in a servant role. The post starts with a question with multiple exclamation marks "Since when have you have been employing Omanis as your servants ?!!!!!!". It sets a confrontational tone and serves as a rhetorical device that aims to critique the practice of casting Omanis in such roles, as there is a clear expectation that Omanis should not be portrayed as servants.

1- <http://t.co/PHYop8NdyF>²

It is then followed by more rhetorical questions “didn’t you find anyone but an Omani for this role?!!”, and “what is the meaning of this?”, which emphasises again the element of non-acceptance of such portrayal. Indeed, the commenter viewed this act as “an insult” and clearly expressed, “we don’t accept it”. The use of “we” in this statement signifies a collective sentiment towards this act; to explain further, it is not just one person rejecting the act and labelling the portrayal as “an insult”; it is a group stance which not only enhances the weight of the objection but also highlights a great sense of national pride in how Omanis perceive themselves and insist on being perceived by others.

Examples (4)

"البنجالية أخوة لنا في الدين والإنسانية معززين مكرمين، ... تصرفات بعض العمانيين بعد المباراة لا تمت للعماني الأصل " بصلّة، إذا كان الأخوة البنجالية لا يعرفون ماذا تعني تلك الكلمات نحن نعلمها جيّدًا ما صدر في هذا المقطع من كلمات بعد إساءة"

“Bengalis are **our brothers in Islam** and humanity, they are honoured and dignified The **behaviour** of some Omanis after the match **has nothing to do with how authentic Omanis are**. If the Bengalis brothers don’t know what those words mean, we know them very well. **What was said** in this clip is considered **an offence**”.

Additionally, the above post was made under a video condemning Omanis who used “words” that were considered “offensive” towards Bangladesh at the end of a football match. The narrator delineates a profound expectation regarding the conduct expected of Omanis, particularly, in how they behave with Bengalis, who are viewed as “brothers in Islam and humanity”. The expectation is multifaceted, encompassing religious and cultural norms that were breached. The post begins by describing Bengalis as “our brothers in Islam and humanity” and that they are “honoured and respected”; this sets a baseline expectation that Bengalis are to be treated with honour and respect due to shared religious and humanistic bond. However, this did not happen as reflected in the post. Therefore, the commenter not only condemned “the behaviour of some Omanis” but viewed those those Omanis who behaved in that way as in outliers, as he emphasised that it “has nothing to do with how authentic Omanis are”. The reference to “authentic Omanis” implicitly sets a standard and expectation for behaviour, in other words, it hints at a framework within which Omanis are expected

to act. However, what was displayed does not adhere to the behaviour of “authentic Omanis”. It must be mentioned that the commenter does not explain what it means to be “authentic Omanis”, but being part of the community makes it easy to single out people who fail to behave accordingly as there seems to be a shared understanding of what makes an Omani an “authentic Omani”

Example 5

"هذا الوافد تعدي على كرامة عمان ويتخذ بشأنه إجراءات مقاضاته ودفع تعويضات إهانة كرامة وطن وإنهاء إقامته ومغادرة البلد".

“The expatriate has **violated the dignity of Oman**, and measures are being taken against him to prosecute him, pay compensation for **insulting the nation’s dignity**, terminating his residency, and deporting him from the country”.

The above tweet (5) was written in response to a public apology issued by the CEO of Al Jazeera Iron Company, following his controversial statement that “Omanis are incapable of producing a single gram without foreigners”. The tweet explicitly stated that “the expatriate” referring to the CEO, had “violated the dignity of Oman” and must be held accountable for “insulting the dignity of the nation”. The language used in this post signals that the speaker’s remarks were perceived as a serious offence on two levels: the country and the nation. The reference to both “Oman” and “the nation” suggests that the perceived violation was not only directed at the country as a political entity but also constituted a deeper offence against the collective identity, pride, and dignity of the Omani people.

To explain further, the CEO’s original statement directly questioned the competence of Omanis, which was framed in the user’s response as an attack on a core aspect of national identity. By stating that the expatriate “violated the dignity of Oman” and “insulted the dignity of the nation,” the tweet constructs the denial of competence as an offence against how Omanis are collectively represented and understood. In this context, national identity appears to be closely tied to perceptions of capability and contribution. While national pride may also be implicated, the data primarily reflects a concern with how competence forms part of the collective self-image. The claim that Omanis are unable to produce anything without foreign assistance implies a lack of capability, which is constructed here as deeply insulting. Moreover, the fact that legal action was taken by the government further underlines the severity of the perceived offence. The government’s involvement signals that the matter touched on collective dignity, not only offending individuals but challenging broader expectations around how Oman and its people should be spoken about.

Example 6

"هذي أكبر إهانة للشعب العماني أفضل تنشعل بنفسك وبلادك اخر زمن والله اسأل الله رب العرش العظيم يحرق قلبك بأقرب شخص لك حسبني الله ونعم الوكيل في كل واحد يغلط على سلطان عمان الله يرحمه، الي فينا مكفيناً".

"This is the greatest insult to the Omani people. You better mind your own business and your country. I pray to Allah, the Almighty, to burn your heart with the person closest to you. **Allah is sufficient for and best disposer of affairs against anyone who wrong the Sultan of Oman**, may Allah have mercy on him. What we have is enough for us".

Example 7

"طيب ليش هذه المدعي خالد يلمز السلطان ويسب الخليلي؟ أليس هذا فيه إهانة للبلد وأهلها؟

"Well then, why does so called Khalid **slander the Sultan** and curse Al Khalili? **Isn't this an insult to the country and its people?**".

Furthermore, the above posts show more tweets of Omanis reacting to what they perceived as an insult to significant figures in Oman: the Sultan, who is the previous leader of Oman, and Al Khalili, who is the grand mufti of Oman. In post (6) the commenter started the post with superlative language "هذي أكبر إهانة للشعب العماني" which translates to "This is the greatest insult to Omani people" marking the severity of the behaviour and implying that any disrespect towards the deceased Sultan of Oman is taken as a direct affront to the people themselves. In response to the insult, the commenter called for a divine intervention by saying "I ask Allah, the lord of the great throne to burn the heart of the closest person to you". The appeal to divine authority, which is Allah, underscores the seriousness of the transgression, and the curse-like prayer exemplifies the depth of the perceived affront; it reflects a wish for the offender to experience a similar feeling. Moreover, the commenter invoked another prayer which is commonly used when someone feels wronged and seeks divine justice "May Allah suffice me, and he is the best disposer of affairs against anyone who wrongs the Sultan of Oman". It is evident from the language used that there is a deep feeling of pride and protection people feel toward the late Sultan who is considered a key national symbol and part of their national identity.

Similarly, post (7) expresses disapproval towards someone named Khalid who made derogatory remarks about the previous leader of Oman and the mufti of Oman. The commenter poses two rhetorical questions to express his disapproval of the perceived insult: “why does this ...Khalid *slanders* the Sultan and *insult* Al Kalili? and “isn’t this an insult to the country and its people”. The former implies that Khalid’s actions are unacceptable and there is no valid reason for such behaviour, while the latter directly addresses the impact of Khalid’s actions. These questions imply that slandering the Sultan and insulting the Khalili equates to insulting the nation and its citizens. In other words, an affront to these figures is an affront to everyone. Both figures are considered national symbols, where respect is expected to be accorded to them; however, by publicly slandering or insulting them, Khalid violated the expectation.

In all of the above posts, there is a great sense of defensiveness and protectiveness toward the Sultan of Oman and any significant Omani figure, and by extension, the national identity of Oman. This reflects a collective sentiment of solidarity and respect towards the Sultan.

Example 8

"اقصد بالتغريدة السابقة الذين يسبون لي عمان بتغريداتهم من الخارج فنحن مشغولين بولائنا لحكومتنا وخدمة وطننا وما يهمنا ويعيننا ولسنا متفرغين لكلمات الذين يصدرها مشكلاتهم لكل الجهات حتى ترد ونشاركهم الاساء فنحن لسنا اهل اساء ولسنا في القاموس العماني وأدري بشؤوننا ولا نأخذها من أحد".

“ I meant by the previous tweet, ***those who offend Oman with their tweets from abroad.*** We are busy with our loyalty to our government, serving our nation, and what matters and concerns us. We are not free to engage with the words of those who spread their problems to everyone, and then expecting a response from us to participate in the offences. ***We are not people of offence,*** and it is not in the Omanis dictionary. We are aware of our own affairs, and we do not take them from anyone”.

Additionally, example (8) actively constructs a discursive boundary between Omanis and those who are seen to offend Oman from abroad. The commenter addresses individuals “who offend Oman from abroad,” drawing an implicit contrast between their actions and the values upheld by Omanis. In contrast to these outsiders, Omanis are described as engaged in meaningful national practices such as “loyalty to our government” and “service to our nation.” The repeated use of inclusive

pronouns (“we,” “our”) does more than express group affiliation; it performs a shared moral positioning that reinforces collective identity. Here, loyalty, responsibility, and national focus are not simply personal traits but are invoked as defining characteristics of what it means to be Omani. Through this discursive move, the post reaffirms an expectation that Omanis should be portrayed as unified, respectful, and committed to national values, an image that stands in opposition to the behaviour of those positioned as outsiders to that identity. This identity is further reinforced through the rejection of offensive behaviour. The commenter stated, “we are not people of offence, and it is not in the Omani dictionary”. The assertion that offence is “not in the Omani dictionary positions anything offensive as foreign to the cultural and moral values associated with the Omani identity. This assertion functions not merely as a denial of association with offensive conduct, but as a rhetorical act that signals what falls outside the values associated with being Omani. As such, the post exemplifies how the discourse of offence is used not merely to react to misrepresentation but to actively construct and defend a shared sense of Omani identity.

(9)

"الاشقاء في دولة الامارات... دول الخليج العربي منا وفينا ولا نقبل مثل هذه المهاترات لهم فمن يسئ لهم فهي إساءة بحقنا. عمل يفتقد لي أبسط معاني الاخلاق التي تربينا عليها كعمانيين. لن نستعزى بأحد ولنترفع".

“The brothers in UAE.. the Arab Gulf countries are part of us, **and we do not accept such polemics against them. Whoever offends them offend us.** This act lacks the simplest meanings of morality which we were raised on as Omanis. We will not mock anyone and will rise above”.

(10)

"عمان واهلها مدرسة في الأخلاق الكريمة لذلك لا تسعدنا الردود التي تمثل إهانة لأي إمارة أو دولة أو لأي إنسان فالكل نراكم أخوة كرام ، وسوف تعود المياه لمجاريها مهما كان ومهما صار وفي أهل الخليج الخير الى يوم الدين"

“**Oman and its people are a school of noble morals.** Therefore, we are not pleased with responses that represent an insult to any emirates, or country or any person. **We see you all as brothers,** and things will return to normal no matter what has happened. There is goodness in the people of the Gulf until the end of time”

(11)

كل واحد يدافع عن وطنه بطريقته اللي يشوفها مناسبة بأمانة ما نرضى حال أي إماراتي لأنهم اهل وأيضاً نحن لانقبل إهانة عمان وسلطينها. الوطن خط احمر بدون انبطاح ولا تهاون.

“Everyone defends their homeland in their own way which they see as appropriate. Honestly, **we don’t not accept this for any Emirati** because they are our family, and **we also do not accept insults to Oman and its Sultans.** The homeland is a red line, with no compromise or complacency”.

While the previous posts (see examples from 1 to 8) focus on national identity, the data also shows that Omani users' expectations around respectful representation are not limited to portrayals of Oman or Omanis themselves, but also extend to include neighbouring Gulf countries. The data has shown that Omanis consider it an "offence" and/ or and "insult" when someone offends any of the Arab Gulf countries. This construction of regional identity is grounded in recurring references to brotherhood and solidarity, which emerge across several posts. To illustrate, the commenters in posts (9), (10), and (11) draw on these notions to adopt a defensive stance against perceived disrespect toward Gulf states. Phrases such as "our brothers," "our people," "they are our family," "part of us," and "we see you all as brothers", are used to construct a sense of shared belonging, in which Gulf nationals are positioned as close enough to warrant the same protective stance that Omanis extend to their own. This symbolic proximity shapes how offence is perceived: any insult or derogation directed toward Gulf allies is treated as a personal affront to Omanis themselves. As expressed in post (9), 'whoever offends them offends us', and in post (10), 'we do not accept this for any Emiratis'. These responses reinforce a broader discourse of regional solidarity and brotherhood, in which Gulf nationals, particularly Emiratis, are framed not as outsiders but as being 'one of us'.

While posts (9), (10), and (11) demonstrate how Omanis consider any offence directed at Gulf countries as equally offensive to themselves, they also implicitly highlight specific aspects of Omani group identity that are expected to be upheld. To explain, in post (9) the commenter highlighted that the act that was directed to the Emirates lacks 'the simplest meanings of morality that we were raised on as Omanis'. This reference to shared upbringing invokes collective moral values assumed to be widely understood within the Omani community. The statement not only defends a regional ally but also evaluates the behaviour through the lens of Omani values, implying that the act violated the values that Omanis were raised with.

The post goes further by explicitly articulating what adhering to Omani morality entails: 'we will not mock anyone and let us rise above'. The repeated use of "we" highlights a communal stance and underscores the expectation that Omanis act in accordance with a shared moral code. In this case, rejecting mockery and exercising restraint are invoked as key expectations that Omanis are socially obliged to uphold. By calling on shared moral upbringing and explicitly encouraging others to "rise above," the commenter is not only condemning the offensive act but reminding fellow Omanis of the values they are expected to maintain. The post thus serves a dual function: it expresses taking offence on behalf of a regional ally, while simultaneously reinforcing internal behavioural norms

rooted in a shared understanding of Omani morality.

4.3.2 Unfulfilled expectation of respecting Islam and its religious symbols

The second prominent theme reflects a recurring expectation among Omani X users that Islam, as a core part of their collective identity, should be treated with reverence. This expectation becomes particularly visible in how users respond to what they perceive as ‘offence to the religion’. In the data, offending religion refers to actions, depictions, or statements that are perceived as disrespectful toward Islam, particularly references to Allah, the Prophet Muhammad, or broader religious expressions. This pattern was evident in the corpus analysis, where such references frequently co-occurred with evaluative terms like “إساءة” (offence), “إهانة” (insult), highlighting the sensitivity around how religious content is represented in public discourse (see Sections 4.2.1 & 4.2.3).

This pattern reflects what Spencer-Oatey (2008) defines as a concern for social identity face in this example unlike in the previous section 4.3.1, individuals are concerned with their religious group. In this context, Islam is not treated merely as a personal belief system but as part of group identity and any perceived disrespect towards it is seen as an attack on the group. In addition, these expressions of offence also suggest a violation of equity rights, particularly the expectation that a religious group will be treated fairly and in the same way as other religious groups. The examples discussed below demonstrate how users draw on their religious identity to assert boundaries around what constitutes acceptable treatment of religious references and to evaluate perceived violations as collective affronts.

Example (12)

"من يتجحون بالحريات الإعلامية... ألا يستطيعوا أن يبقوا حرياتهم بعيدة عن إهانة الرموز الدينية؟؟!!!! فليتحملوا ردات الفعل"

“Those who brag about media freedom.... Can’t they keep their freedom away from **offending religious symbols**??!! Let them bear the reactions if they can!!”.

Example (13)

"إهانة المسلمين حرية رأي اما اهانة اليهود والتشكيك ... يستوجب الدانة والتجريم..من هنا يولد التطرف"

“**Offending Muslims is freedom of speech** but offending Jewish and questioning... requires condemnation and criminalisation...from here extremism is born”.

An illustration of this expectation is evident in posts (12) and (13), both of which respond to a

caricature published in a Danish newspaper depicting the Prophet Muhammad. The comments reflect a strong sense of offence, framed as a perceived violation of the sanctity of the Prophet Muhammad and expectations that Islamic beliefs be treated with the same respect as those of other religious groups. In both posts, the unfulfilled expectation of respecting religious references is intertwined with a broader critique of Western media freedoms and perceived inconsistencies in how different religious groups are treated.

In post (12), the rhetorical question ‘Can’t they keep their freedoms away from offending religious symbols?’ challenges what is perceived as a misuse of free speech. It frames this transgression as crossing boundaries of religious sanctity, thereby threatening social identity face (Spencer-Oatey, 2008). The comment suggests that core aspects of Islamic identity are being disrespected under the guise of media freedom.

Furthermore, the phrase “let them bear the reactions” expresses that such violations are not only offensive but carry anticipated consequences. In post (13), the commenter further intensifies this by contrasting the treatment of Muslims and Jews in public discourse: ‘Offending Muslims is freedom of expression, but offending Jews... requires condemnation and criminalisation’. This comparison reveals a perception of unequal treatment, with Muslim identities being subjected to more frequent or accepted disrespect. This reflects a perceived violation of equity rights, particularly in terms of how different religious groups are handled in global discourse and how Muslim groups are handled.

Example (14)

"والله حرام يرفع أسم رب العباد جل جلاله (الله) ونبيه محمد صلي عليه على أعلام الانتحاريين داعش والقاعدة وغيرهم.. هذه إهانة للدين"

“I swear it is forbidden to raise the name of the lord almighty (Allah) and his Prophet Muhammed (peace upon him) on the flags of the suicide bombers ISIS and Al-Qaeda and others. This is an offence to the religion”.

Post (14) illustrates a particularly intense expression of offence in response to the perceived desecration of Islamic sanctity. The commenter condemns the association of Islam’s most sacred names ‘Allah’ and ‘the Prophet Muhammad’ (peace be upon him) with extremist organisations like ISIS and Al-Qaeda, referred to as ‘suicide bombers’. Beginning with the phrase ‘I swear it is forbidden’ (والله حرام), the post signals a religious transgression. The use of the word ‘forbidden’ draws

directly from Islamic religious discourse, framing the offence as a breach of sacred norms. The offence lies not only in the use of sacred names but also in their symbolic association with acts of violence, which is seen as a distortion of Islamic values and the identity of the religious community.

Example (15)

" فليم العرض على شاطي من شواطئ صلالة لهو إهانة للدين يكفي ما الخفي ولكن إن لم تستحي ففعل ما شئت، ربنا لا تؤخذنا بما فعل السفاء منا"

"The film being shown in one of Salalah beaches is **an insult to the religion**. What is hidden is already enough, **if you have no shame, then do as you wish**. O our Allah, do not hold us accountable for what the foolish among us have done"

Example (15) presents a related but distinct form of religious offence, this time in response to a local event, a film screening on a public beach in Salalah, which the commenter labels as 'an insult to the religion'. This evaluative judgement in this example signals that offence is taken as a moral and religious transgression, one that signals a failure to uphold the standards of reverence expected in a Muslim society. To underscore this claim, the commenter draws on the prophetic saying, 'If you have no shame, do as you wish' which is grounded in the Islamic concept of (*ḥayā*). While often translated as 'shame', *ḥayā*'is more accurately understood as a multi-dimensional religious awareness encompassing a person's internalised sense of accountability before God, moral conduct toward others, and personal conscience (Sawai et al., 2020).

The type of *ḥayā*' being invoked here reflects what Sawai et al. (2020) describe as *ḥayā before Allah*, a sense of reverence and accountability toward God that compels individuals to avoid actions that contradict divine commandments as well as *self-ḥayā*, the internalised moral consciousness that deters a person from engaging in inappropriate behaviour. In this context, the commenter implies that the offence, namely allowing the film screening, could only occur in the absence of *ḥayā*, positioning it as the root cause of the perceived transgression. The post, therefore, does not merely condemn the act but frames it as a failure to uphold the values that define proper conduct in a religious society.

4.4 Conclusion

This chapter aimed to offer an initial understanding of what causes offence in Omani society's discourse by analysing how individuals express and evaluate offence in online contexts. The analysis combines corpus linguistics with thematic analysis. The analysis combined corpus linguistics and

thematic analysis to explore both the linguistic patterns and the underlying expectations that shape the discourse. The corpus was built from tweets collected through four key hashtags/keywords, which are #مسيء [offensive], #مستاء [upset], #إساءة [offence], and #إهانة [insult]. These hashtags served as key linguistic markers into how people in Omani society articulated offence in response to perceived violations. Despite the distinct uses of each hashtag, several unifying patterns emerged across the data, reflecting collective concerns around how Omanis and Oman are represented, how religion is represented.

A prominent finding across all hashtags was the tendency for users to frame offence as a collective experience rather than a personal reaction. This was indicated through the use of plural terms such as 'everyone', 'people', 'all', 'Omanis', and 'citizens'. These words were frequently used to emphasise that the perceived offence affected the wider community.

In #مستاء (upset), offence was most often tied to dissatisfaction with everyday issues such as service quality. These expressions commonly co-occurred with the preposition من [from], signalling a pattern of attributing emotional discomfort to a specific person or action. The commenters under this hashtag justified being upset by indicating unmet expectations regarding how a particular service should have been delivered. In contrast, the hashtags #مسيء [offensive], #إساءة [offence], and #إهانة [insult] revealed deeper sensitivities around religious and national identity. There was a high frequency of terms related to religion such as 'the Prophet', 'religion', and 'Muslims'.

Also, words related to national identity were among the most frequently mentioned in the whole dataset. Words such as 'homeland', 'country', 'the people', and العلم 'the national flag' appeared frequently across the posts, suggesting that many users perceived certain actions or representations as an affront to Oman and its people. Moreover, alongside religious and national concerns, words there were repeated use of terms such as 'modesty', 'manners', and 'morality'. Nonetheless, in all of the examples that used the word morality and modesty, it was tied to the collective image of Oman.

Building on these findings, the thematic analysis in the second part of this chapter unpacked the underlying expectations that shaped these evaluations of offence. Across the data, users took offence when they perceived that either their collective identity as Omanis or their religion was disrespected or misrepresented. In cases involving words related to national identity, offence stemmed from a perceived threat to their social identity face; Omanis felt offended when they were misrepresented not only by others, but also when their Omani fellows failed to uphold the shared values that reflect how Omanis are.

Similarly, in religious contexts, offence arose when sacred figures such as the Prophet and Allah were seen as misused or associated with terrorist groups. This not only signalled a violation of religious sanctity, but also a failure to accord Islam the same respect given to other religions thus challenging both their group religious identity and equity rights. To conclude, the corpus and thematic analyses demonstrated that participants grounded their judgements based on shared sociocultural norms and expectations. The findings here set the stage for the next chapter, which shifts focus from public expressions on X to personal narratives, offering a more detailed and individual perspective on offence.

CHAPTER 5: RESULTS - PHASE 2 (B)

5.1 Introduction

Building on the analysis of X data presented in Chapter 4, this chapter examines personal accounts of offence as narrated by individuals through diary reports to further investigate what causes Omanis to take offence. The findings from the previous phase revealed that offence was frequently triggered by representations or behaviour perceived to misrepresent Omanis and reflect negatively on the group. Such portrayals were often interpreted as public mischaracterisation that prompted strong reactions, particularly when they touched on national identity. Religion also emerged as a prominent source of offence, especially when religious symbols were perceived to have been violated. These patterns revealed the expectations that, when breached, prompted public expression of offence.

The diary report data analysed in this chapter provides an additional layer to this inquiry by capturing participants detailed personal, lived experiences of offence. By focusing on how individuals narrate and evaluate specific incidents, this phase contributes to a deeper understanding of the social expectations and contextual factors that underpin offence in everyday life. The primary objective of the diary report was to explore, in greater depth, the range of situations and perspectives that lead Omani individuals to take offence. Accordingly, the design of this phase was directly informed by the findings of Phase 1. Patterns observed in the data, particularly the ways in which these incidents were framed, guided the wording and sequencing of diary report questions. This helped ensure that the prompts aligned with how participants naturally expressed offence. In this way, Phase 1 provided the communicative framing for the data collection in this phase.

The analysis presented in this chapter is guided by Braun and Clarke's (2006) approach to thematic analysis, allowing for the identification of recurring patterns in how offence is experienced and explained. In addition, Spencer-Oatey's (2008) rapport management framework is employed to interpret participants' evaluations of expectation violations, particularly in relation to face sensitivities, sociality rights and obligations. This combination provides a structured yet flexible lens through which to explore expectations underlying participants' accounts.

The chapter is organised as follows. Section 5.2 provides an overview of the thematic patterns identified in the data. This is followed by six individual sections (5.3 to 5.8), each dedicated to one of the main themes that emerged from the analysis. Each thematic section presents a detailed discussion supported by illustrative excerpts from the diary reports, highlighting how participants

interpret and evaluate moments of offence. The chapter concludes with a synthesis of the key findings and a reflection on their relationship to the broader patterns observed in the public discourse analysed in Chapter 3.

The following section summarises the themes that emerged throughout the analysis:

5.2 Themes overview

The data analysis shows that the Omani participants are generally offended because one or more of the following expectations are not met:

Unfulfillment of quality face expectations caused by underestimating one's abilities
Unfulfillment of interpersonal expectations caused by betrayal within close relationship
Unfulfillment of equity expectations caused by lack of consideration
Unfulfillment of reciprocity expectations caused by misunderstanding of intentions
Unfulfillment of association right expectations caused by being denied expressing oneself
Unfulfillment of deference expectations caused by crossing boundaries

5.3 Unfulfillment of quality face expectations caused by underestimating one's abilities

A recurring pattern across the data involves participants taking offence in response to being perceived as lacking competence, experience, or credibility. These accounts reflect a deeper affront to what Spencer-Oatey (2002, 2008) terms quality face, the desire to be positively evaluated in terms of one's personal qualities, including skills, capability, and appearance. Based on the data, when this aspect of face is undermined, individuals experience a threat to their self-worth, particularly in contexts where competence is central to how one is positioned or recognised by others. The offence expressed in these narratives stems from a perceived mismatch between how participants viewed themselves and how others evaluated them. In many cases, this face threat was compounded by a perceived lack of fairness, such as not being given adequate support, recognition, or opportunity to demonstrate one's abilities. This relates to what Spencer-Oatey (2002, 2008) refers to as equity rights, which involve the expectation to be treated fairly, without undue imposition. While equity rights were not the primary source of offence, they were often entangled with quality face concerns, reinforcing the sense of being undervalued or unfairly judged.

The following examples illustrate situations in which participants perceived their quality face expectations to have been undermined or disregarded.

(1)

"التقليل من مقدرتي فالعمل بمعنى ادق انت لم تحصلي على الشهادة الجامعية وليس لديك الخبرة فالعمل ولا يوجد أي تقدير فالعمل، شعرت بالإحباط".

"Underestimating my ability at work, more precisely, you do not have a university degree and you do not have work experience, and there **is no appreciation at work, I felt frustrated**".

In the narrative above, the narrator expressed offence and frustration at being underestimated in the workplace. She reported experiencing "the underestimation of my ability at work," which she attributed to others pointing out that she "did not obtain a university degree" and "had no work experience". These remarks dismissed her personal qualities and reduced her value to formal credentials, reflecting a clear violation of quality face. The narrator did not question her own capability, but felt that others failed to see her potential, creating a mismatch between her self-perception and how she was evaluated by others. She also noted that "there was no appreciation at work" which added to her sense of being undervalued. This lack of recognition suggested an unmet expectation that her efforts and abilities should be acknowledged, regardless of her qualifications. While the primary source of offence was the threat to her quality face, the narrative also hinted at a broader concern with fairness, as the narrator implicitly expected to be acknowledged for her efforts and potential, rather than judged solely on formal qualifications. The combined effect of negative evaluation and the absence of appreciation resulted in feelings of discouragement and offence.

(2)

"حصل في فترة دراستي الشخص المشرف علي ينتقد عملي بطريقة مهينة وبحسني اني لست قد المسؤولية واني ما عندي المهارات الكافية لي إتمام المهمة المكلفة بها، شعرت بالذل والاهانة مع اني واثقة من نفسي واني قادرة على انجاز المهمة، كنت محتاجة للوقت الكافي فقط، هذا الشعور أدى الى عدم تقبلي العمل معه وبالتالي ما قدرت اتأقلم في البيئة الي كنت ادرس فيها"

"It happened during my studies that the person supervising me criticised my work in an insulting way and made me feel that I was **not responsible** and that I did **not have enough skills** to complete the task assigned to me. I felt **offended** and **humiliated** even **though I was confident in myself and that I could complete the task**. I just needed enough time. This feeling led me **not to accept working with him** and therefore I was **unable to adapt to environment** in which I was studying".

Narrative 2 illustrates how offence arises when an individual's expectation of being recognized as competent and capable is dismissed by supervisors' negative evaluation. The narrator reported that her supervisor criticised her work 'in a humiliating way', which made her feel 'not responsible' and that she lacked 'the necessary skills' to complete the task. However, she stated that she was 'confident in [herself]' and believed she could complete the task successfully. The offence did not stem simply from receiving negative feedback, but from the perception that it contradicted how she

(3)

”تم وصفي بالغراب من قبل ابن عمي شعرت بالحزن كثيرا لان هذه الإهانة جات من قريب

“I was described to **be a crow** by my cousin. I felt so sad because this insult came from someone **close**”.

saw herself and how she wished to be perceived by others. This disconnect between her self-perception and the way she was positioned by the supervisor reflects a clear violation of quality face, as her competence was not only questioned but disregarded.

The narrative also reflects an implicit expectation of fair treatment. Her comment that she “just needed enough time” suggests that she believed the judgement was premature and that she was not afforded a fair chance to demonstrate her capability. While quality face was the primary concern, this perceived lack of opportunity added another layer to the offence by reinforcing the sense that her abilities were dismissed without justification. The narrator's account shows how the offence was shaped not only by the way her abilities were dismissed, but also by the sense that she was not given the opportunity to prove herself. This combination of negative evaluation and limited support reflects how threats to quality face may be reinforced by unmet expectations of fairness in how one is assessed.

5.4 Unfulfillment of interpersonal expectations within close relationships

This theme centres around offences that arise when expectations embedded within close personal relationships are violated. These expectations are shaped by what Chen, Boucher, and Tapias (2006) describe as the relational self, the self in relation to “significant others”, defined as “ individuals whom one knows, (v.s just met), with whom one feels some degree of closeness, and usually with whom one shares a relationship that can be normatively (e.g., friend) or idiosyncratically labelled (e.g., my closest high school friend)” (p. 153). From a relational perspective (Spencer-Oatey, 2011), offence in these contexts arises not simply from the act itself, but from the fact that it violates relationship-

specific expectations shaped by emotional closeness and shared history. In this study, these expectations are referred to as interpersonal expectations norms of behaviour that are context-dependent and often implicit, varying according to the quality, role, and type of the relationship. The examples in this category involve offences committed by individuals with whom the participant shared a close personal relationship, such as a family member or friend. In each case, the offence was shaped not only by the action itself but by the fact that it came from someone with whom the participant had an established relational history. That history gave rise to implicit expectations grounded in trust, emotional closeness, or loyalty that the offender was expected to uphold. Several participants indicated that their sense of offence was heightened precisely because the behaviour came from someone close, rather than a stranger or casual acquaintance. The following examples illustrate how the unfulfillment of interpersonal expectations within close relationships led to particularly meaningful and emotionally charged experiences of offence.

Extract 3 presents an incident in which the narrator felt offended when his cousin, described as someone close, called him “a crow.” What appears to have caused the offence was not the insult itself, but the fact that it came from a close relative. The narrator explicitly states that he felt sad “because this offence came from someone close,” indicating that if the same comment had come from someone else, it may not have provoked the same emotional response. This suggests that the evaluation of offence does not depend solely on the content of what was said, but significantly on who said it.

The narrator’s use of the word “*close*” points to a long-standing relationship, likely marked by emotional familiarity and shared history. His sadness reflects a sense of violated interpersonal expectations, namely, that someone within his inner circle would avoid using insulting language. In this context, the offence arose from the violation of expectations commonly associated with close relationships, where individuals anticipate care, support, and restraint in how they are addressed. The narrative suggests that the closer the relationship, the higher the expectation for positive and affirming interactions, which makes derogatory remarks feel particularly hurtful and disappointing.

(4)

" تعطي ظهرك لشخص واثق منه وتعتبرها اختك لك وفجأة التفت ورأيت انها تفعل أشياء من خلف ظهري بالإشارات تبين انها تتكلم خلفي بسوء، تأثرت نفسي لمدة ٤ أشهر، شعرت بضيق واحباط وخذلان وعدم الوثوق بالآخرين ... "

"You turn your back on someone that **you trust** and **consider a sister** and then suddenly you turn around and see that she is **making gestures behind your back**, indicating that she is **speaking ill of you**, my mental state was affected for 4 months. I **felt bad** and was **disappointment** and **lost trust in others**".

Narrative (4) clearly shows how offence can arise when expectations in close relationships are not met. The narrator begins with, '*you turn your back to someone you trust and consider a sister*' which highlights the emotional closeness and trust that defined the relationship. This closeness creates certain expectations about how one should be treated, expectations that are often unspoken but assumed. As Spencer-Oatey (2011) notes, close relationships carry relationship-specific behavioural expectations. In this case, the narrator likely expected emotional loyalty and protection from hurtful behaviour.

The narrator saw that her friend, who is like her sister, was 'speaking ill' of her; this act itself was perceived as a direct violation of the expectations associated with being 'like a sister'. It is important to mention here that the narrator does not present the offence as rooted in the specific words spoken, or even the action itself but in who committed the act. The offence that emerges here stems from the rupture of a bond framed as sister-like. In this way, the narrative reinforces that interpersonal expectations in close relationship carry a deeper weight, and when violated, trigger more intense emotional consequences.

The reported emotional impact, '*my mental state was affected for four months... I felt distress, disappointment, and a loss of trust in others*' which further highlights the depth of the offence. What makes this account particularly powerful is the contrast between the assumed role of the offender "a sister" and her actual behaviour, creating a gap between expectation and reality that lies at the heart of the offence.

5.5 Unfulfillment of equity expectations caused by lack of consideration

The data reveals that in certain contexts, participants expected to receive a level of personal consideration from others, grounded in notions of fairness. This expectation relates to what Spencer-Oatey defines as equity rights and is defined as "We have a fundamental belief that we are entitled

to personal consideration from others, so that we are treated fairly: that we are not unduly imposed upon, that we are not unfairly ordered about and that we are not taken advantage of or exploited" (2008, p.16). Such expectations may not always be explicitly stated, but they reflect a normative understanding of how people believe they ought to be treated within a given social context.

In the examples that follow, participants describe moments in which these equity-based expectations were not met. The offence in these cases stems from a perceived lack of fair and considerate treatment, such as being expected to sacrifice personal needs without acknowledgement, having one's time or efforts disregarded, or being repeatedly denied what they believed was rightfully theirs.

(5)

"التزمت بدفع مبلغ يزيد عن ٥٠٠ ريال عماني من قبل قريب من الدرجة الأولى وذلك للمساهمة في شراء سيارة لي احد القريبات من الدرجة الأولى كذلك وكان هذه الالتزام في فترة لم يكن في حسابي البنكي هذا المبلغ وكنت في اشد الحاجة للمساعدة أصلاً بسبب التزامي ببناء منزل لي وكان الجميع يعلم اني ابني بيت بتمويل خاص دون قرض من البنك او ما شابه. عند توفر المبلغ اضطررت لتقديم امر المساهمة في شراء السيارة وتأجيل امر ملح لإتمام البناء مما اخر امور كثيرة متعلقة بالبناء. شعرت بالضيق والاستياء لإنني ايقنت ان الناس مدينة لمصالحها، ولا يوجد شخص يؤمن بأولويات الأشخاص الآخرين ولا يراعي ظروفهم وان كان على علم بها"

" I committed to paying an amount exceeding 500 Omani Rials to a first degree relative to contribute to buying a car for one of my close first-degree relatives. This commitment came at a time when I did not have this amount in my bank account, I was in dire need of help, in the first place, due to my commitment to building a house for myself. Everyone was aware that I was building a house without a bank loan. When the amount became available, I had to proceed with the car purchase contribution, and postpone a crucial matter related to completing the construction, delaying many other constructions related matters. I was frustrated and upset because I realized that people prioritise their own interests, and there is no one who believes in the priorities of others or considers their circumstance, even if they are aware of them".

This example illustrates how offence can emerge when equity expectations are violated specifically, the expectation that others will take one's circumstances into account when making requests. The narrator describes feeling upset and frustrated after being expected to contribute financially toward purchasing a car for a close relative, despite being in a difficult financial situation himself. What makes the incident offensive is not merely the financial demand but the fact that "everyone was aware" of his ongoing house construction and financial strain. His emotional response reflects a perceived failure of others to act with fairness and consideration of core elements of equity rights as

defined by Spencer-Oatey (2008). The narrator presents the situation as a conflict between his own pressing needs and the expectations placed upon him by others. While he emphasises being ‘in dire need of help’ and under pressure to complete his home construction, he also recounts how he ended up prioritising the contribution for the car, delaying important building-related matters in the process. His language, including phrases like “postpone crucial matters” and “everyone knew,” underscores

(6)

" في يوم من الأيام كنت جالس اتكس وجالس انتظر وانتظر وانتظر وجاء زبون وكنت انا المتقدم وجاء شخص اخر واخذ عني الزبون وجعلني انتظر مرة اخره للأسف وللأسف الشخص الآخر هو من يأخذ مني الأشخاص وحزنت كثيرا ولم استطع الرد عليه وذلك لي قيمتي ... وجلست انتظر فصيرت وجاء زبون افضل اخر افضل من الي قبله واخذته بمبلغ اكبر. وهذا جزاء الصبر دائما الفرج... الموقف جعلني اشعر بالغضب والكره لذلك الشخص، ولكن الايمان بالله والصبر جعلني اكون اقوى"

“One day I was on my taxi, **waiting and waiting, and waiting** until a customer arrived, **and I was ahead**, but **another taxi driver came and took the customer from me**, making me **wait again**, unfortunately. **That person is the one who keeps taking customers** from me, and I **felt very sad**, and I **couldn’t say anything to him due to my values**, I sat waiting, and I **was patient**, another better customer arrived, better than the previous one, and I charged him with a larger amount. This is the reward of patience, relief. The situation made me **feel angry and resentment** towards that person, but faith in God and patience made me stronger”.

the offence taken: not at the financial act itself, but at being expected to give at personal cost without acknowledgment of his situation. The comment that ‘people prioritise their own interests’ and ‘do not consider the circumstances of others, even if they are aware of them’ reveals a breakdown of interpersonal fairness. The offence, in this case, stems from a lack of consideration for his needs, and a perceived disregard for his situation, ultimately reflecting an unmet expectation of fair and considerate treatment from those who were aware of his circumstances.

Narrative 6 presents a case in which the narrator, a taxi driver, takes offence due to a perceived violation of fairness in a work-related interaction. He recounts waiting a long time for a customer, emphasised through the repetition of ‘waiting and waiting and waiting’, only for another driver to intervene and take the customer instead. This incident triggered feelings of ‘anger and resentment’, reflecting a strong emotional response tied to a perceived injustice.

The narrator’s reaction points to an unspoken but socially recognised norm of turn-taking among taxi drivers, an informal practice that supports fairness in accessing customers. Although the narrator does not explicitly use the word ‘unfair’, his frustration reflects a clear violation of equity expectations.

To explain, the narrator followed the expected process and invested his time, yet another driver disregarded those norms, and took his customer. The statement that “this person is the one who keeps taking customers from me” indicates that this was not an isolated case, but part of a repeated pattern, which further reinforced the sense of being treated unfairly.

Despite his anger, the narrator states that he “couldn’t respond because of [his] values,” introducing a moral dimension to the narrative. While he does not specify what values he is referring to, his silence in the face of perceived unfairness reflects a tension between personal values and repeated experiences of unfairness.

(7)

"كنت بصحبة طفلي في أحد المكاتب الشرائية لي شراء أدوات مدرسية وفي الانتظار بالطابور كان المحاسب مشغول بالحديث مع موظف الطباعة بالمكتبة ولم يعر اهتمام للزبائن الواقفين بالطابور ثم جاء فجاء شخص للمكينة واخذ ادواته وتقدم للدور الأول بالطابور من دون احترام للواقفين بالطابور وكذلك المحاسب لم يبد رده فعل لتصرفه مما جعل الزبائن والأطفال يتضايقون من الموقف. شعرت بالاستياء وعدم الرضى لعدم احترام الطابور وكذلك الموظف المسؤول لم يتخذ أي رد فعل".

“ I was with my daughter in one of the primary schools to buy school supplies while **waiting in the line**. The cashier was busy talking to the printing staff at the office and did not pay attention to the customers standing in the line. Suddenly, a person came to the machine and took his items and **advanced to the front of the queue without respecting those already standing** in line. Additionally, **the cashier did not show any reaction** to his behaviour **causing annoyance among the customers and** the children. I felt **frustrated and dissatisfied due to the lack of respect for the queue and because the staff did not take any action**”.

This narrative presents a situation in which the narrator, accompanied by her daughter, experiences offence due to the unfulfillment of equity expectations at a stationery shop. The scenario involves three key actors: the customers waiting in line, including the narrator and her child; the individual who bypasses the queue; and the cashier who fails to intervene.

The first offence arises when a person skips the queue “without respecting those already standing in line,” directly violating the shared social norm of turn-taking. The narrator explicitly attributes her feelings of frustration and dissatisfaction to this disruption, stating that it was the “lack of respect for the queue” that caused her offence.

While the term “respect” is used, it should be understood not as a face concern but as a matter of equity. In this context, “respecting the queue” refers to adhering to the principle of fairness in public interactions: following the order of arrival and waiting one’s turn. The act of bypassing the queue disregards this unspoken agreement, creating a situation in which the time and presence of those waiting, particularly those who had complied with the norm, are devalued.

A second layer of offence emerges from the cashier’s lack of response. His failure to address or correct the queue-jumping behaviour is perceived as a further violation of equity expectations. Not only does it signal indifference to the breach, but it also suggests a lack of professional impartiality and fairness expected of service providers. The narrator notes that this inaction led to visible annoyance among other customers and children, reinforcing the sense that the principles of fair treatment were not upheld. Together, these two actions, the breach of turn-taking and the absence of a corrective response, reflect a breakdown in the normative expectations of equitable and considerate treatment in everyday interactions.

5.6 Unfulfillment of reciprocity expectation

This theme explores how offence arises when participants’ acts of goodwill are not reciprocated. Across the data, participants describe offering a favour or act of assistance, often using the culturally salient terms *maṣrūf* (a favour) or *xidma* (a service or help provided to someone), through which their gestures were ultimately not reciprocated in any meaningful way. These accounts point to a recurring pattern in which helping others appears to carry a tacit expectation of reciprocation in the form of recognition. Based on the data, this expectation operates across different kinds of relationships, however loosely defined, whether it involves a close connection (such as a friend or relative) or a brief encounter with a stranger in public. In all cases, the absence of an expected response, ‘reciprocation’ becomes a source of offence.

The principle of reciprocity is about maintaining a balance of payment in social interaction (Culpeper & Tantucci, 2021); in other words, “we owe others certain things because of what they have previously done for us, because of the history of previous interaction we have had with them” (Gouldner, 1960, p.171). Therefore, “if someone fails to reciprocate politeness work, it is likely that their actions will be perceived as breaking some implicit social norm” (Culpeper, 2011, p.38).

In this context, the present data show that reciprocation can take the form of appreciation, acknowledgment, or any gesture that signals the act was recognised and valued. When these forms of reciprocation are absent or worse, when the favour is met with suspicion or hostility, the expected

social balance is disrupted resulting in a sense of offence grounded in the violation of normative expectations around reciprocity.

(8)

"بينما كنت اقوم سيارتي ذات يوم تفاجئت بسيارة بجانبى كانت تقودها امراه، حيث تبين لى بان جزء عباءتها كانت خارج السيارة بحيث انه كان قريباً من اطار السيارة. وحاولت ان اوقف المراه ولكن دون جدوا لان المراه لم تعرنى انتباها وكانت تنظر لى وكاتي عدوا لها او بمعنى اعاكسها. ولكن خوفي على المراه وسياراتها. وبعد ان نزلت من سيارتي لم استطع ان ابليها الوضع حيث قابلتني بكلمات والفاظ سيئه جداً جداً لدرجة انها ابليت الشرطه عني وبعد لانتهاه من ذلك الفضل الذي انتهى بكل كلمات الشتم ابليتها بان جزء من عبائها كانت خارج السيارة مما كان يودي الى سحبها عن طريق الاطار ويودي ذلك الى اختناقه. شعرت باسئياء كبيراً وتمنيت من نفسي بان لم اوقف هذه المراه واتقبل هذه الاهانات السيئه. وكما قال المثل خيراً تعمل شراً تلقى"

"one day as I was driving my car, I was surprised to see a car next to me driven by a woman and it appeared to me that **part of her abaya was outside the car**, and it was close to the car tire. **I tried to stop the woman**, but to no avail, ... and **she was looking at me as if I were her enemy or in other words, as if was flirting with her**. I was worried that **something will happen to this woman** and her car. After I got out of my car, I could not inform her of the situation as she immediately started **saying very very bad words** to the extent that **she informed the police** about me, and after **the favour I done** to her which ended up with me **receiving swear words**, I told her that part of her abaya was outside the car, which could have led her to being pulled outside through the tire and being suffocated. I felt a lot of resentment and wished that I did not stop that woman and receive these bad insults. As the saying goes no good deeds goes unpunished".

Narrative 8 reveals a fundamental mismatch between the speaker's intended act of "favour" and the interpretation it received, a misalignment that ultimately gave rise to offence. The narrator describes attempting to assist a woman whose abaya was dangerously caught outside her car door. Although motivated by concern for her safety, his repeated efforts to alert her were misinterpreted as flirtation or inappropriate attention; he reported that the woman looked at him "as if [he] were her enemy" or as though he were "flirting with her," and responded with "very, very bad words" and even reporting him to the police.

From the narrator's perspective, this was a clear *maʿrūf*. He explicitly labels his intervention a "favour" and expresses disbelief and frustration that this favour "ended with [him] receiving insults." The fact that he frames his help in this way signals an implicit expectation that such an act will be socially recognised if not appreciated. What makes the event offensive is not simply the absence of recognition, but the fact that the narrator's act of help was entirely misinterpreted. His reference to the proverb 'you do good, you receive harm' underscores a broader sense of disillusionment, where a well-intentioned act is not only unreciprocated but socially penalised. favour' is misinterpreted. In this

case, the narrator's act of *maḥrūf* was not simply unreciprocated; it was reframed as inappropriate behaviour, contradicting the meaning the narrator had attached to it.

(9)

"في يوم من الأيام كنت أحاول اساعد جنتي في غسل شعرها ولكن هي فهمت انا اريد اضرها شعرت بالخجل والاحراج لاني اريد افعل معروف لجنتي"

"One day I was trying to help my grandmother to wash her hair, but she **thought I wanted to harm her**. I felt **ashamed and embarrassed** because I wanted to **do a favour** to my grandmother".

This idea of offence arising from a misalignment between intended favour and received interpretation is further echoed in Narrative 9. Here, the narrator describes a moment when he attempted to help his grandmother wash her hair, an act he explicitly identifies as a *maḥrūf* (favour). However, instead of receiving his gesture as one of care and assistance, the grandmother misinterpreted it as an attempt to cause harm. The narrator's emotional response, feeling "shame and embarrassment", highlights how the offence was not triggered by the dissonance between his intention and how it was perceived.

As with the previous example, the core issue is not the absence of reciprocation, but from the failure of the act to be received within its intended frame. While it may seem natural to feel offended when one's intentions are misunderstood, the examples in this section show that the offence is not simply a reaction to misunderstanding itself. Rather, it emerges from a deeper sense of frustration when a favour especially one framed as a *maḥrūf* is not only misread but stripped of its intended meaning. Participants did not take offence because the other person was deliberately hostile, but because their goodwill was interpreted in ways that contradicted their purpose. Even when the misunderstanding was acknowledged, as in Narrative 9, the emotional impact remained.

This highlights that the offence stems not just from a lack of reciprocation or not reciprocation, but from the failure of others to recognise the act as a favour and understand it as it was intended. In this way, reciprocity is shown to depend not only on returning a favour, but on correctly interpreting and acknowledging the intent behind it. In this case, the close familial relationship adds further weight to the expectation of recognition, making the misinterpretation more emotionally charged. This suggests that reciprocity depends not only on returning a favour, but also on correctly interpreting and acknowledging the intent behind it particularly in relationships where mutual understanding might be assumed.

(10)

"عرضت للتمر عبر قناة التواصل الاجتماعي تويتر من شخص قدمت له خدمة سابقاً، حيث لم يتفق معي بإحدى التغريدات و قام بالرد بطريقة بها اساءة لي شعرت بالكثير من الحزن و الغضب خاصةً أنني قدمت خدمة للشخص. كوني شخص حساس وفي وسط موجة من التعليقات الساخرة والمهينة شعرت بالضعف الشديد والإهانة "

"I was subjected to **bullying** via a social media networking, Twitter, from a person whom I helped before, as he did not agree with me on one of the tweets and **responded in a way that offended me**. I **felt so angry and sad especially that I helped that person**. Being a sensitive person and amid a wave of sarcastic and **insulting** comments, I felt **very vulnerable and offended**".

Unlike the previous examples (8 &9) where offence arose from misunderstood intentions, Narrative 10 highlights a different breach of reciprocity, one in which a past favour was disregarded and followed by a publicly offensive response. The narrator recounts being bullied on X (formerly Twitter), receiving "a wave of sarcastic and insulting comments" that left him feeling "very sad and angry." However, what makes the incident particularly offensive is not the online aggression itself, but the fact that one of the individuals involved was someone he had "helped before." The narrator uses the term *xidma* a culturally salient term equivalent to *maʿrūf* (favour) and repeats the verb "helped," underscoring his expectation that past assistance should have at least secured respectful treatment, if not solidarity.

This expectation is explicitly voiced in the phrase "especially because I helped that person," indicating that the breach lies not just in being insulted, but in being insulted by someone with whom the narrator had a prior relationship shaped by a previous act of help, thereby creating an implicit expectation of respectful or considerate treatment in return.

5.7 Unfulfillment of association rights expectation caused by being denied expressing oneself

Some examples in the data show that individuals took offence when they were denied the opportunity to connect emotionally or socially with others in ways they felt were appropriate to the relationship. These experiences relate to association rights, which, within the Rapport Management Framework (Spencer-Oatey, 2008), refer to people's expectations for inclusion, emotional involvement, and participation in social interaction. Unlike equity rights, which concern fairness and balance in the distribution of benefits and obligations, association rights are concerned with whether individuals are granted or denied the space to engage, express, and connect. These expectations vary depending on relational closeness, cultural norms, and personal boundaries, but when individuals feel socially

excluded or emotionally shut down, offence may arise. The examples that follow demonstrate how participants experienced offence when their attempts to express themselves were restricted or dismissed.

(11)

"أحياناً أحس أنني مهمشة في المجتمع يعني مثلاً في المدرسة حسيت أنني ما عندي الحرية أنني أعبر عن رأيي بكل صراحة وشفافية وكان التركيز أنني أسمع كلام المدرسات ونخلص المناهج"

"Sometimes I feel **marginalised** in the society, for instance, in school I felt like I didn't have the **freedom to express my opinions openly and transparently**. The focus was more on listening to the teachers and completing the curriculum".

In the narrative above, the speaker describes a situation in which she felt offended due to being "marginalised" within the school community. She recounts how her freedom to express her opinions "openly and transparently" was constrained, as the institutional focus was primarily on listening to teachers and completing the curriculum. This experience reflects a perceived denial of what Spencer-Oatey (2008) terms association rights the expectation of being allowed to engage in meaningful interaction and to express oneself within a social setting. The narrator's sense of marginalisation indicates a breach of her anticipated entitlement to be heard and included, both emotionally and conversationally. The offence arises from being excluded from the communicative and relational dynamics of the environment. The clash between her expectation of participatory engagement and the limited opportunity for expression highlights a violation of association rights.

(12)

"في البيت من يوم أنا كنت صغيرة ما كان مسموح لي في البيت أني أزعج وأعصب وجهي وإذا سويت، أمي راح تعطيني كلام وتحسنني بالذنب وتأنيب الضمير كأنني سويت شي غلط. هذي المواقف كثير خلاني وحيدة ومنعزلة عن العالم. لأن لما أحاول انخرط بالناس أحس بالخوف والتوتر والقلق وتأنيب الضمير. أحس مهما علمت مستحيل"

"At home, since I was a child, I was **not allowed to be upset, or frown**. If I did, my mother would reprimand me, **make me feel guilty** as if I had done something wrong. These situations made me feel **lonely and isolated** from the world. When I try to engage with people, I feel fear, tension, and anxiety, along with a sense of guilt. I feel that no matter how much I do, **it is impossible to meet or satisfy people's expectations**".

Narrative (12) presents a situation in which the narrator's association rights were not fulfilled due to being denied the freedom to express her emotions without fear of reprimand. The narrative begins

with a reflection on the home environment, where the speaker states that she was “not allowed” to show emotional discomfort, such as being upset or frowning. This phrase signals a perceived restriction on emotional expression within a close relational setting. The consequences of attempting to express such emotions were significant: her mother would reprimand her and make her feel guilty, ‘as if [she] had done something wrong’. The offence arises from the implicit belief that she is entitled to an emotional openness within her family, but does not get it.

As a result, the speaker reports feeling “lonely and isolated from the world,” suggesting that her inability to express herself at home contributed to a broader sense of emotional disconnection. This disconnection extended beyond the family setting and shaped her experiences in wider social contexts. She describes feeling “fear, anxiety, and guilt” when engaging with others, and expresses a belief that “it is impossible to meet or satisfy people’s expectations.” These reflections illustrate how the early denial of her association rights within her family undermined her ability to feel socially connected and emotionally secure in broader interactions.

5.8 Unfulfillment of deference expectation based on role

The data from in the diary report revealed that offence arise when individuals feel that the level of deference they are entitled to based on their social or institutional role, is not granted. In this context, deference refers to the recognition individuals expect in accordance with their perceived position within a social hierarchy. As Shils (1982, pp. 145–146) explains, deference is linked to “macrosocial” properties such as occupational role, accomplishment, income, lifestyle, and level of education. These attributes influence how people are positioned in society and shape expectations for how they should be treated. When such deference is expressed, it communicates a recognition of the individual's higher status or authority. Conversely, when it is withheld such as failure to observe role-appropriate boundaries, it implies that the person’s position is not acknowledged or valued. In certain contexts, people express either implicitly or explicitly that they are entitled to receive a certain level of deference based on their social or institutional role. This perceived denial of recognition can lead to feelings of offence, particularly when individuals, whether implicitly or explicitly, believe that their role entitles them to a certain kind of treatment.

Moreover, deference expectations are shaped by broader sociocultural norms, which influence the perceived importance of social attributes such as occupational role, age, or institutional status. These norms govern the extent to which such attributes are socially valued and regarded as deserving of

differential treatment, thereby shaping individuals' expectations for how they should be acknowledged or positioned within interactions. In this context, participants frequently used the Arabic term احترام (/ʔihtira:m/), commonly translated as *respect*. However, in these narratives, احترام refers more specifically to role-based deference, the culturally grounded expectation that one's social or professional status will be acknowledged and upheld through appropriate behaviour. While the extent of these expectations varied among individuals, the denial of (/ʔihtira:m/), in this sense, consistently emerged as a trigger for taking offence. The following examples illustrate how such perceived violations of role-based expectations were evaluated as offensive.

(13)

”أحد الطلاب قام بالتعليق السلبي علي عدساتي امام زملائه وتم التفاهم معه مباشرة وجاء للاعتذار ولم اقبل اعتذار شعرت بالاستياء لعدم الاحترام امام الطلاب وأيضا عدم اظهار الندم على ما فعله، بل الإصرار انه لم يفعل شي سيئ“

“One of the students made a **negative comment** about my contact lenses in front of his classmates, and he was spoken to directly, and he came to apologise, and I did not accept his apology because he **did not respect me** in front of the students and also because **he did not show remorse** for what he has done but rather **insisting that he did nothing**”.

Extract (13) presents a layered account of offence in which the narrator responds to what she perceives as a violation of role-based deference expectations. The incident involves a student making a negative comment about the narrator's contact lenses in front of his classmates. While the content of the remark is framed as negative, the narrator's emphasis on the public setting “in front of the students” suggests that the central issue is not simply the comment itself, but the failure to meet expectations regarding how she should be treated in front of others. Her statement that the student “did not respect me in front of the students” indicates that she anticipated a certain level of restraint or recognition in line with her role, most likely a position of authority, which was not upheld.

This expectation of deference appears to be rooted in the hierarchical nature of the relationship between the narrator and the student. Although her role is not explicitly stated, her evaluation of the interaction implies that she viewed the student's behaviour as inappropriate within the boundaries of their respective roles. The public nature of the act intensifies the offence, as it not only violates her expectation of being treated with deference but also does so in a way that exposes her to possible embarrassment or loss of face in front of others.

The final layer of offence emerges from the student's apology, which, rather than repairing the situation, appears to have exacerbated the narrator's sense of disrespect. Although the student offered an apology, the narrator rejected it, explaining that it lacked remorse and was accompanied by a denial of wrongdoing "he insisted that he did nothing wrong." This failure to acknowledge disrespect falls short of the narrator's likely expectations for how the situation should have been addressed. As noted by Shafa et al. (2017), perceptions of sincerity in an apology are closely tied to the degree of blame acknowledged and remorse expressed. In this case, the absence of both made the apology ineffective and further intensified the narrator's offence. The apology was not perceived as a recognition of the speaker's role or a restoration of the disrupted social boundary, but rather as a refusal to accept responsibility, reinforcing the initial violation of expected deference. In other words, it reflects not just a failure to restore deference, but a refusal to accept that any deference was due in the first place.

(14)

"في واحد من الطلاب قلل ادبه علي عن طريق اهائته واتهامه لي بالتقصير ف العمل واني ما استحق الراتب الي اخذه خلاني اشعر بالازعاج والاستفزاز
لانه قلل من احترامي وتخطه حدوده معي "

"One of the students **offended me and accused** me of negligence in my work and that I did not deserve the salary that I received. He made **me feel annoyed and provoked** because he disrespected me and crossed his boundaries with me".

Extract (14) provides another example in which the informant expresses offence in response to a student's behaviour that she perceived as both disrespectful and inappropriate within the professional context. According to the narrative, the student accused the speaker of failing to fulfil her work responsibilities and added that she did not deserve the salary she received. The narrator reports feeling "annoyed and provoked," and frames the incident as an act of "disrespect" and a case of the student having "crossed his boundaries".

The narrator's emphasis on having been "disrespected" and on the student having "crossed boundaries" indicates an implicit expectation of role-based deference. In institutional settings, particularly academic or professional ones, there are often unspoken norms that govern interaction based on status and role. The student's behaviour is perceived to have breached these norms, not only by questioning the narrator's professional integrity, but by doing so in a way that disregards the expected asymmetry in their social positions. The notion of "boundaries" here refers to socially understood limits on what kind of evaluative behaviour is acceptable from someone in the student's

position. The offence is rooted not simply in the comment itself, but in the misalignment between the speaker's role and the behaviour enacted, which challenges the narrator's perceived entitlement to professional recognition and respect.

5.9 Conclusion

This chapter examined the lived experiences of participants who reported feeling offended in various contexts. Through thematic analysis of the diary report data, seven distinct themes were identified, each pointing to a specific type of expectation whose unfulfillment triggered feelings of offence.

A recurring source of offence across the data was the unfulfillment of quality face (see section 5.3, examples 1 & 2), which is the desire to be recognised for one's abilities and competence (Spencer-Oatey, 2002, 2008). Participants often recounted being dismissed or underestimated, particularly in professional settings, where their skills or potential were overlooked. These moments not only threatened their self-worth but were frequently accompanied by a sense of unfairness, pointing to an overlap with equity rights, the expectation of being treated justly (Spencer-Oatey, 2008).

Another common theme involved violations of interpersonal expectations within close relationships (see Section 5.4, examples 3,4). In these cases, offence was not triggered by what was said or done, but by who said it. To explain, participants emphasised that they were offended because the behaviour came from someone described as 'close' and someone the participant considered 'like a sister'. The relationships in these examples were marked by closeness, which came with implicit expectations of how the other person should behave. When these expectations were not met, and the behaviour did not align with what is normally expected in close relationships, participants reported feelings of sadness, disappointment, and, in some cases, a loss of trust (Chen, Boucher & Tapias, 2006; Spencer-Oatey, 2011).

Participants also described taking offence when their equity expectations were disregarded (see Section 5.5, examples 5,6 & 7). They expressed frustration in situations where they felt people were not considerate and were unfair with them by asking them to contribute financially during hardship, ignoring turn-taking among taxi drivers, or skipping the queue. In all of these situations, offence was perceived due to the violation of implicit expectations that others would act with fairness and consideration (Spencer-Oatey, 2000).

Further, several participants narrated experiences where they had 'extended help' or 'favours', often framed using culturally significant terms like *maṣrūf* and *xidma*, but were met with suspicion, or even hostility (see section 5.6, examples 8,9 & 10). In these instances, participants reported feeling

offended when their intention behind the favour was misunderstood, and on some occasions, the favour was not acknowledged or reciprocated in any meaningful way. These accounts point to the social expectations surrounding acts of help, where providing assistance carries an implicit expectation of some form of recognition. While traditional understandings of reciprocity often centre on a balance of exchange (Culpeper & Tantucci, 2021), the data here suggest that offence also arose when the intent behind the favour was misinterpreted.

Moreover, other participants described feeling offended when they were denied the opportunity to participate, engage, or express themselves in contexts where such engagement was expected (see section 5.7 examples 11 & 12). The examples narrated point to the violation of association rights, which is the entitlement to inclusion and emotional involvement in interaction (Spencer-Oatey, 2008). For instance, one participant reported feeling marginalised in a school environment that prioritised finishing the curriculum over letting students express their opinions, while another described being frowned upon at home for being upset.

The final theme in this chapter involved offence arising from the failure to receive the level of deference participants expected based on their institutional roles (see Section 5.8, examples 13 and 14 for more details). In this context, the term *ihtirām* was used by participants to express expectations of role-based deference, rather than respect. Offence was perceived when others failed to show appropriate recognition in line with the participant's role; for example, when students made inappropriate remarks in front of others or accused them of not doing their job. These incidents were seen as violations of expected treatment tied to social and institutional roles (Shils, 1982; Spencer-Oatey, 2008).

CHAPTER 6: RESULTS - PHASE 1 (A)

6.1 Introduction

This chapter presents the findings of Phase 1 of the study, which investigates how incivility is perceived, framed, and evaluated in online discourse within the Omani context. The focus is on naturally occurring posts from X, where users comment on or report behaviour they consider inappropriate in shared spaces. The data were collected using two hashtags in the Arabic language (see Section 6.2, Table 6.1), chosen to capture a range of expressions that reflect users' responses to perceived incivility.

The analysis is structured in two interconnected stages. The first stage involves a corpus-driven analysis, with a focus on frequency and concordance analysis of phrases surrounding the selected hashtags. This stage aims to identify common lexical items and recurring patterns that appear in users' descriptions of uncivil behaviours. By examining how often particular terms occur and how they are used in context, this layer of analysis offers insights into the linguistic framing of incivility and the kinds of behaviour that attract public critique or disapproval.

The second part of the analysis builds on the patterns observed in the corpus analysis through a thematic analysis, which explores the underlying norms that inform users' evaluations of incivility. These norms emerge through users' reactions to perceived breaches of appropriate conduct. The thematic analysis draws on Spencer-Oatey's (2008, 2011) rapport management framework to interpret how judgements of incivility are shaped by perceived violations of face, sociality rights and obligations within the Omani context.

This chapter is divided into two main sections. Section 6.2 presents the corpus-based analysis of four selected hashtags. Each subsection (6.2.1 to 6.2.2) focuses on a different hashtag, examining its lexical context. Following this, section 6.3 presents the thematic analysis, and outlines the main themes that emerged from the data, demonstrating how incivility is constructed in relation to social norms. Finally, the chapter concludes with a summary of the main insights from both layers of analysis and their relevance to the next phase of the study.

6.2 Corpus driven analysis

Given that two hashtags were selected for this study (see Table 6.1), two separate corpora were constructed accordingly. To explore how incivility is expressed in connection with each hashtag, attention was directed toward the immediate textual context in which the hashtag appeared. Specifically, the analysis focused on identifying and extracting the words or phrases that occurred directly before the hashtag across the dataset, as these often carry important evaluative or descriptive content.

The goal was to determine how users linguistically frame or introduce acts they consider uncivil, and to examine whether particular lexical patterns consistently emerge across different posts. This process was guided by the following questions:

- What comes before the hashtag? (referred to as -1 Gram)
- What is the frequency of -1 Gram? (referred to as frequency 1)
- What is the concordance of each -1gram + the hashtag? (referred to as concordance)
- What is the frequency of the concordance? (referred to as frequency 2)
- What is the setting of the act? (referred to as setting)

Hashtags	Translation	Transcription
# غير حضاري	uncivil	/ʕe:r ħa'dʕɑ:ri:/
# غير لائق	Inappropriate	/ʕe:r la:ʔiq/

Table 6.1: Hashtags

6.2.1 Hashtag 1: Corpus

Setting	Frequency 2	Concordance	Hashtag	-1 Gram	Frequency 1
"الأحياء السكنية" "residential neighbourhood"	2	"حيوانات سائبة " "stray animals"			
"أماكن سياحية" "touristic places"	8				
"السبب" "Al Seeb"					
"صلالة " "Salalah"					
		"رمي المخلفات"			

"الرسّاق" "Al Rustaq"		"throwing rubbish"	غير حضاري uncivil]] /ye:r ħa'dʕa:ri: / /	منظر view /'mandʕar /
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"سوق السمك بمطرح" "Mutrah fish market"	1	"ترك بلا مواقف منظمة. فوضى عارمة في مواقف "it was left without an organised parking. a chaotic mess in the parking lot"			
"صندوق تبرع بالملايس" "clothing donation box"	1	"أليس ينبغي أن نتبرع بأفضل الأشياء ..." " shouldn't we donate the best items ...?"			
"صلاة" "Salalah"	2	"التفريط على بيئة الخضراء" "drifting on green spaces"			
"الأودية" "wadi"	1	"المجازفة ودخول مجاري" "الأودية" "taking risks and entering the riverbeds"			
"على الطريق" "on the road"	1	"التفل" "spitting"			
"صلاة" "Salalah"	5	"رمي المخلفات" "throwing garbage"			
"بنك" "bank"					
"منتزه" "park"	1	"يشوهون منتزهاتنا وشواطئنا" "defacing & parks and beaches"			
"محافظة ظفار" "governorate of Dhofar"	1	"عدم احترام الطبيعة وتشويه منظر العام" "disrespecting nature and spoiling the public view"			
"صلاة" "Salalah"	6	"ترك المخلفات او رميها" ng or throwing away waste"			
"مسقط" "Muscat"					
"سهول وسفوح الجبال" "plains and mountain foothills"					
"الطريق" "road"	1	"تصوير ضحايا الحوادث" "المروية" "Filming traffic accident victims"			

"مواقف" "parking"	1	"استخدام مواقف ذوي الاحتياجات الخاصة" "using people with special needs parking spaces"	/su'lu:k/	
"مواقف مخصصة لمركبات المعاقين" "disabled parking space"	2	"الوقوف في أماكن مخصصة لمركبات المعاقين" "parking in spaces designated for disabled people"		
"جدران المنازل والمرافق العامة" "house walls and public facilities"	1	"الكتابة على الجدران" "writing on the walls"	ظاهرة [phenom enon] /'ðɑ:.hi.r a/	5
"ساحل" "shore"	1	"الكلاب الغير ضالة" "non-stray dogs"		
"الأماكن السياحية" "tourist spots"	1	"تلويث الأماكن السياحية بالمخلفات من قبل السياح" "polluting tourist spots with litter by tourists"		
"وسط مساكن العائلات" "among family residences"	1	"سكنات الأيدي العاملة الوافدة" "expatriate workers accommodation"		
"الأماكن والساحات العامة" "public places and squares"	3	"رمي النفايات والمخلفات" "throwing trash and waste"	ممارسات [practice s] /mu.ma: ra:'sa:t/	3
"الأماكن السياحية" "tourist spots"				

Table 6.2: Corpus analysis of hashtag 1 (#غير حضاري - uncivil)

Table 2 presents the result of the analysis of the hashtag /ʔe:r ħɑ'dʕɑ:ri:/, [uncivil] taken from a corpus of 1815 words. The following points briefly summarise the table:

1. The hashtag /ʔe:r ħɑ'dʕɑ:ri:/, [uncivil] collocates with six main words referred to as -1 Gram in the table. The words are "ظاهرة", "سلوك", "تصرف", "مشهد", "منظر" and "ممارسات" which are translated to [view], [scene], [behaviour], [behaviour], [phenomenon] and [practices].
2. The most frequent word used among all of these is /'manðar/ which is equivalent to [view], it was mentioned 16 times, followed by /su'lu:k/ and its synonym /tʕa'sʕar.ruf/ which are both equivalent to [behaviour] being mentioned 14 and 13 times.
3. The frequent mention of /'manðar/ and /'maʃ.had/ refers to the visual aspect of acts that are

described to be uncivil while the rest of the words describes action aspect of the uncivil act.

4. Based on the concordance line across the whole corpus, the most frequent uncivil act based on all of the -Grams is "رمي المخلفات" which is translated to "throwing rubbish". It was mentioned 8 times in relation to the word /'manðar/ while in relation to its synonym /'maʃ.had/ it was mentioned 3 times. Additionally, with the word /tʃa'sʃar.ruf/, it was mentioned 5 times, and with its synonym /su'lu:k/, "throwing rubbish" appeared 6 times. Lastly, it appeared 3 times with the word /mu.ma:l.ra:'sa:t/.
5. The fact that "throwing rubbish" emerged as the most frequently mentioned issue as it was reported 25 times in this corpus, highlights the concern about this act.
6. Furthermore, across the corpus, the phrase "throwing rubbish" was articulated in various other ways such as "يشوهون منتزهاتنا وشواطئنا" translated to "defacing our parks and beaches", "المنظر العام", "عدم احترام الطبيعة و تشويه" which is equivalent to "disrespecting nature and spoiling the public view" and "تلويث الأماكن السياحية" translated to "polluting tourist spots".
7. Another uncivil act that was mentioned related to nature is "التفحيط على البيئة الخضراء" translated to "drifting on green spaces".
8. The most common setting associated with throwing rubbish was 'touristic places', 'Salalah', which is a famous touristic, and the capital city 'Muscat' along with 'parks and beaches'.
9. Furthermore, there is a frequent mention of "parking in space designated for disabled people", and it was described to be /'ðʃa:hi.ra/ which is translated to a "phenomenon". Using the phrase "ظاهرة" with this act "indicates that the behaviour is not just a one- time occurrence but it is happening frequently.
10. There is an emphasis on uncivil "view" and "phenomena" in relation to "expatriate workers" in two different contexts. To explain, Omanis find it uncivil for "expatriate workers" to have their accommodation "among family residence". The second context is having many of "expatriate workers" in touristic sites specifically "Nizwa Market".
11. Furthermore, there are a few tweets that described the "lack of organisation" as uncivil "view" and "scene". For example, the lack of organization in front of touristic site "Sultan Qaboos port" and the struggle to arrange a taxi. In another scene, the commenter described Mutrah Fish Market parking to be in "a chaotic mess" due to lack of organised parking. In both examples, the commentor considered this uncivil not just because of the act of "lack of organization" but because the locations of both of these places are considered to be touristic and the center of Muscat.
12. Moreover, the corpus also highlights several acts that are considered uncivil such as "spitting

on the road”, and “writing on the wall” as well as the presence of “stray animals” close to the residential area and presence of “non-stray dogs” along the coast.

13. Other behaviours that were reported on X as “uncivil scenes” are driving in reverse during congestion and “filming and crowding” and “taking pictures at accident scenes”.

6.2.2 Hashtag 2: Corpus

Setting	Frequency	Concordance	Hashtag	-1 Gram	Frequency
" السبب" “ Al Seeb”	1	" روائح كريهة بالإضافة الي تكس بعض مخلفات الأشجار" “unpleasant odours, in addition to the accumulation of some tree debris”	غير لائق [inappropriate] /ʕe:r la:ʔiq/	منظر view /ˈmanðar/	14
"المسجد والشارع والمستشفى و الجهات الحكومية" “mosque, on the street, and the hospital and government department ”	1	"لايس بجامه نوم" “wearing pyjamas”			
" حديقة عامة" “public park”	5	"رمي القمامة في " “throwing garbage”			
"الاماكن العامة" “public places”					
" الاماكن السياحية" “ tourist”					
" جامع السلطان قابوس" “Sultan Qaboos Grand Mosque”	1	" يتزاحمون امام السيارات" “crowding in front of the cars”			
" قلب مسقط" “heart of Muscat”	1	" انعدام رصيف مهيا للمشى وإضاءة ضعيفة" “the lack of a proper sidewalk and poor lighting"			
" حظائر " “ barn”	1	" رائحة الحظائر ملاذ للحشرات " “the smell of the barn is a heaven for insects”			
" مكينه السحب " “ATM machine”	1	" إذا كنت ما تحتاج للإيصال ليش تطبعه؟ “ If you don’t need the receipt, why print it ?!”			
" امام بيت من بيوت الله " “in front of one of god’s houses”	1	" عرض السيارات " “displaying cars”			

"سوق مطرح" "Mutrah souq"	1	ابتزاز الباعة للمتسوقين وتلك بالإلزامهم بالشراء "vendors blackmailing shoppers by forcing them to buy"		
"مرسى ميناء شنه" "Shannah Port Quay"	1	"شاحنات وبعض السيارات العطلانه بمرسى ميناء شنه" "trucks and some broken-down cars at the Shannah Port"		
"في نهار رمضان" In broad daylight, in Radman"	1	"وليس دشداشة عمانية ويأكل ويشرب قدام الناس" "wearing an Omani dishdasha and eats and drinks in front of people"		
"في الشارع" "in the street"	1	"بليس غير لائق" "wearing inappropriate dress."		
"المواقع السياحية" "tourist sites"	1	"..من بعض الشباب المتهور في ..." "...some reckless young people at tourist sites.."		
-	1	"هذه المستوى من الانتحطاط الأخلاقي و التعدي لولاة امرنا" "this level of moral degradation and violating our leaders"		
"مقطع" "video clip"	1	"شباب يرقصوا... لابسين الخنجر العماني" "men dancing ..wearing the Omani dagger"		
"الجهات الحكومية... و مراكز الأحوال المدنية.. "government entities ...and Civil status centre"	1	"نخليص معاملة بينطلون وقميص" "clearing a transaction in pants and a shirt"		
-	1	"عمل بث فيه تحريض على التمرد على القيم والعادات" "broadcasting content that incites rebellion against our values, customs"		
"مقاطع" "video clip"	1	"شركات تظهر بمقاطع... وبالزّي العماني" "companies appear in clips... and in Omani dress"		
			تصرف/تصرفات behaviour /tʃaˈsʃar.ruf/	
			بشكل And بطريقة [in a way] /biˈʃikl/ /ba.tʃaˈri:.qa/	3
			محتوى [content] /muhˈtawa:/	2
			مقاطع [videos] /maˈqa:tiʃ/	1

–		"تؤثر سلباً على هوية الكمة العمانية" "negatively affect the identity of the Omani cap"		ألوان وزخارف [colours & decoration] /ʔal'wa:n wa za'xa:rif/	1
"المنتزهات" "parks"	1	"ترك النفايات" "leaving trash"		عمل [action] /ʕa.mal/	2
-	1	"تخريب اللوحات الإعلانية الدعائية" "vandalizing the advertising billboards"			

Table 6.3: Corpus analysis of hashtag 1 (#غير لائق - inappropriate)

Table 3 presents the result of the analysis of the hashtag /ʕe:r la:ʔiq/ taken from a corpus of 1279 words. The following points provide a concise overview of the table:

1. The hashtag /ʕe:r ʔa'dʕa:ri:/, [inappropriate] collocates with six main words referred to as -1 Gram in the table. The words are "عمل", "محتوى", "بشكل", "تصرف", "منظر" and which are translated to [view], [behaviour], [in a way], and [action]. There are a few other words mentioned that were used once like but were included in the table due to some similarities in the concordance line like "مقاطع" and "ألوان وزخارف" which translate to [video clips] and [colours & decoration].
2. The most frequent word used before the hashtag /ʕe:r la:ʔiq/ is /'manðar/, [view] which is similar to the result of the /ʕe:r ʔa'dʕa:ri:/ hashtag. It was mentioned for 14 times. It suggests that the commenters usually label "views" to be uncivil and inappropriate. It is followed by /tʕa'sʕar.ruf/ and bi'ʃikl/ or /ba.tʕa'ri:.qa/ which both occurred 3 times.
3. Throughout all the categories, the most recurrent inappropriate act is "throwing garbage"; it occurred 6 times.
4. The most mentioned setting in which this view and behaviour were witnessed is "public parks" and "tourist places".
5. In addition to "throwing garbage", there are few more environmental related issues that were reported in the tweets that are viewed to be "inappropriate" such as "unpleasant odours, "smell of barn" close to residential areas and printing ATM receipts despite not needing it.
6. Moreover, the table highlights that there is concern about wearing pyjamas in public as well as wearing pants in certain settings. To explain, Omanis consider it "inappropriate" to wear clothes in public that are typically worn at home for sleeping or lounging. The commenter specifically mentioned places where he witnessed the act, which are streets, mosques and hospitals and in governmental places. In regard to wearing pants, it is considered inappropriate to wear anything

other than the Omani traditional attire within government entities.

7. Furthermore, data also highlighted elements of traditional attire such as the Omani dishdasha, cap, and dagger goes in relations to certain acts like dancing and eating during Ramdan.
8. A number of traffic safety concerns were described to be inappropriate such as worshippers gathering in front of car due to not having pedestrian bridge near Sultan Qaboos Mosque as well as lack of proper sidewalks and poor lighting near the Grand Mall.
9. Moreover, some of the tweets reflect deep concern about practices and behaviours that are seen as contrary to cultural and the Omani morals such as “vendors blackmailing shoppers by forcing them to buy” as it “offends the morals of the Omani traders”. Also, by “violating our leader” was considered not only inappropriate but also was described to be “a moral degradation”.

6.3 Thematic analysis of the corpus

Building on the patterns identified in the corpus analysis, this section presents the thematic analysis of the X dataset, focusing on how incivility is constructed and evaluated. While the frequency and concordance analysis offered an initial view of commonly co-occurring expressions and the immediate linguistic context surrounding the hashtags, the thematic analysis moves beyond these surface patterns to offer a deeper exploration of how frequently occurring patterns in the data reflect widely held, but often implicit, norms that inform evaluations of incivility. This analysis aims to uncover the underlying sociocultural norms that shape users' judgements by closely examining specific instances of recurring linguistic patterns associated with the hashtags *غير حضاري* ('uncivilised') and *غير لائق* ('inappropriate'). As with offence, these evaluations are not arbitrary but socially constructed and negotiated through discourse (Culpeper, 2011; Locher & Watts, 2005). Moments in which users call out incivility often reveal expectations about proper public conduct expectations that, while not always explicitly stated, are nevertheless discursively invoked.

To interpret the nature of these violated norms and expectations, the thematic analysis is informed by Spencer-Oatey's rapport management framework (2002, 2008), which offers a structured approach to understanding the grounds that participants allude to when justifying their judgements particularly those related to face sensitivities, sociality rights, and obligations. This framework enables a more nuanced interpretation of why certain behaviours are judged as uncivil in the data, and what these judgements reveal about the values embedded in the sociocultural context in which they are made. Nonetheless, as explained in the methodology chapter, Section 3.7, it is the data that direct me, not the categories of the framework itself.

The following analysis reveals the underlying norms that shape and inform societal expectations

regarding appropriate behaviours. While the data includes a variety of behaviours regarding appropriate behaviour, such as throwing rubbish, eating during Ramadan, and wearing inappropriate clothing, the thematic analysis does not group the findings according to these individual acts. Instead, the themes are organised around the broader social norms that these behaviours are perceived to violate. This approach allows for a clearer understanding of how users construct and evaluate incivility in discourse, not simply based on the nature of the act, but on the specific normative expectations it is seen to breach.

6.4 Themes overview

The following table summarises the themes and the sub-themes found in the data, followed by sections elaborating on them:

Themes
Failure to uphold the norm of adhering to Islamic teachings
Failure to adhere to the norm of projecting a positive image of the area
Failure to uphold the norm of shared responsibility for maintaining cleanliness
Failure to uphold Omani identity norms

Table 6.4: Overview of X data themes

6.5 Failure to uphold the norm of adhering to Islamic teachings

A key normative expectation evident in the data is that individuals should behave in ways that reflect and uphold Islamic teachings. In the Omani context, Islam is not only a religious belief system but a deeply embedded reference for social conduct, contributing to people's understanding of what is appropriate and inappropriate. Acts such as littering on many occasions were judged as violations of religious obligations. These judgements are frequently supported by references to Islamic principles, such as 'cleanliness is part of faith' and public appeals to religious conscience.

These reactions are understood as responses to breaches of sociality obligations where the source of the obligations is religion. As Spencer-Oatey (2008) and Spencer-Oatey and Kádár (2021) note sociality obligations may arise from behavioural conventions, and in this context, those conventions are shaped by Islamic teachings that establish cleanliness as a religious norm. In this sense, incivility is constructed as a religious failure, in which individuals are judged not only for what they did but for failing to live up to a norm that is expected of them as members of a religious community.

The following examples from the data illustrate how incivility is framed as a violation of Islamic teachings:

(1)

"غيب الوازع الديني اولا وانعدام الوعي لدي السائح ينتج عن ذلك سلوك غير حضاري ل يقبله النسان المسلم ابدا "

“ the absence of religious conscience, first and foremost, and the lack of awareness among tourists result in uncivilized behaviour that is completely unacceptable to a Muslim person”.

(2)

"أسلوب غير حضاري... في حديقة بركاء بعد فعالية المخيني يا ناس احنا اهل دين ونظافة وبش هذا الأسلوب كل حد رمي زبالته "

“ uncivilised way... in Barka after the Makhaini’s even. People we are people of religion and cleanliness. What is this behaviour? Everyone just threw their trash”.

(3)

"للأسف ممارسات خاطئة غير حضارية تتكرر واولها ترك القمامة بشكل لا يليق بالإنسان الحضاري الذي امره الاسلام بالنظافة والثاني هو تجميع القمامة في كيس النفايات وتركه في محله فتأتي الماشية وتنتشره في كل مكان وكلا التصرفين خاطئ ، لذلك فرض الغرامة المالية هو الحل السليم"

“unfortunately, wrong and uncivil are practices continue to occur. The first is leaving garbage in a way that does not befit a civilised person who is commanded by Islam to be clean and the second is collecting garbage in a garbage bag and leaving it in its places then the goats gather and scatter it everywhere. Both actions are wrong, so imposing a financial penalty is the proper solution”.

4)

"و إطارات مرمية بجانب المجمع الرياضي بالبريمي منظر غير حضاري و غير لائق بمدخل الولاية و تشويه للمظهر العام (رسالة إلى الجهات المعنية)- النظافة من الإيمان"

“...tires discarded next to the sports complex in Al Buraimi uncivil and inappropriate view at the entrance of the wilaya and it distort the public view (message to the concerned authorities)- cleanliness is part of faith”.

In post (1), the commenter expressed frustration over the trash left behind by attendees after an event, stating that “everyone just threw their trash.” To highlight that this behaviour deviated from expected norms, the commenter emphasised a shared Islamic identity by writing, “People, we are people of religion and cleanliness.” The use of the collective “we” constructs a shared identity grounded in Islamic values, implying that there are common religiously informed norms about how members of society should behave in public spaces.

By identifying the group as 'people of religion', the commenter positions Islam as the framework that guides everyday conduct. In this context, cleanliness is not simply a matter of civic duty, but a religious expectation. This is further reinforced in post (4), where another user writes, 'Cleanliness is part of faith'. By framing cleanliness as an aspect of religious identity, both tweets reveal how uncivil behaviour, such as littering, is not just seen as inappropriate, but as a violation of religiously derived social obligations. The act is evaluated as uncivil precisely because it fails to align with norms that are grounded in Islamic teachings, which function as a shared moral and behavioural reference point in Omani society.

Along the same lines, post (2) reflects deep concern about repeated uncivil behaviours, particularly the act of leaving trash in public spaces and the improper disposal of waste. These actions are described as behaviour that "does not befit a civilised person who is commanded by Islam to be clean." This unified statement merges both social and religious expectations into a single evaluative judgement. The phrase suggests that being "civilised" involves not only meeting communal standards of cleanliness but also adhering to religious obligations. By referencing Islam's command to be clean, the commenter introduces a religious dimension to the concept of civility, framing these acts as violations of Islamic teachings. In this context, cleanliness is not merely a matter of social etiquette or civic responsibility; it is presented as a religious duty. Therefore, when individuals fail to maintain cleanliness, their behaviour is judged not only as inappropriate but as a breach of obligations grounded in both social and religious norms.

Moreover, example (3) reinforces this religious framing by linking the absence of religious conscience to the emergence of uncivil behaviour. The commenter attributes the act of littering to a lack of religious awareness stating that such behaviour is "unacceptable to a Muslim person". This phrase underscores the belief that Islamic teachings provide clear behavioural guidance, and that deviation from these expectations results in conduct judged as uncivilised. Here, incivility is constructed not as a failure to internalise and act upon religious obligations.

To sum up, these posts (1,2,3 & 4) demonstrate that littering is judged not only as a civic or environmental issue but more importantly, as a violation of Islamic norms. They reflect a broader understanding within the discourse that cleanliness is an expectation derived from religious teachings, and that breaching this expectation constitutes a violation of sociality obligations whose source is Islam.

6.6 Failure to adhere to the norm of projecting a positive image of the area

A significant number of posts demonstrate that littering is perceived as an act that tarnishes the image of the area. This notion refers to behaviours that are seen to contribute negatively to how a location is perceived, both by locals and outsiders. The commenters place great concern on how the area is presented to others and how the area is perceived by others, which indicates that members of the society are expected to uphold a positive image of the area. In other words, individuals are held accountable not just for their actions, but also for how these actions impact the collective image of the area. This concern with public image aligns with Spencer-Oatey's (2008) concept of social identity face, which refers to the desire for one's group to be positively evaluated.

While Spencer-Oatey's (2008) notion of social identity face typically refers to groups and their desire to be positively evaluated, this study extends the concept to include the way places are discursively treated as extensions of the community's image. When a public space becomes dirty, neglected, or misrepresented particularly in tourist sites like Ras Al Jinz Turtle Reserve or public parks like Riyam the behaviour is judged as uncivilised or inappropriate, because it reflects poorly on the identity and values of the area's residents or caretakers. The following examples demonstrate how incivility is constructed as a threat to the social identity associated with the area and, by extension, the wider community.

(5)

"تسالني عن الحال...هذه هو الحال، كانت من أنظف الولايات ولاية دباء ولكن الآن صارت هذه المناظر منتشرة في ربوع الولاية، للأسف الشديد، بحت حناجرنا من المطالبات ولكن لا حياة لمن تتادي السؤال: اين المعنيين اين المشرفين في الشركة لماذا ننقل صورة غير حضارية عن الولاية بسبب إهمال مسؤول"

"You ask me about the situation... this is the situation, Dibba used to be one of cleanest region, but now these scenes are widespeared throughout the region, unfortunately. Our voices have gone hoarse from making demands, but it is like talking to a wall. The question is where are the supervisors in the company? **Why are we conveying an uncivilised image of the region due to negligence of a responsible party**"

(6)

"منظر غير لائق لمكان سياحي يرتاده سياح وهذا الامر يعكس سلبا عن المكان بتصرف فردي في محمية السلاحف في راس الجنز. القمامة منتشرة بكل بقعه"

"An inappropriate scene at a tourist spot frequented by **tourists reflects negatively on the place due to an individual's actions** at Ras Al Jinz Reserve. Garbage is scattered everywhere"

(7)

"اخواني في بلدية مسقط هذا منظر غير لائق بتاتا في حديقة عامة مثل حديقة الريام وهناك الكثير من الزوار لهذه المناظر"

"My brothers at Muscat Municipality, this is completely inappropriate scenes in public park like Riyam Park, and there are many **visitors to these sights**"

The data reveals a recurring concern with how uncivil behaviour, particularly littering, impacts the way public spaces and, by extension, entire communities are perceived. In tweet (5), the commenter contrasts the past and present condition of Dibba, noting that it “was one of the cleanest wilayas” but is now associated with “uncivilised images.” This shift is attributed to the “negligence of a responsible party,” and the rhetorical question “Why are we projecting an uncivilised image of the wilaya?” clearly reflects an underlying expectation: that residents and officials are responsible for maintaining a positive and respectable image of the place. The emphasis is not only on cleanliness but on the collective image the area conveys to outsiders. This suggests a norm in which public spaces are expected to visually represent the values and standards of their communities.

A similar concern is expressed in tweet (6), where the commenter criticises the presence of garbage at a popular tourist destination. The post highlights that the issue “reflects negatively on the place,” suggesting that the act of littering is evaluated not just for its environmental harm but for how it affects the site's public image. The concern is intensified by the fact that the location is frequently visited by tourists, which elevates the expectation that such spaces should be well-maintained and orderly. Tweet (7) builds on this theme by noting the presence of “many visitors” to Riyam Park and calling the visual state of the area “completely inappropriate.” Here, the presence of an external audience makes the failure to maintain the space more consequential, as it threatens the way the area and, implicitly, the community is perceived.

Across these tweets, incivility is not judged solely as a violation of cleanliness or environmental standards, but as a threat to the social identity face of the community. In this case, the places themselves like ‘parks’ and ‘tourist sites’, are discursively treated as representations of the community, and uncivil behaviours such as littering are evaluated based on the damage they do to that collective image. The concern is not only with what was done, but with how it makes the area, and by extension, its people appear to others.

6.7 Failure to uphold the norm of shared responsibility for maintaining cleanliness

Another recurring norm identified in the data is the expectation that all members of society share the responsibility for maintaining cleanliness in public spaces. Across tweets, behaviours such as littering are frequently described as ‘uncivil’ or ‘inappropriate’ and these evaluations are often accompanied by concerns about a lack of communal responsibility. Rather than focusing solely on the physical act, commenters highlight how such behaviour reflects a broader disregard for the shared duty to care for public environments. In this sense, the act is constructed as uncivil not solely

due to its visible impact on the environment, but because it signifies a failure to fulfill a socially expected obligation of collective responsibility.

In this context, shared societal responsibility refers to the collective obligation of individuals and groups within a society to maintain the cleanliness and orderliness of public spaces. The data reveals a clear belief that this responsibility should not fall solely on specific groups such as municipal workers or local authorities but is a role shared across the community. This expectation reflects what Spencer-Oatey (2000, 2008) describes as sociality obligations the behaviours individuals feel others *should or should not* perform based on socially shared expectations. In the data, this sense of obligation is explicitly appealed to, as seen in repeated calls such as “كن مسؤولاً” which translates to ‘be responsible’. These appeals demonstrate that the evaluation of incivility is grounded in a clear expectation that individuals must contribute to the upkeep of shared spaces. The obligation here is shaped by behavioural conventions tied to communal life: individuals are expected not only to act responsibly themselves but also to ensure that others, such as family members or domestic workers, act in accordance with these norms. The following examples illustrate how the expectations and obligations discussed above are reflected in everyday discourse, where acts of littering are evaluated as breaches of shared social responsibility:

(8)

"ممارسات غير حضارية تتم عن قلة الوعي وضعف المسؤولية المجتمعية من بينها رمي المخلفات والنفايات في الاماكن والساحات العامة انعكاسات بيئية وصحية وتشويه للوجه الحضاري والقيم الجمالية للمنطقة بسبب رمي المخلفات"

“uncivilized practices **that reflect a lack of awareness and weak societal reasonability**, including throwing garbage and rubbish in public places and squares. Environmental and health repercussion and tarnish the civilized image and aesthetic values of the area due to this disposal of waste”.

(9)

"هذه بعض الصور التي رأيته اليوم لدى زيارتي لوادي بدبد للأسف الشديد ممارسات غير حضارية من قبل بعض مرتادي المواقع السياحية ومن جانب آخر لم أرى حاوية قمامة قريبة من الموقع حتى يتسنى للناس رمي قمامتهم فيها طبعاً ليس عذراً لرمي القمامة في الموقع. **كن مسؤولاً**"

“here are some photos I took during my visit to Wadi Bidbid, unfortunately, I witnessed uncivilized behaviour by some visitors to this tourist spot. On the other hand, **I didn’t see any trash bins nearby** which would allow people to dispose their garbage properly. Of course **this is not an excuse to litter** the area. **Be responsible**”.

(10)

هذا مشهد غير حضاري ومتكرر للأسف الشديد! رمي أكياس القمامة بجانب الحاويات رغم إنها فاضية حتى لو كان عاملات المنازل فهي مسؤولة الأسرة في توعيتهم بخطأ هذا التصرف! ال يعكس هذا ثقافة السرة ونظافتها؟

“Unfortunately, this is an uncivilised behaviour and recurring scene! Throwing garbage bags next to the containers even though they are empty even **if they are domestic workers, it is the family’s responsibility to educate them about the wrongfulness of this behaviour!** Doesn’t this reflect the family’s and their cleanliness?!”

The expectation of shared responsibility is made explicit across the dataset through commenters’ direct appeals to behavioural obligation. In tweet (8), the act of littering in public spaces is described as ‘uncivil practices’ that reflect both ‘a lack of awareness’ and ‘weak societal responsibility’. This framing constructs incivility as a recurring failure to meet the normative expectation that all members of society contribute to the care of public spaces. The evaluation goes beyond the act of littering itself, linking it to wider social consequences such as environmental and health damage, and to the degradation of the area’s aesthetic and civilised image. In doing so, the tweet reinforces the idea that incivility arises not merely from what is done, but by from, whether individuals are seen to meet the socially expected obligation to contribute to the upkeep of shared spaces. Similarly, in tweet (9), the failure to fulfil this shared responsibility is made explicit through the phrase ‘be responsible’ which functions as a direct appeal to individual behavioural obligation. Moreover, although the commenter acknowledges that no rubbish bins were available nearby, this is immediately dismissed as a justification for littering. The assertion that the absence of bins is “*not an excuse*” signals that the expectation to act responsibly remains intact, regardless of situational constraints.

Further, this sense of obligation is extended beyond individuals to include family members and domestic workers. Tweet (10) condemns the act of placing garbage beside an empty bin, stating that “even if it is the housemaid, the family is responsible for teaching her that this behaviour is wrong.” This view reflects an expectation not only to act appropriately but to guide others in accordance with social norms. In this case, the conventions surrounding the use of public space carry prescriptive force. The frustration expressed in the data reflects that these conventions have evolved into clearly perceived obligations which when unfulfilled, lead to the behaviour being labelled as uncivil. These examples show that incivility is evaluated in relation to failure to meet culturally embedded expectations of shared responsibility, rather than the act itself.

6.8 Upholding Omani identity norms

One of the most dominant themes that emerged in the thematic analysis is the failure to uphold

Omani identity norms. This theme captures public reaction to behaviours that are perceived as incompatible with what is expected of individuals who visibly or culturally represent Omani identity. These expectations encompass both cultural values, social traditions, and moral traits associated with the Omani character, as well as everyday social conventions such as how individuals dress and present themselves in public settings like government offices or mosques.

In the dataset, Omani identity is constructed as something both symbolically marked and socially performed. Cultural symbols such as الزي العماني [Omani dress], الخنجر العماني [the khanjar], and العمانية الكمة [the Omani cap], as observed in the corpus analysis (see Chapter 6, Section 6.2.2), not only signal belonging, but also activate specific behavioural expectations. When individuals who display these markers act in ways that contradict those expectations, they are judged not merely for the behaviour itself, but for the perceived mismatch between their visible identity and their public conduct.

In addition to symbolic markers, Omani identity is also expressed through behavioural expectations that operate at both explicit and implicit levels. These include explicit institutional obligations such as dress codes in government offices as well as widely shared, unwritten obligations about how individuals should dress, and present themselves in public. When these expectations are not met, behaviour is not simply judged in isolation but evaluated in light of broader social standards of appropriateness. In this way, identity is not just worn through visible symbols it is also performed through everyday conduct that aligns with collective understandings of what it means to behave like an Omani.

This pattern is best understood through Spencer-Oatey's (2008) concepts of social identity face and sociality obligations, which help explain how incivility is evaluated. Social identity face, which refers to the desire for one's group membership to be positively evaluated by others. In these instances, identity carries behavioural obligations. In parallel, sociality obligations are the behavioural expectations individuals believe others should or should not do (Spencer-Oatey, 2008). In parallel, sociality obligations are the things individuals feel others should or should not do that are derived from various sources. In the context of this study, when individuals are visibly marked as Omani through dress for; example, they are implicitly expected to act in ways that align with what the group collectively values and upholds. These visible markers come with a sense of obligation, whereby the person is expected to behave in accordance with shared norms. When such expectations are not met, the behaviour is not simply seen as inappropriate on an individual level, but as a violation that risks undermining the group's positive identity in the eyes of others. In this way, the concepts of identity face and sociality obligations work together to explain how and why certain acts are judged

as uncivil: not because of the acts alone, but because of the social expectations attached to the identities of those performing them.

(11)

" لا حسيت انها احتقار وما الومهم لأنه فعلا تصرف غير لائق ابدأ في نهار رمضان من شخص مسلم وعماني ولايس دشداشة عمانية ويأكل ويشرب قدام العالم "

"No I felt it was contempt, and I don't blame them because it is indeed inappropriate behaviour during daytime in Ramadan from a Muslim person and an Omani and wears an Omani dishdasha and eats and drinks Infront of the people"

(12)

" عدم الاهتمام بالتاريخ والحفاظ على الهوية العمانية والعادات والتقاليد سبب من أسباب حالنا اليوم وللأسف الان نجينا شركات وتظهر بمقاطع غير لائقة وبالزى العماني أتمنى اتخاذ أشد العقوبة على الي صور والي متصور "

"Neglecting history and not preserving Omani identity, customs and traditions is one of the reasons for our current situation. Unfortunately, now we have companies producing inappropriate content while wearing Omani attire. I hope that the strictest punishment is imposed on those who filmed and those who were filmed".

(13)

" خلال شهرين او ٣ مر على اكثر من مقطع لي شباب يرقصوا بشكل غير لائق لابسين الخنجر العماني حقيقة هذه لا يرضيني متى يوقفو عند حدهم "

"In the past two or three months, I have come across more than one video of young men dancing inappropriately while wearing the Omani Khanjar. Honestly, I am not satisfied with this, when will they stop"

In tweet (11), the commenter strongly condemns an individual who was seen eating and drinking in public during Ramadan. The act is described as "تصرف غير لائق أبداً" ("a completely inappropriate act"). However, the criticism is not directed at the behaviour in isolation. Instead, it is embedded within a broader evaluation of who the person is and how he appears. The disapproval intensifies as the commenter points out that the individual was "a Muslim," "an Omani," and "wearing the Omani dishdasha" a layered identity description that foregrounds both religious and national affiliation.

Crucially, these identity references do not operate independently. Rather, they work together to construct the behaviour as a serious transgression of shared norms, particularly those tied to maintaining social identity face. In this context, the individual's Muslim identity is not invoked to appeal to religious obligations per se, as was the case in the earlier theme on adhering to Islamic teachings (see Section 6.5). Instead, religion functions here as part of a layered and unified identity,

it reinforces that being Muslim is implicitly integrated into what it means to be Omani.

Moreover, the references to the individual as “an Omani” and “wearing the Omani dishdasha” are what intensify the perceived violation in this post. To explain, wearing the dishdasha places the individual within a recognised normative framework, where certain behaviours such as observing appropriate conduct during Ramadan are socially expected. The dishdasha is not merely traditional attire; it is a visible symbol that signals the wearer’s alignment with a normative framework and its associated obligations. As such, when someone visibly marked by this symbol fails to meet these expectations, the act is judged not simply as inappropriate behaviour, but as a public breach of the norms tied to Omani identity. This perceived contradiction between appearance and conduct constitutes a threat to social identity face (Spencer-Oatey, 2008), as the individual is seen to undermine the image of the group they visibly represent.

Similarly, in posts (12) and (13) the expression of disapproval is anchored not only in the perceived inappropriateness of the actions themselves such as dancing or appearing in videos deemed “غير لائقة” (inappropriate) but more significantly in the fact that the individuals were wearing Omani national symbols, such as the traditional attire and the khanjar, while engaging in these acts. The critique is not directed merely at the content of the behaviour, but at the contradiction between that behaviour and the expectations evoked by what the individuals are wearing. In both cases, the behaviour is framed as a violation of what it means to visibly and publicly embody Omani identity.

In post (12), the commenter links this kind of behaviour to a broader societal failure to respect Omani heritage, explicitly referencing the neglect of ‘history’, ‘Omani identity’, and ‘customs and traditions’. The disapproval is heightened by the fact that the individuals in the video are wearing the Omani dress while engaging in what is perceived to be inappropriate conduct. Here, the attire is evaluated; it signals that the individuals are expected to represent and uphold the cultural values embedded in the nation’s dress. The act of wearing the Omani attire in a context perceived as socially improper creates a dissonance between appearance and conduct. In this context, the Omani dress carries implicit expectations of decorum, respect for tradition, and national pride. When those wearing it engage in behaviour deemed inappropriate, the act is interpreted as a public misrepresentation of Omani identity.

In post (13), the commenter expresses increasing frustration over the recurrence of videos showing young men dancing “inappropriately” while wearing the ‘Omani khanjar’. The phrase “In the past two or three months, I’ve seen more than one clip” highlights the repeated nature of the behaviour, suggesting a growing concern about a pattern of conduct that contradicts expected norms. What

intensifies the disapproval is not just the act of dancing, but the fact that those performing it are wearing the khanjar, a visible marker of Omani identity that positions the wearer as a representative of what it means to be Omani.

This framing becomes clear in the comment “Honestly, this does not please me,” which initially conveys a personal reaction but is immediately followed by a broader appeal: “When will they be stopped?” The shift from individual disappointment to a call for intervention suggests that the concern extends beyond the specific behaviour to a wider concern about how Omani identity is being portrayed. In this context, the criticism is not simply about social appropriateness but about the perceived misrepresentation of cultural values in a public and highly visible way. Wearing the khanjar carries an implicit obligation to uphold the behavioural norms associated with Omani identity, and when those expectations are violated, the action is judged as a breach of shared cultural standards.

(14)

"من الأمور التي اهتم بها السلطان قابوس بن سعيد، المحافظة على ارتداء اللباس العماني في الجهات الحكومية للموظفين والمراجعين، شهدت عدة مرات ارجاع مواطنين حضروا الجهات الحكومية لتخليص معاملة بينطلون وقميص، شوهدت أيضا في مراكز الأحوال المدنية بإرجاع مواطنين قاموا بقص لحاهم بطريقة غير لائقة "

“One of the matters that the Sultan Qaboos Bin Said emphasised was the preservation of wearing Omani traditional clothing in governmental offices, both for the employees and visitors. I have witnessed several instances where citizens who came to the government offices to complete transactions wearing pants and shirt were turned away. I have also seen citizens being turned away at civil centres for shaving their beards in an inappropriate manner”.

(15)

"منظر غير لائق ان ترى شاب فوق العشرين عام لابس بيجامة نوم في المسجد والشارع وفي مختلف الأماكن العامة والجهات الحكومية. اسمها بيجامة نوم يعني تلبسها اذا بتنام فقط وبمعنى اخر لا تفعل نفسك وتتكشخ في بيجامة النوم وين ما رحت على أساس انك ذوق وعلى الموضة"

“It is inappropriate to see a **young man over twenty years old wearing pajamas** in the **mosque, on the street, in the hospital and various public places and government offices**. They are called pajamas for a reason, meaning you should only wear them when you are going to sleep. In other words, do not embarrass yourself by dressing up in pajamas wherever you go, thinking it is stylish or fashionable”.

While the previous tweets presented the Omani attire as a symbolic marker of national identity, where the disapproval arose from individuals engaging in inappropriate behaviour while visibly dressed in national attire (see posts 10,12 &13), the following tweets shift the focus toward contexts where traditional clothing operates not just symbolically, but as a prescriptive code. In these cases, attire is

framed as something that must be adhered to either through formal regulation or implicit social expectation, particularly in institutional or religious settings. Here, the act of dressing inappropriately is constructed as a breach of the sociocultural norms, and commenters' posts reflect an effort to reinforce both implicit social norms and explicit institutional norms.

Both tweet (14) and tweet (15) focus on individuals who failed to adhere to expected dress norms in specific public settings. In tweet (14), the commenter describes instances where citizens have turned away from government offices for arriving in trousers and shirts rather than the traditional Omani attire. This highlights the enforcement of an explicit institutional dress code, where wearing the national dress is not just encouraged but required. The tweet further mentions cases in which individuals were asked to leave civil centers due to shaving their beards "in an inappropriate manner," suggesting that appearance expectations extend beyond clothing to grooming practices. Here, deviation from accepted standards of presentation is not framed as a breach of formal norms tied to institutional respectability.

Tweet (15), by contrast, highlights implicit social norms governing dress in public spaces beyond formal institutions. The commenter expresses disapproval at seeing "a young man over twenty" wearing pyjamas in places such as mosques, streets, and government buildings. Unlike the context in tweet (14), these settings 'mosques', and 'street' may not be governed by formal dress codes. However, the tweet reflects an implicit sociocultural norm that shapes expectations about appropriate attire in public places. The commenter finds it inappropriate that a man "over twenty years old" would appear in pyjamas outside the home, implying that by this age, he should have internalised social standards of public presentation. The reference to age highlights a perceived maturity gap between what is expected and what was displayed. The act becomes inappropriate not only due to the clothing itself, but because the individual's failure to align his public appearance with the age-related expectations of appropriate social behaviour. Moreover, the norm violation is reinforced through the commenter's literal interpretation of the pyjamas' function: 'It's called pyjamas, meaning you only wear them if you are going to sleep'. The commenter sets clear boundaries around the appropriate use of pyjamas, reinforcing the norm that they are not suitable for public settings and framing their use outside the home as a clear breach of expected behaviour.

To sum up, tweets (14) and (15) illustrate how traditional and everyday clothing are not only symbolic markers of identity but are also governed by both explicit regulations and implicit sociocultural expectations. While tweet (14) reflects institutional enforcement of dress codes where attire becomes a formal requirement, tweet (15) reveals that behaviour can be judged inappropriate as public even

in the absence of formal rules. In both cases, the construction of incivility stems from perceived failure to adhere to explicit and implicit norms of the dress code.

(17)

"ظاهرة أخرى في سوق مطرح تسيء لي أخلاق التاجر العماني وهي ابتزاز الباعة للمتسوقين وذلك بالزمامهم بالشراء في منظر غير لائق منفر للسائح والمتسوق"

"Another phenomenon in Matrah **market that offends the morals of the Omani trader** through extortion of buyers by sellers where they force them to purchase in an inappropriate view that is repulsive to tourists and shoppers"

(18)

"هل يحق لأي مواطن مقاضاة أي مشهور أو مشهوره في البلد ينشر أو تنشر محتوى غير لائق أخلاقيا عن طريق عمل بث فيه تحريض على التمرد على القيم والعادات والتقاليد والظهور فيه بلبس غير لائق لا يمثل قيمنا وعاداتنا في المجتمع العماني المعروف؟؟؟"

"does any citizen have the right to sue any famous man or woman in the country who publishes **morally inappropriate content through** a livestreaming that incites rebellion against **the values, customs, and tradition, or appears in improper attire that does not represent our values and customs in the well-known Omani society????**."

In earlier examples under this theme, the evaluation of incivility was based on the mismatch between visible identity markers and the behaviour performed (see examples 11, 12, and 13). In examples 14 and 15, the judgement was grounded less in symbolic markers and more in the failure to adhere to explicit and implicit expectations surrounding dress in public settings.

In examples (17) and (18), the focus shifts to moral expectations explicitly linked to Omani identity. In example (17), the commenter expresses concern over exploitative sales tactics in Muttrah Souq, stating that the phenomenon "offends the morals of the Omani trader." The act of coercing customers into buying is not only described as "غير لائق" (inappropriate) but also as repellent to both tourists and locals. This judgement reflects a deep-seated moral expectation: that traders should embody honesty, hospitality, and integrity qualities traditionally associated with Omani commercial identity. The comment thus invokes a normative ideal of how Omani traders should behave, and positions deviation from this ideal as both culturally inappropriate and socially damaging. While this phenomenon was described to be offensive the morality of the Omani merchants, it was deemed "inappropriate". The inappropriateness stemmed from the action of the vendors "extorting shoppers by forcing them to buy in an inappropriate and off-putting manner for tourists and shoppers". Pressuring or coercing shoppers into buying something runs counter to the morally prescribed

behaviour that merchants are expected to follow.

Similarly, in example (18), the focus is on influencers or public figures who produce content perceived to be morally inappropriate. The commenter questions whether citizens have the right to sue influencers who publish material that “incites rebellion against values, customs, and traditions” and who appear in “لبس غير لائق” (inappropriate dress). This post reveals a concern with how public figures, especially those visibly situated within Omani society, may threaten shared moral and cultural standards through their behaviour. Incivility in this context is not just framed as an individual transgression, but as a challenge to the collective moral fabric that defines the community.

In both cases, the judgement of incivility is tied to a perceived violation of moral expectations that are integral to Omani identity expectations, not only about how one appears in public, but also about acting in ways that reflect and uphold shared moral values and social customs.

6.9 Conclusion

The findings from this chapter bring together insights from both corpus analysis and thematic analysis to reveal how public evaluations of incivility on X (formerly Twitter) in Oman are shaped by distinct but overlapping normative frameworks. While the behaviours being judged often fall within a narrow range, most notably, the act of throwing rubbish, the rationale behind these judgements varies considerably depending on the specific norm that is perceived to have been breached. This conclusion synthesises the key insights from both layers of analysis by highlighting how the same act can be differently constructed and viewed through different lenses.

6.9.1 Throwing rubbish: a singular behaviour, multiple normative violations

Across both corpora, the most frequently cited uncivil or inappropriate act was “throwing rubbish”, which appeared 25 times in the /ʔe:r ḥa'dʕa:ri:/ [uncivil] corpus and 6 times in the /ʔe:r la:ʔiq/ [inappropriate] corpus. However, thematic analysis showed that this act was not evaluated in uniform terms. Instead, it triggered multiple types of disapproval depending on which normative lens was applied:

- In the theme “Failure to uphold the norm of adhering to Islamic Teachings” throwing rubbish was framed as a violation of religious obligation. Tweets explicitly referenced Islamic principles such as ‘cleanliness is part of faith’ making it clear that incivility was constructed as failure to follow Islamic norms. The commenters explicitly emphasised that ‘we are people of religion’ thus such behaviour is especially inappropriate and contradicts the Islamic obligations
- The theme “Failure to adhere to the norm of projecting a positive image of the area” the same

behaviour was judged through the lens of communal image and reputation. Here, incivility was not only about littering, but about how such acts were perceived by outsiders, especially tourists. The damage was framed not in religious terms, but in symbolic terms of how the area and by extension, its residents are represented to others. This connects with Spencer-Oatey's (2008) notion of social identity face, where individuals as a group are concerned about their image and how they want to be perceived by others.

- The theme "Failure to uphold the norm of shared responsibility for maintaining cleanliness" framed the act in terms of collective duty. This time the concern was not external perception or breaching religious norms, but a broader sense of a communal obligation. Tweets explicitly referenced "weak societal responsibility" and included direct appeals to individuals saying 'be responsible'. In the examples presented, the expectation that all members of society to contribute to maintaining public cleanliness was highlighted.

Thus, although the corpus findings revealed the prominence of rubbish-related terms across hashtags, it was the thematic analysis that unpacked the qualitative depth of these evaluations by linking them to distinct normative expectations.

6.9.2 Performing the Omani identity: dress and behaviour

The second major focus of the analysis revolved around attire, particularly in the theme "Failure to uphold Omani identity norms". While the corpora reflected recurring terms related to traditional attire such as 'Omani dress', 'the Omani Khanjar', and 'Omani cap', the thematic analysis revealed that these symbols functioned as more than just indicators of national belonging. They activated behavioural expectations tied to what it means to embody Omani identity.

- In some examples, incivility was constructed through the mismatch between visible identity markers and public conduct. Individuals wearing the Omani dishdasha while engaging in behaviour deemed inappropriate (e.g., dancing, eating in public during Ramadan) were judged not only for the acts themselves, but for failing to meet the behavioural obligations carried by their visible identity. This reflects an evaluative logic grounded in social identity face, where the individual is expected to act in a way that protects the group's image.
- In other instances, tweets focused on violations of explicit and implicit dress codes, particularly in public institutions or sacred spaces. Whether it was pyjamas worn in mosques or individuals arriving at government offices without the traditional attire, these breaches were framed as failures to perform socially appropriate behaviour. The norms here were rooted less

in symbolic identity and more in codified and context-specific behavioural expectations.

- Lastly, a smaller set of tweets drew attention to moral expectations embedded in Omani identity. For example, traders who pressured customers were criticised for violating "the morals of the Omani trader," indicating that morality itself is considered a defining trait of the Omani identity.

CHAPTER 7: RESULTS - PHASE 2 (B)

7.1 Introduction

Building on the analysis of X data presented in Chapter 6, this chapter examines personal accounts of incivility as narrated by participants through diary reports, in order to further explore the norms that shape how Omani people perceive uncivil behaviour. The findings from the previous phase indicated that incivility was most commonly associated with specific public behaviours such as throwing rubbish, wearing inappropriate attire, or acting in ways deemed morally improper. However, these actions were not evaluated in isolation. Instead, participants judged them through the lens of underlying sociocultural norms, including religious obligations (e.g., maintaining cleanliness), expectations tied to Omani identity (e.g., dressing or behaving in a way that reflects well on the community), and shared responsibilities (e.g., collective care for public spaces).

This chapter builds on those findings by turning to individual, lived experiences. While the themes identified in Phase One were not used to inform the content of the diary report, the wording and structure of the questions were shaped by the communicative framing observed in the tweets (see Chapter 3 section 3.6.2 for further explanation). This phase explores how participants themselves narrate and evaluate incidents they perceived as uncivil, revealing both the types of behaviours they found inappropriate and the social norms that underpin their judgements. It is also worth noting that not all participants explicitly justified their judgements. Some simply reported the behaviour and described their emotional response such as anger or discomfort without articulating the reason for considering an act as uncivil. In these cases, the disapproval appears to stem from a general sense that the act was inappropriate or out of place, highlighting how certain forms of incivility are recognised as self-evident within the cultural context.

The diary report data thus provides a deeper, more contextualised understanding of incivility by highlighting how individuals interpret and respond to norm violations in everyday life. It moves beyond public discourse to examine private evaluations, offering insight into how uncivil behaviour is recognised, justified, and emotionally experienced. The analysis presented in this chapter is guided by Braun and Clarke's (2006) thematic analysis approach and draws on Spencer-Oatey's (2008) rapport management framework particularly the concepts of sociality rights and obligations, and social identity face to interpret how participants construct and articulate evaluations of inappropriate conduct.

The chapter is structured as follows: Section 7.2 outlines the key thematic patterns identified in the diary report data. Sections 7.3 to 7.6 each examine one of the core themes in detail, using participant excerpts to illustrate how incivility is constructed and assessed through the lens of social norms.

7.2 Themes overview

The following table summarises the themes and gives a short description for each theme, and examples found in the data, followed by sections elaborating on them:

Theme	Incidents Examples
1. Failure to uphold the norm of public decency	- Dressing immodestly in public - Engaging in obscene public behaviour - Harassing women
2. Failure to uphold the norms of treating expatriate workers with respect	- Disrespecting or shouting at expatriate workers - Using demeaning language toward service staff
3. Failure to uphold the norm of caring for and guiding children	- Verbally or physically harming children in public - Neglecting to correct misbehaviour
4. Failure to uphold norms of road conduct	- Overtaking in the yellow lane - Taking more than one parking space - Speeding in residential areas
5. Failure to uphold the norm of shared responsibility for maintaining public cleanliness	- Throwing rubbish in public places - Littering in natural or tourist areas

Table 7.1: Overview of diary report themes

7.3 Failure to uphold the norm of public decency norms

A key norm that shaped participants' evaluations of incivility was the expectation that individuals uphold standards of modesty and moral conduct in public, particularly in how they dress, behave in public and interact with the other gender. Public decency refers to a level of behaviour in public spaces that is considered socially acceptable and not obscene according to shared moral standards (Dalton & Klingemann, 2007). In this context, participants' perceptions of incivility were often triggered by actions that violated these expectations such as immodest clothing, inappropriate gestures or speech, and behavior that blurred gender boundaries in ways deemed culturally unacceptable. The judgement of these behaviours was not only tied to social identity face the desire for the group but also to sociality rights and obligations (Spencer-Oatey, 2008). When individuals act in ways that undermine public modesty, they are seen to breach the shared obligations to

maintain socially appropriate conduct. This is especially pronounced in settings where such behaviour reflects poorly on the group's collective image. Thus, the evaluation of incivility arises not simply from the actions themselves, but from the perception that these actions threaten both the group's social standing and the implicit expectations of appropriate conduct in public spaces.

The following subsections examine the three most common ways in which this norm was perceived to be violated: failure to dress modestly in public, failure to refrain from engaging in obscene or socially inappropriate acts and interacting with the other gender in ways deemed culturally unacceptable.

7.3.1 Omani find it uncivil to dress immodestly in public

The informants in all the examples in this section collectively underscore a concern for public decency norms, particularly concerning clothing choices in public places such as shopping malls. It should be mentioned here that to “dress inappropriately” and “dressing immodestly” means not to follow an implicit dress code in public areas, which is to wear clothes that cover the shoulders, upper arms and fall below the knees, and women that are expected to cover their hair.

(1)

"في التجمعات التجارية أكثر من نشاهد الملابس الغير لائقة ترتديها العمانيّة والشعر خارج الحواف من غير مسك الأيدي والضحك المرتفع. شعرت بأن السينة نعم والحسنه تخص وإن البنت هي نفس البنت فحافظي على نفسك. لماذا؟ لأن العار للجميع"

"In shopping malls, we often see **inappropriate clothes** worn by Omani women and their **hair sticking out of their scarfs, holding hands**, and **laughing loud**. I felt that the **bad act spreads and the good act is limited**. And the **woman is woman so take care of yourself**. Why? Because **shame is on everyone**".

The narrator in the narrative (1) expresses disapproval towards what he observes as “inappropriate clothes” worn by Omani women and having their hair being shown out of their hijab. There is a clear expectation for women here to uphold modesty standards by dressing and wearing the hijab in a specific way to avoid bringing “shame” upon themselves, and the broader community “because shame is on everyone”. The narrator accentuated this expectation by using a proverb which suggests that an individual's negative action will affect everyone collectively, therefore, the narrator says “women are women, so take care of yourself” implying a communal responsibility to maintain societal values, by dressing appropriately in public.

(2)

"اللبس الغير محتشم في الأماكن العامة، شعرت بالندم الى ما وصلنا اليه"

"Dressing immodestly in public places, I felt remorse for what we had reached".

(3)

"اللبس غير المحتشم، تعكس نظرة غير جيدة عن الشعب العماني"

"Dressing immodestly does not reflect a good image of the Omani society".

Similarly, in narratives (2) and (3), the narrators also highlight instances where individuals did not adhere to dressing modestly in public, leading to feelings of regret and disappointment. The narrator's statement "I felt remorse for what we have reached" implies that by dressing "inappropriately", there is a departure from the traditional standards. Narrative (3) reinforces the previous examples by suggesting that the reason why the narrator considers dressing immodestly uncivil is because it "does not reflect a good image of our society". There seems to be a concern here about the image being portrayed to others of Omani society. The statement implies that there are certain expectations for how individuals should present themselves in public, and failing to meet these expectations can reflect poorly on the society as a whole. It implies a belief that members of the society have a responsibility to uphold and project their values through their personal appearance "dressing modestly", and that deviation from these norms can be seen as a failure to respect or maintain social standards.

(4)

" في المجمع التجاري حيث شاهدت شباب عمانيين البنطلون تحت الوسط حتى الملابس الداخلية تبين. شعرت بالغضب، لان هذي المناظر لا تمت لدينا او قيمنا المجتمعية "

"In the mall, I saw young Omani men with their pants below waist, even their underwear was visible. I felt angry because these scenes do not represent our religious or our societal values".

Narrative (4) sheds light specifically on the way men dress in shopping malls. The informant expresses his anger upon witnessing young Omani men wearing trousers below the waist, revealing their underwear. The narrator explicitly states that this behaviour does not align with the religion that Omani people follow, nor with their societal values. The phrase "does not represent" suggests

a complete divergence from what is considered acceptable within the narrator's cultural and religious context. It also suggests a disassociation from the behaviour, indicating that it is seen as contrary to the established norms and values of society.

In all of the examples presented, the narrators describe individuals who did not adhere to modesty standards in their attire, which they considered to be uncivil and contrary to what society and religion expect them to do. Additionally, the narratives illustrate how adherence to public decency, specifically dressing modestly is viewed as essential for preserving the reputation of both the individuals and the Omani society. The concern over the image of Omani society is a very prominent notion in all of the presented data, and the previous narratives emphasised the interconnectedness of the individual conduct and societal reputation, highlighting a collective responsibility for upholding cultural and religious values and norms of decency in public settings.

7.3.2 Omanis find it uncivil to commit any obscene activity in public

The following narratives highlight instances where the narrators witness obscene behaviour in public in various contexts. Obscenity in this context refers to any action, image or words that offend sexual morality, such as committing a sexual act or displaying affection or using vulgar language in public.

(5)

" نرى أحيانا بعض التصرفات في أماكن عامة مثل احتضان أحدهم لي فتاة أو ممارسة غير لائقة في السيارة، منظر غير لائق."

"Sometimes we see some behaviours in public places such as **someone hugging a girl** or **indecent behaviour** in the car, or **indecent act**".

In narrative (5), the narrator describes uncivil behaviour committed by men and women in public such as "someone hugging a girl" and engaging in "an indecent behaviour in the car". The narrator describes these behaviours as "indecent", reflecting a breach of societal norms and expectations regarding adhering to public decency norms.

(6)

في الشاطئ مسقط بعض التصرفات الخاطئة من الشباب مع البنات. سلوك مذل للآداب، شعرت بالخجل لأنني جيت هذا المكان
وشي "مؤسف تحصل هذا الجيل بسلوكيات خاطئة

"At the beach in Muscat, there were some **wrongful acts** from **young men towards girls**, displaying **obscene behaviour**. I **felt embarrassed that I came to this place**, and it is **unfortunate** to see this generation engaging in **wrongful behaviour**".

In narrative (6) the narrator describes another uncivil behaviour that he witnessed at the beach, which he deems to be a "wrongful act" and "obscene behaviour" indicating a breach of expected standards of conduct. The narrator describes the act between young men and girls at the beach to have made him feel embarrassed, "I felt embarrassed that I came to this place". The narrator's feeling of embarrassment reflects a sense of discomfort and disapproval towards witnessing a behaviour that deviates from the accepted norms of decency. Furthermore, there is an implicit sense of regret for being in a place associated with such actions, as if their presence might suggest to others an acceptance or endorsement of the behaviour observed. Moreover, the narrator expresses his disappointment with the behaviour of the younger generation suggesting a concern for the decline in adhering to societal norms of decency "it is unfortunate to see this generation engaging in wrongful behaviour", which again emphasises a rejection of this type of behaviour.

(7)

"في العمل كلام يחדش الحياء امام الجميع ، شعرت بالضيق وذهبت من موقع الحديث"

"At work, there was **obscene talk made** in front of everyone, I **felt upset** and **left the place** of the conversation".

Similarly, in narrative (7), the narrator briefly narrates an incident that occurred at the workplace when there was some "obscene talk" in front of everyone. The narrator does not explain what was said exactly, but describes what was as "obscene". The use of the term "كلام يחדش الحياء", "obscene talk" suggests a recognition of the inappropriateness of the speech in a professional public context. The narrator felt upset and chose to remove himself from the conversation; leaving the scene indicates the narrator's non-verbal rejection of the behaviour and signals his unwillingness to participate or condone such conduct. Overall, the narrator's feelings and reaction to the incident reflect that there is a clear violation.

7.3.3 Omanis find it uncivil when men violated norms of gendered conduct in public

The following excerpts capture incidents in which men's behaviour toward women in public spaces is perceived as inappropriate, including unwanted remarks or actions, such as persistent following, verbal advances or flirtation.

(8)

"في حديقة القرم الطبيعية، التحرش بشكل فاضح. لو املك القانون راح انزل اشد العقوبات"

"At Qurum Natural Park, **harassment** happens in **flagrant manner**. If I make the law, I will **impose** the **harshest punishment**".

In extract (8), the narrator describes the harassment that he witnessed which occurs "in flagrant manner" at the park. The narrator's use of the word "فاضح بشكل", "flagrant manner", emphasises the visibility of the harassment, suggesting that it occurs openly, conspicuously and without any attempt to hide or disguise it. The harassment that "happens in flagrant manner" signifies a significant breach of societal norms, illustrating a lack of regard for decency norms. Thus, the narrator expresses his frustration by saying "if I had the law, I would impose the harshest punishments". The desire to have the power to impose stricter legal measures against those responsible for the harassment reflects that there is an infringement of the norm that cannot be ignored.

(9)

"اغلبها مولات مغاللة بين جنسين، حرقة ل يمثل مجتمعنا"

"In most of the malls, **men and women flirt** with each other which **does not represent our society**".

(10)

"في الجامعة حيث اصدر احد الذكور صوت عند مروري مرتين من عنده، شعرت بالاشمئزاز، شعرت وكأن شخصا ما قد تعرض لي وراء جسدي بالإجبار."

"At the university, one of the **males made a sound twice** when I passed by, I **felt disgusted**, as **If someone had assaulted me from behind forcibly**".

Another example that violates public decency is presented in narrative (9) which suggests that a significant portion of the act observed involves flirtatious behaviour between individuals of different genders. The speaker expresses discomfort with this behaviour, indicating that it contradicts the values and the norms of their society, "does not represent our society". This statement implies a

belief that “flirting” is not acceptable in the Omani society emphasising a sense of discord between the observed behaviour and the societal expectations. It also reflects a belief that the society holds itself to different social standards than what is being observed in the mall.

Narrative (10) describes an incident at a university where the narrator experiences a profound sense of violation and disgust when a male individual makes a sound as she passes by him, not once but twice “one of the males made a sound twice when I passed by”. This repeated action made the narrator feel disgusted. The feeling of disgust and the metaphorical expression of being physically violated, “as If someone had assaulted me from behind forcibly” underline the violation the narrator experienced. This comparison is used to articulate the sense of discomfort the narrator felt, emphasising that the impact of such actions on the narrator’s psychological and emotional state can be as profound as a physical violation.

(11)

التعرض للتحرشات من الشباب في الأماكن العامة والحق بالبنات الي منازلهم. شعرت بالخوف من ان يراني احد رغم اني لم افعل شي ابدا، شعرت بعدم الأمان وعدم الرغبة بالخروج مرة أخرى

“Being **harassed** by **young men** in public places and girls **being followed** to their homes. **I felt scared** that **someone would see me** even though I have never done anything. **I felt unsafe** and **not wanting to go out again**”.

Moreover, narratives (11 , 12 and 13) describe three separate uncivil incidents that share a common theme of feeling unsafe due to the behaviour of “a group of guys” following girls. Narrative (11) begins with explicit mentions of “harassment” and “being followed home”; this situation gave the narrator a sense of fear and insecurity, particularly the fear that someone would see her being followed “I felt scared that someone would see me”. The fear that the narrator felt reflects a sense of the potential for misunderstanding associated with being targeted in such a manner. In other words, the narrator worries about being judged or blamed for the actions of the harassers. To explain more, the narrator’s statement “even though I have never done anything” shows that the narrator tries to prove that she is innocent and did not invite such harassment to avoid being blamed. As a result of this harassment, the narrator states that after the incident, she “felt unsafe and not wanting to go out again”; this phrase captures a shift in the narrator’s sense of security and a strong aversion to re-experiencing potential harm.

(12)

"في الجامعة كنا نريد نطلع من السوبر ماركت وفجأة دخلوا مجموعة شباب وجلسوا عند الباب وما خلونا نطلع لحد ما جاء الدكتور، شعرت بالخوف لأن كل مكان شباب ونحن فقط ٥ بنات".

"At the university, we wanted to leave the supermarket, but suddenly a **group of guys** came in and **stood by the door, not allowing us to leave** until the professor arrived. I **felt scared** because the **place was crowded with guys**, and **we were only five girls**".

The second incident in the narrative (12) describes another event experienced by the narrator and her female' companions at a university supermarket. The narrator explains that they were trying to leave the supermarket when "a group of guys" deliberately positioned themselves at the doorway. This act is described as "they sat at the door and did not let us leave", highlighting the deliberate nature of their actions to restrict the women ability to move. This act of obstruction continued until the arrival of a professor. The act of the guys obstructing the doorway made the narrator feel "scared" due to the overwhelming presence of young men compared to their small group of women "the place was full of young men, and we were only 5 girls". The disparity in numbers not only made the situation more intimidating but also emphasised the vulnerability of the narrator and her companions. The narrative underlines a significant breach of the expectation that public spaces should be safe and accessible to all, free from intimidation or harassment.

(13)

في مركز تجاري، قام مجموعة من الشباب بملاحقتي لفترة طويلة، شعرت بالخوف والغضب، لانهم ساروا خلفي لمسافة طويلة حتى بعد خروج من المركز

"At the shopping mall, a group of **guys followed me** for a long time, I **felt scared and angry** because **they walked behind me** for a long distance **even after I left the mall**".

Narrative (13) outlines another distressing encounter within a shopping centre, where the narrator is persistently followed by a group of young men for an extended period "the guys followed me for a long time". However, this experience does not conclude within the confines of the shopping centre, instead, it extended beyond its premises, continuing even after the narrator left the facility "they walked behind me for a long distance even after I left the mall". The continuation of the pursuit even after leaving the center is a critical detail that highlights the unrelenting nature of harassment that continued even outside the initial context of the shopping centre. This persistence indicates a deliberate disregard for the well-being of the individual, which emphasises the breach of societal

expectations regarding public decency. Moreover, the emotional impact of the incident on the narrator is captured in the phrases “I felt scared and angry”, conveying the distress and the violation felt by the narrator.

7.4 Failure to uphold the norm of treating expatriate workers with dignity

One of the key norms that shaped participants’ evaluations of incivility was the expectation that people, especially those perceived as socially or structurally vulnerable, should be treated with dignity. In this context, dignity refers to the basic recognition of a person's worth and humanity, and it includes being treated with fairness, and consideration, and without humiliation or degradation. This norm was especially salient in how participants responded to the treatment of expatriate workers, who frequently occupy service roles in Omani society. There is a strong social expectation that these individuals should be treated with dignity and not subjected to public humiliation or mistreatment.

The examples in this section focus on incidents in which expatriate workers were yelled at, demeaned, or physically mistreated by Omanis in public settings. These behaviours were consistently evaluated as violations of the norm of treating expatriate workers with dignity. Participants expressed strong emotions such as anger, shame, and embarrassment, viewing such acts not merely as individual failings but as public violations that reflect poorly on Omani society. In many cases, the mistreatment of expatriates was seen to undermine the group’s identity face that is, the positive group image of Omanis as respectful and considerate in their treatment of others. Participants expressed concern that such behaviour contradicts the values traditionally associated with Omani society, thus harming the group’s collective reputation. In other instances, the evaluation was grounded in sociality obligations: the belief that individuals, especially those who are socially or structurally vulnerable, should be treated with dignity and fairness

(14)

"زبون يقوم بالصراخ على موظف المقهى لعدم احضاره طلبه الى طاولته، شعرت بالغضب العارم"

"A customer **yelling at the café employee for not bringing his order to his table. I was furious**".

In narrative (14), the informant describes a customer yelling at a café employee for not bringing their order to the table which caused the observer to feel “furious”. The informant does not explain why “yelling at the café employee” made the narrator feel angry, however, yelling at the café employee is a direct violation of the norm of treating people with dignity.

(15)

"في محلات التجارية عندما يقول المشتري الفاظ غير جيدة للوافد، شعور محزن لأنه جاء من بلد ويشغل و الهدف من تغريه من دولته لي يعمل لمعيشته الافراد".

"At shopping stores when the customer uses **inappropriate language** with the **expatriate**. It is **sad** because **they came from their country** and **work hard to earn a living** in another country".

Based on yelling at people, narrative (15) describes a customer using "inappropriate language" towards an expatriate in a shopping store setting. Using "inappropriate language" with the expatriate shows, according to the narrator, a profound disrespect for their sacrifices in living and working in a foreign land "they came from their country and work hard to earn a living in another country". The narrator's "sad feeling" in response to this behaviour underscores the emotional impact of such disrespect, reflecting a broader societal expectation that all individuals, especially those in vulnerable positions, should be treated with dignity and respect.

(16)

"التقليل من شأن الموظفين في المطاعم والمحلات والمجمعات التجارية خصوصاً الأجانب منهم وذلك برفع الصوت عليهم بدون داعي بل على وجه الاستكبار والتفاخر وفرض الطلبات عليهم بطريقة غير محترمة و غير لائقة بهدف جعلهم يشعروهم بأنهم أقل مستوى وليسوا اشخاص مهمين. اشعر بالخجل في مثل هذه المواقف لأنها تصرفات لاتعكس طبيعة الشعب العماني وهذا يؤدي الى جرح الموظف بالكلمات الغير لائقة خصوصاً امام عامة الشعب وقد يشعره بالإهانة، فلا احد منا يستحق ان يشعر بهذه الشعور السيئ".

"**Belittling the employees** in restaurants, stores, and shopping malls especially foreigners by **raising one's voice** at them **unnecessarily**, rather in **an arrogant** and **boastful manner**, and **imposing demands on them** in a **disrespectful** and **inappropriate manner**, with the aim of **making them feel inferior** and **unimportant**. I feel **ashamed** because these actions **do not reflect the nature of the Omani people**, and this can lead to **hurting the employee with inappropriate words**, especially in front of the public which may make **them feel humiliated**. **None of us deserves to feel such negative feeling**".

Narrative (16) presents a scenario where employees, particularly expatriates in restaurants, and shopping stores are treated in a "disrespectful and inappropriate manner". The disrespect is manifested through "belittling the employees" by raising their voices, having "arrogant and boastful" attitudes, and through the "disrespectful imposition of demands". The actions are described as being done "unnecessarily" and deliberately, aimed at "making them feel inferior and unimportant". Such

conduct clearly violates the basic principle of respect, which is not only apparent through the actions presented, but also through the feelings expressed. To explain, the narrator felt “ashamed” witnessing these acts which highlights a deep-seated belief in the inherent dignity of every individual, acknowledging that “none of us deserves to feel such negative feelings”, such as feelings “humiliated” or “hurt”. Moreover, the feeling of shame also stems from the recognition that such an act “does not reflect the nature of the Omani people”. To explain further, the narrator makes a clear distinction here between the behaviour of a few and the inherent values of the Omani people, emphasising a disconnection between the actions described and the cultural norms of Oman. In other words, it implies a societal norm within Oman that values respect towards others regardless of their jobs or background. It reinforces the idea that such disrespect is not representative of the Omani community, and therefore, it breaches the expected norm.

(17)

"عدم احترام البائع في المحل، شعرت بالإزعاج لأنه هذا التصرف يشوه ويعطي انطباع سيء للمجتمع وللشخص بالنفس. احس بالشفقة أحيانا على الشخص الي تصرف بهذه التصرف لانه غير متربي- استصغر صاحب هذه التصرف لانه قلل من قيمة نفسه بهذا التصرف".

“Disrespecting the seller in the store, I **felt annoyed** because this behaviour **tarnishes** and gives **a negative impression** of both the **society** and the **individual**. I **feel pity** for the person who behaves in such a manner because **he was not well parented**. I pity this person because they **diminish their own self-worth** by acting this way”.

Similarly, narrative (17) describes a situation where a seller in shop is treated with disrespect. The incident elicits a reaction as she said, “felt annoyed” highlighting the narrator’s discomfort with “disrespecting the seller”. The narrator expresses that this conduct does not only impact the individual subjected to it, but also the broader societal perception of the person who committed the uncivil act as the narrator stated, it “gives a negative impression of both the society and the individual”. To explain, in terms of its impact to the society, “this behaviour tarnishes ... the society”. This statement implies that the behaviour of individuals within a society reflects on the society as a whole. Therefore, the act of “disrespecting the seller” deviates significantly from the accepted behaviour within Omani society which shows a disregard for the shared norm which is to treat people with respect.

Furthermore, in terms of its impact on the individual who exhibited this behaviour, the narrator feels “pity” towards this person, recognising that their disrespectful behaviour is a sign of poor upbringing “, not well parented”, and a diminution of their own self-worth. This perspective implies a deeper societal norm: respect is not only about how we treat others, but also significantly influences how we

are perceived by others. The act of “disrespecting the seller” is seen as “self-demeaning”, highlighting a belief in the intrinsic value of maintaining respectful interaction as a reflection of one’s character and upbringing. The narrative not only points out the breach of respect but also touches on the implications of such behaviour on the individual’s social standing and the collective image of the community. The mention of the impact on the community and the individual’s self-perception emphasises the interconnectedness of personal behaviour and the societal norms, underlining “the negative impression” that disrespecting someone can leave.

(18)

"في تاريخ ١٧ من هذا الشهر ذهبت لي اقدم اختبار براميل وشد انتباهي معلم سياقة يعامل التلميذ بطريقة وقحة فقط لان التلميذ لم يكن يفهم اللغة العربية بطلافه ولم يستوعب ما الذي يطلب منه معلم القيادة. شعرت بالحزن والاستياء للتلميذ لانه وحيد بعيد عن اهله في دولة لا يفهم من ثقافتهم ولا لغتهم".

“On the 17th of this month, I went to take a driving test, and my attention was drawn to a **driving instructor** who treated **the student rudely** simply because the student did not understand the Arabic language well and didn’t comprehend what the driving instructor was asking him. **I felt sad and frustrated** for the student **because he was alone, far from his family, in a country where he doesn’t understand their culture or language**”.

Narrative (18) presents another incident where there is a deviation from the norm of treating people with respect, particularly in an instructional context. A driving instructor is described as treating the student “rudely” because the student did not understand Arabic well, “Just because he didn’t understand Arabic” and struggled to comprehend the instructor’s directions. The use of the phrase “just because” indicates that the reason behind the instructor’s behaviour is unjustifiable. The narrator felt “sad and frustrated”, highlighting the empathy that society expects individuals to show towards those in a vulnerable position. To explain, the mention of the student being alone and far from his family in a foreign country “he was alone, far from his family, in a country where he doesn’t understand their culture or language” amplifies the inappropriate nature of the instructor’s behaviour which significantly breaches the norm of treating people with respect.

(19)

"عندما قام شخص بضرب عامل في سيارة في الشارع عند تعليمه السوافة، شعرت ببغض من تصرف الشخص، اردت ان انزل " من سيارة واتوجه اليه لكن كانت قد اشتغلت إشارات المرور لأنه شخص قام بدفع لك المبلغ لتعليمه السوافة، وليس ضربه وأهانته. جاء من مكان بعيد لي يعمل ويصرف على عائلته في بلادك فيجب انت مساعدته وتمد يد العون وتحترمه كما تريد ان تحترم وتعامله معامله طيبة".

" Someone **hit a worker** inside the car, when he was teaching him how to drive, **I felt hatred toward this person's behaviour**. I wanted to get out of the car and go towards him, but the traffic lights turned green. This worker has paid the driver to get driving lessons, not to beat him and offend him. **He came from afar place** to work and provide for his family in your country. **You should help him and extend a helping hand and respect him as you want to be respected and treat him kindly**".

Narrative (19) intensifies the breach of the norm of respect when an individual, a driving instructor, physically assaults a learner "hit a worker inside the car", in the middle of a driving lesson on the street. This act contravenes the fundamental societal expectation that all individuals regardless of their status or role, deserve to be treated with dignity and respect. The narrator's emotional response to witnessing this violation is one of hatred "I felt hatred towards this person's behaviour" highlighting the gravity of the instructor's misconduct. Moreover, the desire to intervene "I wanted to get out of the car and go toward him", underscores the narrator's recognition of the unjust nature of the act, emphasising the inherent understanding that such behaviour is unacceptable and deserving of immediate condemnation. However, the intervention was hindered by the traffic light adding a layer of helplessness to the scenario. The text clearly delineates the expectation that the learner, who has paid for a service, should receive instructions and guidance, not abuse of offence, "This worker has paid for the driver to get driving lessons, not to beat him and offend him". This expectation is rooted in the norm of respect, which demands that all interactions be conducted with courtesy and humanity.

Further compounding the violation is the learner's background. To explain, the learner is described by the narrator as someone who has come from afar and works to support his family in the instructor's country "he came from a far place to work in your country and provide for his family", highlighting the learner vulnerability. The narrator concludes his narrative with advice embedded with the expectation that "you should help him, extend a helping hand, and respect him as you want to be respected and treat him kindly"; the expected act in this situation is to support the learner, who has not only paid for this service but also carries the burden of supporting a family. The beating inflicted upon him is not just a breach of "respect", but a disregard for his human dignity and precarious situation he navigates coming from afar to earn a livelihood.

In all of the above narratives, the narrator condemns the disrespectful behaviour exhibited towards the workers, who are expatriates. Moreover, all of the emotions expressed in the narratives whether anger, sadness, shame, dismay, hatred, annoyance, or pity, serve to highlight the social expectation of respect that has been breached. These narratives underscore the importance of maintaining respectful interactions and the social consequences when these norms are not adhered to.

7.5 Failure to uphold the norm of treating the children with care and guidance

One of the key norms shaping participants' evaluations of incivility is the expectation that children should be treated with empathy, dignity, and proper guidance. Across the data, participants judged behaviours such as name-calling, physical punishment, public shaming, or failure to intervene in misbehaviour as inappropriate and uncivil. These acts were not only seen as harmful to the child but also as violations of broader social expectations about how children should be treated in public places and guided.

These evaluations are best understood through sociality rights and obligations and face sensitivities (Spencer-Oatey, 2008). Under this theme, the relevant sociality obligation is the parental duty to treat children with care and to guide them. When parents or those in caregiving roles fail to meet these obligations, either through harsh punishment or passive neglect, their actions are seen as breaches of fundamental social responsibilities. At the same time, many of the narrator's reactions express concern for the child's quality face that is, the child's sense of self-worth, which was publicly undermined through verbal or physical mistreatment.

(20)

"قام أحدهم بنعت ابنه في السوق "حيوان" لأنه قام بإسقاط بعض المنتجات في الأرض. شعرت بالأحراج ورحمة الطفل، لأنه لا يعي ما يفعل".

"Someone **called his son in the market "an animal"** because he dropped some products on the ground. **I felt embarrassed and sorry for the child** because he does not understand what he is doing".

The following narratives describe incidents where children were mistreated in various forms. Narrative (20) involves a child being publicly called "an animal" by their parent in a market after accidentally dropping some products on the floor. The observer felt "embarrassed" and "sorry for this

child”, recognising that the child did not understand his own action. The norm that was broken here is calling the child with a derogatory name, “an animal” in a public setting, despite the child not knowing “what he was doing”. The observer’s reactions “feeling embarrassed” on behalf of the child and feeling “sorry” indicates that there is a breach in the expected norm; in other words, feeling emphatic towards the child highlights the societal expectation that children should be treated with a greater level of understanding and care as this child “did not understand what he was doing”.

(21)

"في ضرب الأطفال بسبب رغبتهم للحصول على بعض أنواع الطعام (الفشار، ذرة، عصائر)، الموقف كان غير محبب إطلاقاً لأن فيه إخراج للأطفال ومن الممكن انه يؤثر على شخصيتهم وثقتهم في انفسهم. شعرت بالغضب، ولكن لم ادخل ممكن انخرج وازيد من خجل الأطفال".

“ **Hitting** children because they wanted some types of food (popcorn, corn, juices) **it was an entirely unpleasant situation** because it **embarrassed** the children and could potentially affect their **personalities and self-confidence**. **I felt angry** but **did not intervene**, possibly to avoid embarrassing the children even more”.

Narrative (21) describes another incident involving children being beaten for expressing their desire to have certain type of food “popcorn, corn, juices”, leading to a situation that is “unpleasant” for both the children involved and the bystander. To explain, the use of physical punishment in response to such basic requests not only embarrasses the children but also poses a risk to their developing self-confidence and self- esteem. The narrative explicitly mentions that the situation was “unpleasant because it embarrassed the children and could potentially affect their personalities and self-confidence”. This acknowledgment highlights the normative expectation that children should be treated with care. Furthermore, the bystander’s reactions, including embarrassment, anger, sadness, and helplessness highlight the societal recognition of the norm broken and the discomfort faced when it is broken. The reluctance to intervene, fearing to exacerbate the situation, reflects a complex interplay of emotions and societal norms regarding intervention “did not intervene, possibly to avoid embarrassing the children even more”.

(22)

"شاهدت فتاة صغيرة تتعرض للضرب من قبل أخيها حيث كان يضربها ويرمي عليها كلام جارح. شعرت بالحزن بسبب عدم قدرتي على التدخل وحزنت لرؤية انسان يتم التعامل معه بهذه الطريقة"

"I saw a little girl **being beaten** by her brother, who was **beating her** and **hurling hurtful words** at her. **I felt sad** because I couldn't intervene and **was saddened to see a human being treated in such way**".

Narrative (22) recounts an incident where a little girl is physically and verbally abused by her brother highlighting a violation of the norm concerning treating children with care. The breach of this norm is twofold in this situation: the physical aspect "being beaten by her brother" and the emotional aspect "hurling hurtful words at her". Moreover, similar to narrative (21), the observer's reaction, feeling sadness and helplessness due to their inability to intervene, sheds light on another aspect of this social norm. Witnessing such treatment not only elicits a strong emotional response but also highlights the societal expectation that adults will intervene or at least disapprove of such action to protect the child. Furthermore, the fact that the narrator mentioned "I was saddened to see a human being treated in that way" confirms that there was a breach of norm and reinforces the idea that any deviation from this standard is not only not unacceptable and requires intervention but also deeply saddening.

(23)

"وجود طفلين بصحبة والديهما في حديقة عامه، كانا يعبثان بالورود والأزهار والسياح وانايبب المياه التي تسقي الازهار الجميلة على مراي والديهما دون أي ردة فعل منهم او توجيه او تهذيب لسلوكهم الخاطئ وأيضا صراخهم العالي المزعج الذي أدى الى جذب الانتباه وازعاج الآخرين بما فيه الكفاية. شعرت بالغضب من ردة فعل والديهما لان هذا السلوك يترتب عليه تنشئة جيل لا يقدر ولا يتحمل المسؤولية، وفي عصرنا الحالي المسؤولية المبكرة هي من أولويات ومتطلبات الحياة فينشأ جيل لا يستشعر بقيمة ما حوله وقد يؤدي ذلك الى ارتكابه سلوكيات أخطر في المستقبل".

"There were two children with their parents in a park. They were **tempering with roses, flowers, the fence and the water pipes** that watered the beautiful flowers in front of their **parents without any reaction or guidance or correction** for their wrong behaviour, and also their loud annoying screaming that drew attention and annoyed others. **I felt angry at their parents' reaction** because this behaviour leads to raising a generation that doesn't appreciate or take responsibility. In this era, teaching your children to be reasonable should be one of your top priorities. **Raising a generation that does not value what is around them, potentially leading to more dangerous behaviour in the future**".

Narrative (23) outlines a scenario in a public park where two children were engaging in disruptive behaviours, “tempering with roses, flowers, the fence and the water pipes”. Additionally, the children’s loud and annoying screaming drew attention and significantly disturbed others around them. Nevertheless, while all of that happened “in front of their parents”, the parents did not do anything “without any reaction or guidance or correction for their wrong behaviour”. The fact that the parents did not react to their children’s “wrong behaviour” is what made the narrator angry. The narrator’s frustration with the parents’ non-reactive stance points towards a breached norm where the parents were expected to guide or correct their children. Thus, the parents’ decision not to act or correct their children’s behaviours highlights a neglect of parental obligations to discipline and teach their children. Their inaction suggests a tolerance for disrespect towards public spaces and indifference towards the disturbance caused to others. The narrator warns of the long-term consequences of neglecting these obligations suggesting that today’s uncorrected behaviours could evolve into tomorrow’s more serious societal problems “raising a generation that does not value what is around them, potentially leading to more dangerous behaviour in the future”. In other words, failing to discipline and guide children not only leads to immediate disturbance in public spaces but also risks breeding a future generation that “doesn’t appreciate or take responsibility”.

The norm broken in all of the above narratives is the fundamental expectation that children should be treated with care, kindness, understanding, and protection. The narratives show that this norm was violated by the children’s parents through the acts of name-calling, beating and using hurtful words with them in public, and through not guiding them. It also touches on the bystanders’ dilemma, feeling anger, and sadness, embarrassed but hesitating to intervene due to fear of worsening the situation.

7.6 Failure to uphold norms of road conduct

A recurring concern in participants’ accounts of incivility was the failure to observe expected norms of road behaviour. Across the dataset, informants described behaviours such as overtaking via the yellow lane during traffic congestion, taking up more than one parking space, and reckless driving in areas where families and children are present. These acts are consistently described as ‘inappropriate, and ‘uncivil’, highlighting their perceived incompatibility with the norms.

Several participants explicitly noted that such actions like parking across multiple spaces or driving on the shoulder during traffic, involve ‘infringing on others’ rights’, highlighting a violation of the shared equity rights. The frustration was not only directed at the behaviour itself, but at the way it reflected on the collective image of Omani society. Several participants expressed concern that such

conduct 'portrays Omanis in a negative way', particularly in the presence of tourists, which directly ties with the concept of identity face, where individuals feel responsible for protecting their group's image (Spencer-Oatey, 2000,2008).

The following examples illustrate how breaches of road conduct norms were framed as violations of shared sociality obligations and, in some cases touch on identity face concerns.

(24)

في الشارع، حين يتم التجاوز في الزدحام من الخط الأصفر، شعرت بالغضب لأنه سلوك غير لائق ولأنه كلنا عالقين في "الزحمة

"In the street, when someone **overtakes you in the congestion** from the yellow line, I **felt angry** because **it is inappropriate behaviour**, and **we were all stuck in the traffic**".

(25)

"تجاوز السيارات من جهة التخزين للوصول الى المقدمة وعدم الالتزام بركن السيارات بطريقة صحيحة في المواقف ومواقف المولات. وأيضاً هنالك البعض من الناس الذي يخالف الآداب العامة ويقوم السائق بفتح أبواب سياراتهم والبيصق على الشارع وهذا السلوك غير أخلاقي. شعرت بغضب شديد لأن المتجاوز يتعدى على حق غيره من غير مبرر وهو تصرف ينم عن قلة نوق. ولأنه السيارة تأخذ أكثر من موقف بدن وجه حق. اشعر بالاشمئزاز من هذه التصرفات التي قد تعكس تصرفات الشعب العماني بصورة سلبية وتظهره بصورة غير لائقة وغير حضارية خصوصاً امام السائحين".

"**Overtaking cars from the storage lane to get to the front and not adhering to parking cars correctly** in the parking lots and the malls parking lots. There are also some people who violate public morality; **the drivers open their car doors and spit on the street**. This is unethical behaviour. I felt very angry because **the overtaker was violating the right of others without justification and his behaviour was distasteful and because the car is taking more than one parking space without any right**. I feel disgusted because these behaviours **may reflect the behaviour of the Omani people in a negative way** and show **them in an inappropriate way and uncivilized manner**, especially in front of tourists".

One prime example presented in narrative (24), is the act of overtaking in congested traffic, "when someone overtakes you in the congestion from the yellow line", and another example presented in narrative (25) is "overtaking cars from the storage lane to get to the front". These acts made the narrators in both narratives feel "very angry", as both of them not only feel that this behaviour is "inappropriate" and "distasteful", but also the overtaker "was violating the rights of others without justification" as the narrator in narrative (24) explained that "we were all stuck in the traffic". There is an element of unfairness here, as narrator mentioned that the overtaker "was violating the rights of others", and "we were all stuck in the traffic", which highlights that the overtaker prioritised his own

progress at the expense of others “the rights of others” despite the fact that being stuck in a traffic is a collective experience. Therefore, the narrators’ anger here stems from witnessing a blatant disregard for the collective expected norms that require the individuals to wait for their turn in situations of shared inconvenience.

Moreover, another uncivil behaviour that was highlighted by the narrator in a narrative (25) is “not adhering to parking cars correctly in the parking lot”, which made the narrator angry “because the car was taking more than one parking space without any right”. The mention of “without any right” emphasises again the fact that the rights of others are infringed upon through the lack of consideration for others.

(26)

"تهور الشباب في القيادة في أماكن غير مخصصة للسرعة بالرغم من وجود عوائل وأطفال في تلك المناطق. انزعجت من المنظر وتمنيت ان يكون فيه ردع أكثر لهذه الفئة من الشباب".

“The **recklessness** of **young people driving in areas not designated for speeding** **despite** the presence of **families and children** in those areas. **I was disturbed** by the sight and wished there was more deterrent for this group of young people”.

Another incident that was highlighted in the data, narrative (26), is the “recklessness of young people driving in an area not designated for speeding”. The narrator emphasises that the reckless driving happens “despite the presence of families and children” which makes him feel disturbed and wish for a more “deterrent for this group of young people”. The violation here is not just a matter of breaking traffic laws but also reflects a disregard for the safety and well-being of others, particularly in spaces that should be safe for families and children.

7.7 Failure to uphold the norms of maintaining public cleanliness

A recurring theme in participants’ evaluations of incivility was the failure to maintain cleanliness in shared public spaces. Acts such as discarding rubbish in non-designated areas, throwing cigarette butts from cars, and neglecting to properly dispose of food waste were described as ‘uncivil’ and ‘tarnishing the image of the country’. These evaluations were not simply based on the physical act of polluting, but on deeper social meanings attached to those actions. Participants viewed maintaining cleanliness in shared spaces as a collective responsibility an obligation that each individual is expected to uphold. When people fail to meet this obligation, they are seen as disregarding a key social duty, which reflects a violation of sociality obligations (Spencer-Oatey, 2008).

In addition, participants expressed concern that such behaviour harms the collective image of Omani society. Littering was framed not just as disrespectful to the environment, but as damaging to the reputation of Omanis, particularly in public or tourist spaces. These evaluations point to a desire to protect the social identity face of the group the positive image of Omanis as respectful, clean, and considerate people. Thus, the judgement of incivility in this theme is grounded in both the breach of social obligations and the threat to group reputation. The following examples illustrate how participants framed violations of public cleanliness norms as both a personal and communal failure.

(27)

"رأيت احدهم يرمي حبة سيجارة في الأرض وهو يفقد سيارته وجبه السجارة لازالت والعه والطريق تمشي به السيارات. شعرت بالغضب وقتها، ونزلت واخذت حبة السجارة من الأرض ورميتها في وجهه".

"I saw someone **throw a cigarette butt** on the ground while driving their car, and the **cigarette was still lit with cars** moving on the road. **I felt angry** at that moment, got out, picked up the cigarette butt from the ground, and **threw it in his face**".

Narrative (27) describes a person throwing a cigarette butt on the ground while driving, "and the cigarette is still lit with cars moving on the road". The norm being broken here is twofold. Firstly, the act of littering which goes against the societal expectation for individuals to dispose of their waste properly and respect public spaces. Furthermore, throwing a cigarette butt on the ground especially one that is "still lit", not only pollutes the environment but also poses a fire risk, highlighting a disregard for both environment and the safety of others. This action sparked a strong emotional response in the narrator leading them to physically retrieve the discarded cigarette butt and "threw it in his face". This reaction underscores the narrator's frustration and anger towards the individual's disregard for not only environmental cleanliness but also public safety as the narrator emphasised that "the cigarette was still lit with cars moving on the road".

(28)

"رمي المخلفات في الأماكن العامة، أسلوب غير حضاري".

"**Throwing waste** in public places is an **uncivilized behaviour**".

(29)

"في أكثر من مره لزيارتي للحدائق والأماكن السياحية العامة لاحظت ان الكثير من السكان خصوصا في السهال والجبال يلقون المخلفات في الأماكن الغير مخصصة ويتكاسلون ان يضعوها في المكان الصحيح حتى على اسخف الأشياء مثل المناديل الورقية يلقونها وحتى غرش الماء والذي قد يسبب في تشويه صوره المكان وانتشار الحشرات خصوصا اذا كانت هذه المخلفات من بقايا الاكل. شعرت بالغضب والحزن لان انا كفرد من هذا المجتمع لا ارجب ان يقوم احد بتشويه سمعة بلدي وان بخاطر جعل هذه البلد التي تنعم بالنظافة بأن تكون مليئة بالحشرات فعمان هي بلد تولي اهم اهتماماتها بالحفاظ على البيئة وتقوم بأقصى جهودها للحفاظ عليها فيأتي شخص ويهمل هذا الاهتمام، هذا يشعرنى بالغضب الشديد".

"In more than one occasion during my visits to parks and public tourist places, I have noticed that many residents, especially in the plains and mountains, **throw waste in inappropriate places** and are too lazy to put it in the right place, even with the simplest thing like **paper tissues**. They just toss them aside, as well as **water bottles**, which **can distort the image of the place** and lead to the spread of insects, especially if the waste includes leftover food. I felt angry and sad because, **as a member of this society**, **I do not want anyone tarnishing the reputation of my country or risking turning this clean country** into one **filled with insects**. Oman is a country that prioritizes environmental preservation and makes utmost efforts to maintain it. So, when someone **neglects** this concern, it **makes me very angry**".

In narrative (28) and (29), the narrators describe repeated observations of improper waste disposal by visitors in parks and touristic areas, particularly in valleys and mountains. Individuals are seen discarding trash in non-designated areas "they are too lazy to put in it the right place". The behaviour includes throwing away "paper tissues... water bottles" according to the narrator, "distort the image of the place" and can contribute to the "spread of insects, especially if the waste includes leftover food". This behaviour made the narrator feel "angry and sad" because the narrator "does not want anyone tarnishing the reputation of my country or risking turning this clean country into one filled with insects". The phrase "as a member of this community", emphasises the narrator's identification with their community and nation, stressing a shared responsibility and collective identity. It highlights the belief that individuals' actions reflect on the community as a whole as the narrator said "I don't want anyone tarnishing the reputation of my country. The concern about someone "tarnishing the reputation of the country", speaks to a national pride and the importance of maintaining a positive image internationally. It reflects a recognition of how environmental care and cleanliness are

essential to the nation's identity. Also, the narrator acknowledges and praises the country's effort towards environmental preservation "Oman is a country that prioritises environmental preservation"; this statement serves to contrast the actions of those who litter against the collective efforts made by the country, further emphasising the gravity of the irresponsible behaviour.

The uncivil acts observed in the above narratives, ranging from traffic misconduct to environmental negligence, highlight a critical deviation from the established norm of adhering to traffic regulations and respecting public spaces. The observer's reactions of anger, disgust, and sadness not only underscores the personal impact of witnessing such behaviour but also reflects a collective concern for the violation of this norm. The observers express a strong emotional responses, like " I felt disgusted" and " this makes me very angry", highlighting the deep-seated frustration and disappointment in the community's failure to uphold these standards.

7.8 Conclusion

This chapter has explored how participants evaluate everyday uncivil acts based on diary report data, revealing that the judgements made in the narratives are not solely grounded in the behaviours themselves but in the extent to which they are perceived to violate sociocultural norms. Drawing on a diverse range of lived experiences, the analysis demonstrated that incivility was consistently assessed in relation to shared norms about appropriate conduct in public spaces. When behaviours were seen to undermine these collective understandings, they were judged as uncivil and socially unacceptable.

Participants' evaluations of incivility was primarily triggered by perceived threats to the social identity face of the Omani society, which was clearly evident across the themes presented in this chapter (Spencer-Oatey, 2000, 2008). For instance, it was evident in breaches of public decency norms (e.g. immodest dress and men's inappropriate conduct toward women in public), the mistreatment of expatriate workers, disregard for road conduct norms (e.g., reckless driving), and neglect of public cleanliness (e.g. littering in tourist areas). Their evaluation of incivility was also triggered by unfulfilled sociality rights and obligations (Spencer-Oatey, 2000, 2008), specifically expectations related to equity rights, which was evident in the treatment of expatriate workers (e.g. shouting at service staff) and in road conduct (e.g. overtaking in traffic or taking multiple parking spots). It was also triggered by failure to fulfil obligations of care and guidance towards children (e.g. verbal abuse and lack of parental guidance), and finally failure to uphold cleanliness (e.g. leaving rubbish in public or natural spaces).

Across all of the previously discussed findings, participants did not merely report behaviours they perceived as uncivil rather they evaluated those behaviours in relation to deeply held norms and expectations. These evaluations were shaped by both concern for the collective image of Omani society and a shared understanding of sociality rights and obligations (Spencer-Oatey, 2000, 2008). In this case, incivility is socially judged, drawing upon sociocultural norms and expectations.

CHAPTER 8: DISCUSSION

8.1 Introduction

This chapter critically engages with the findings presented in Chapters 4, 5, 6, and 7, drawing insights from both phases of the study to reflect on what makes Omani people take offence and what norms govern the perception of incivility. The discussion in this chapter situates these findings within the broader literature, highlighting areas of alignment as well as contributions that offer new perspectives. This chapter is structured thematically around a series of key insights and interpretive observations that emerged through close engagement with the data across both phases as well as through sustained interaction with the literature throughout the research process. Section 8.2 introduces how social identity face informed participants' evaluations of both taking offence and incivility. Section 8.2.1 focuses specifically on taking offence, discussing how social identity face informed the judgement of offence in relation to the various strands of literature. It then moves to Section 8.2.1 which considers how similar face concerns underpin participants' evaluations of incivility. Following this, Section 8.3 discusses taking offence in response to unmet sociocultural expectations in the diary report narratives. It is then followed by a discussion in Section 8.4 of how power dynamics and social hierarchy influence the perceptions of incivility. Finally, section 8.6 concludes the chapter

8.2 Social identity face in the evaluation of offence and incivility

A key theme emerging from the analysis of X data for both taking offence and incivility is the strong concern with how behaviour reflects on the social groups with which individuals identify. In this chapter, social identity face is understood in Spencer-Oatey's (2007, 2008) relational approach, referring to the aspect of face linked to one's membership in a social group and the expectations associated with representing that group. It captures participants' desire for their group identities such as nationality, religion or community belonging to be respected, acknowledged, and positively represented. In this sense, individuals' actions are not judged in isolation but are evaluated in relation to how well they reflect the social norms associated with their group. According to Culpeper (2011), the potential for face damage is intricately linked to the degree of sensitivity of the face component in question as well as the perceived degree of exposure. Sensitivity refers here to how crucial and emotionally significant a particular aspect of face to the evaluator, with more central components eliciting stronger reactions to perceived offence or uncivility. This was evident when the values and attributes that Omani people claim to have and are expected to uphold were threatened (Culpeper,

2011, Spencer- Oatey, 2007).

The degree of exposure, on the other hand, pertains to the extent to which these components are subject to public scrutiny and potential criticism. As Culpeper (2011) posits, higher exposure in a public setting amplifies the potential for face damage. This was evident in X data narratives, where social identity face concerns were strongly expressed in both taking offence and incivility, particularly when behaviours seen as inappropriate or unrepresentative of Omani identity occurred in highly visible contexts. However, in the diary reports, social identity face concerns were primarily associated with incivility, given its focus on public spaces, where actions are more visible and subject to greater social scrutiny.

8.2.1 Social identity face in the evaluation of offence

Findings from X demonstrated that offence was often expressed in response to representations or behaviour perceived as misrepresenting Omanis and diminishing their dignity. Participants oriented strongly to social identity face In collectivist societies like Oman, where social identity face, treating portrayals of Omanis not merely as depictions of individuals but as reflections of the whole group. As a result, misrepresentations or negative portrayals were evaluated as often perceived as direct affront/infringement to Omani society as a whole.

One of the most evident expressions of this concern was seen in responses to an advertisement portraying an Omani emerging from a manhole, which was evaluated as “an insult” (see for section 4.2 in chapter 4). The reaction was not simply about how one individual was depicted but about the negative connotation of the image, which was seen as degrading and misrepresenting Omanis as a whole. This pattern was further evident in reactions to a statement by the CEO of Al Jazeera Iron Company who claimed that “Omanis are incapable of producing a single gram without foreigners” (see section 4.5 in chapter 4). The response framed this remark as a direct violation of “Oman’s dignity ”, underscoring that it was perceived as an attack on Omani competence and therefore on group identity face. These findings align with recent research on identity positioning on Facebook in Tunisia (Labben, 2022). The study found that Tunisian Facebook users actively responded to identity face threats particularly when external representations were perceived as damaging “ the face of the country” (p.48). This strong concern for public image of the country mirrors the reaction observed in the Omani context.

Moreover, Omanis did not only take offence at misrepresentation of their own country, but also reacted strongly to negative portrayals directed at other Gulf countries, particularly the UAE and Saudi

Arabia (see Chapter 4 examples 9,10 &11). These responses framed offences against Gulf countries as offences to Oman as a nation, reflecting how Omanis perceived their social identity face as intertwined with the broader Gulf identity. This sentiment was encapsulated in the assertion that ‘those who offend them offend us’ and further reinforced by explicit statement ‘ the Gulf countries are part of us, and ‘they are our family’. However, Omanis’ strong reactions to perceived misrepresentation contrast with findings from Culpeper, J., Marti, L., Mei, M., Nevala, M., and Schauer, G. (2010), which examined impoliteness perceptions across England, China, Finland, Germany and Turkey. Drawing on Spencer-Oatey’s rapport management framework (2000), the findings showed that one of the least prominent categories of offence was social identity face, whereas quality face concern emerged as the most significant. This suggests that in these contexts, offence was primarily linked to one’s self-worth rather than social identity face.

This distinction aligns with Ting-Toomey (1988, 2005), arguments that patterns of face concern vary across social contexts, with some placing greater emphasis on self-face concerns, making direct threats to personal identity more salient. In other contexts, people orient more strongly to social identity face, meaning they place higher priority on the self as a member of a group, and they tend to view individuals’ negative behaviour as something that reflects on the group (Ting-Toomey, 1994 & Al Zidjaly, 2012). In the present study, a heightened sensitivity to threats to social identity face was evident in the way participants consistently framed behaviour in relation to the groups with which they identified. Participants were particularly concerned with how certain actions misrepresented “Omanis” or projected a negative image of the country. This pattern was evident in the corpus findings, where the frequent use of collective pronouns (we, us, our) and collective nouns (the people, the Omanis, the country) underscored that offence was framed in relation to the group rather than the individual. This also aligned with Labben’s (2022) corpus linguistic findings, which highlighted the intensive use of deictic expressions to speak on behalf of the group, reinforcing how concerns about social identity can shape responses to perceived threats

Offence was also triggered by some of the in-group members whose behaviour was perceived as a direct affront to Omani social identity face. This offence stems from the deeply held expectation that Omanis should consistently embody and uphold the values and attributes that characterise their group members as a whole. These expectations are rooted in the social norms dictating that as a member of a particular group community, “ you ought to behave in a particular circumscribed manner” (Hogg & Abrams,2007, p.159). Having said that, Barth (1969) maintains that the identification of another person as a fellow member of a group implies a mutual understanding of these norms,

essentially suggesting that all members are expected to “play the same game” (p.15). This was evident in multiple instances where Omanis were criticised for behaviour perceived as not aligning with “the authentic Omani”. One such case involved an Omani who used offensive language toward a Bangladeshi person during a match (see excerpt 8). The backlash was not merely about the language but about what it symbolised, a failure to embody the implicit ideals expected of an Omani.

This criticism was framed in terms of a violation of in-group norms, reinforcing the idea that being an “authentic Omani” entails adherence to specific behavioural expectations. This mutual understanding is not merely about adhering to norms, but also about embodying the prototype of the ‘authentic Omani’, which serves as a representation of the ideal or most typical group member (Hogg, 2005). That is, their beliefs, values, and behaviours are strongly aligned with group norms (McGarty, Turner, Hogg, David and Wetherell, 1992). The data analysis revealed that participants assume, often without explicitly stating it, that every member of the group inherently understands what constitutes the “authentic Omani”. This taken for granted assumption is characteristic of social norms, which as Bicchieri (2006) argues, operate implicitly and only become visible when violated. This was reflected when participants labelled certain behaviours as “against Omani values” or “doesn’t represent us as Omanis”, without further clarification, suggesting unspoken agreement about what is deemed acceptable within Omani society.

Embedded within this understanding of the ‘authentic Omani’ are implicit moral attributes that are perceived as inherent to the group’s identity, shaping both individual behaviour and collective belonging. The moral attributes that participants alluded to, whether implicitly or explicitly, revolved around fundamental values such as respect, fairness, and dignity. According to Giner-Sorolla (2012) when people agree on key values that characterises their group, these values function as a moral standard that defines group identity and guides the social expectations. Rather than treating these values as universal moral principles (Haidt, 2001), they are framed as group-specific moral standards that differentiate their group members from others. This was evident in participants’ tweets, where morality was explicitly linked to group belonging (see Chapter 4 examples 8,9 &10). In these instances, morality was invoked as an essential aspect of being an ‘authentic Omani’, they used moral discourse to assert ingroup distinctiveness, framing certain behaviours as either aligning with or violating shared moral expectations. For example, statements such ‘an action that lacks the most basic morals we were raised with as Omanis’ and ‘Oman and its people are a school of noble morals’ highlight how morality functions as part of the sociocultural norms and expectations.

8.2.2 Social identity face in the evaluation of incivility

A similar pattern emerged in the evaluation of incivility, where individuals perceived uncivil behaviour as threats to social identity face (Spencer- Oatey, 2007, 2000). Across various uncivil acts, including littering, inappropriate dress, spitting and reckless driving, participants judged these behaviours not merely as individual misconduct but as violations of social norms that define and maintain Omani identity. The significance of these acts stemmed from how they contradicted the social norms regulating how Omanis should present themselves in public, embodying the values and attributes that define their group identity, and illustrating that identity is not merely possessed but performed and regulated through social evaluation (Goffman, 1967, Kádár & Haugh, 2013).

Concerns about social identity face were particularly evident in discussions about littering in public spaces. In the X data and diary report, Omanis did not merely see littering as an issue of environmental irresponsibility (see Chapter 6 excerpts 8,9 & 10) or personal negligence but as a behaviour that tarnishes the image of the nation (see Chapter 6 excerpts 5,6 & 7 and Chapter 7 excerpt 29). Participants frequently framed littering as a practice that negatively reflects on the place due to an individual's action reinforcing the notion that individual actions contribute to the collective reputation of the country. Similarly, one respondent questioned, “why are we presenting an uncivilised image of the region?” underscoring the broader concern that such behaviours distort the image of the region.

This perception aligns with broader discourse on incivility, where actions that disrupt social order are not only condemned for their immediate effect, but also their symbolic implications. The act of littering, like many other uncivil behaviours analysed in chapter 6 and 7, was not merely seen as a failure to uphold the value of cleanliness that Omanis collectively endorse but also an act that tarnishes the nation's image, threatening the social identity face of Omanis. As one participant articulated this sentiment explicitly, stating “I do not want anyone to tarnish the reputation of my country”, reinforcing the idea that incivility threatens the national identity. This was especially apparent in highly visible locations such as tourist destinations, where exposure heightens the potential for identity face threat (Culpeper, 2011). The presence of litter in public parks, valleys and beaches, frequented by both locals and visitors from outside the country, reinforced concerns about how such behaviour reflected on the nation's image. The presence of foreigners or visitors, in these spaces further exacerbated the perceived inappropriateness of the behaviour, as it gives a negative image of the country and its people.

This dynamic closely parallels Zhang, Pearce, and Chen's (2019) study on Chinese tourists and

uncivilised behaviour, which found that fear of “losing collective face” motivated Chinese travellers to adopt more “civilised” behaviours when travelling abroad. Zhang et al. (2019) noted that some Chinese travellers would actively correct or reprimand fellow tourists who engaged in behaviours perceived as inappropriate such as littering, or speaking too loudly, or disregarding local etiquette because they feared that such acts would reinforce negative stereotypes about the Chinese as a whole.

Another concern that was frequently narrated was wearing immodest or inappropriate clothing in public, which was seen as directly violating the norms of modesty that define acceptable public appearance and that are tied to the social identity face (see Chapter 7, excerpts 2,3 & 4). Participants framed these violations as a threat to group identity face, as one stated “it gives bad impression of Omani people”. The disapproval of immodest attire stemmed from its perceived misalignment with social norms that dictate modest, and appropriate public attire.

In several excerpts, immodesty and other uncivil acts such as littering were framed through a religious lens (see Chapter 7 excerpt 4 and Chapter 6 excerpts 1,2,3 & 4), as one participant noted “it does not reflect our religion” and in another excerpt “we are people of religion and cleanliness”. This suggests that some evaluation of social norms stemmed directly from religious beliefs that regulate behaviour, shaping what is considered acceptable (Durkheim, 1916). In Muslim societies like Oman, religion plays a significant role in shaping social norms, providing a framework for what ‘ought to be’ performed, influencing how people behave in public life. However, not all participants invoked religion when discussing modesty and other uncivil acts. Instead, their disapproval stemmed from the act deviating from social values, tradition, and moral attributes that they uphold as a group. Nevertheless, even when participants did not explicitly invoke religion, the values they alluded to were inherently rooted in religious teachings, demonstrating how religious principles continue to shape social norms, even when framed through a cultural or identity-based lens.

While adhering to modest attire was considered important, wearing traditional clothing while behaving in a way that deviates from cultural expectations was perceived as a more serious violation of social norms. Traditional attire, such as the *dishdasha* and *khanjar*, is a visual marker of Omani identity, but its significance extends beyond appearance; it carries implicit expectations of conduct (Watzlawik, 2012). To wear these symbols is to embody the behaviours and values they represent, making actions that contradict this expectation particularly, threatening to the group identity face (Spencer- Oatey, 2007). These symbols “are not significant in themselves but derive meaning from the ways in which individuals within a culture ascribe meaning to them (Banks, 2011). That is,

traditional dress is more than an external expression of identity; it is a social contract that requires the wearer to uphold certain behaviours. This was evident in the public disapproval of individuals who wore these symbols while engaging in behaviour deemed “inappropriate” and “uncivil”. For instance, young men wearing the the khanjar (dagger) while dancing in an “inappropriate way” (see excerpt 12) faced strong criticism. The disapproval was not just about the act of dancing but about the perceived misuse of Khanjar in a context that contradicted how some believed it should be used. The Khanjar is considered a national symbol (Al Busaidi, 2014) representing pride, masculinity and identity (Althagafi, 2022). By engaging in behaviour seen as “غير لائق” inappropriate, the individual was perceived as misrepresenting what the Khanjar stands for. The reaction “honestly, this does not please me, when will they stop?”, highlights the belief that wearing the khanjar carries implicit expectations of appropriate conduct.

As a national and identity symbol, those who wear it are expected to embody the qualities it signifies. When behaviour contradicts this expectation, it is not viewed as an individual act but as something that reflects on the larger group, leading to public disapproval as a way to uphold its meaning. Similarly, an Omani was condemned for publicly eating and drinking during Ramadan while wearing a dishdasha (see excerpt 13). The criticism was not just about failing to fulfil a religious obligation but about the contradiction between the symbolic significance of the dishdasha and the behaviour that undermined its expected meaning. By wearing it, the individual implicitly declared himself to be part of Omani community, which in turn implied adherence to the values it represents, including religious observance. When this alignment is broken, it is seen as violating a religious norm that is embedded in Omani identity.

8.3 Taking offence in the diary report due to unmet expectations

While the previous discussion of X data and diary report on incivility highlighted how social group identity face influences perceptions of offence (Spencer-Oatey, 2007), the diary report findings also revealed that taking offence can stem from violations of more personal expectations in various interactions. These expectations are not linked to collective identity, i.e. self in relation to the group (Spencer-Oatey, 2000), but rather linked to self in relation to the individual himself/ herself, and in some cases linked to the self in context on ongoing relationships. The diary report findings revealed six types of expectations that when violated led participants to report feelings of being offended. These included expectation related to quality face (being recognised for their competence), interpersonal expectations (appropriate behaviour based on relational history), equity (fair and considerate treatment), reciprocity (the expectation that one’s action will be met with a corresponding

or appropriate response), deference (respect based on social role) and association (inclusion, and self-expression in social interactions) were violated (Spencer-Oatey, 2005, 2007, 2008; Culpeper, 2011; Shils, 1982). Among these I will discuss two in detail: interpersonal expectations and reciprocity expectations. Notably, interpersonal expectations extend into reciprocity, as individuals expect that the dynamic of their relationship will involve mutual exchanges and balanced responses (Spencer-Oatey, 2008; Gouldner, 1960).

Starting with interpersonal expectations, the findings indicate that one of the most significant sources of offence stems from relational history. Participants anticipated a certain level of appropriate behaviour based on prior interactions and the nature of their relationships (see Chapter 4, examples 4 & 5). When these expectations were violated, participants perceived the offence as a failure to uphold interpersonal obligations, particularly in relationships where mutual understanding was assumed. In this regard, Kádár and Haugh (2013) maintain that in closed relational networks, conventions are often evoked by relational history, meaning that patterns of interaction develop over time and establish implicit expectations for behaviour within the relationship. In these networks, members repeatedly engage with each other in ways that reinforce shared norms, making violations of these norms particularly salient. This aligns with the findings in the present study, where participants took offence not only because of what was done or said but because of who said it. For instance, offence was reported when participant experienced insult and betrayal from individuals with whom they shared relational history. This was evident in statements like 'this insult came from someone close' and 'someone you trust and consider a sister'. These examples highlight that perceived offence is deeply tied to expectations embedded within relationships. In the participant accounts, the perceived betrayal was amplified because the offence came from a person she trusted, reinforcing how relational history shapes evaluations of offence.

Tayebi (2016) similarly found in her study, on Persian speakers, that offence frequently arose from violations of implicit relational expectations shaped by their relational histories. Participants reported feeling offended when family members, friends, or partners behaved in ways that contradicted the expectation formed in the context of that relationship. These expectations typically remain unnoticed when they are met, as they align seamlessly with the established relational norms, but become highly visible when breached, triggering offence (Kádár and Haugh, 2013). This highlights how perceptions of offence are deeply embedded within relational contexts and are significantly influenced by the implicit norms developed over time.

Closely connected to these interpersonal expectations were the expectations of reciprocity, referring to the expectations that one's actions will be matched by an appropriate or corresponding response (see Chapter 4, examples 8, 9 & 10). The analysis indicated that reciprocity expectations often overlapped with interpersonal expectations, as relationships inherently involve mutual exchange and shared obligations (Ohashi & Chang, 2017; Gouldner, 1960). An offence was reported when a reciprocal expectation tied to a prior act of service was met with ingratitude or disregard. For instance, one participant took offence when a favour intended as an act of care was misinterpreted as harm, stating: 'I wanted to do a favour to my grandmother'. Another participant described feeling deeply offended when a person they had previously helped later offended them publicly on social media, stating 'I felt so angry because I helped this person before'. Both cases illustrate that the offence stemmed from the absence of reciprocity, which is strongly tied to the relational context. In the case of the grandmother, the expectation of acknowledgment was rooted in an established relationship, reinforced by previous interactions, where familial bonds typically assume mutual understanding (Spencer-Oatey, 2008).

In contrast, the social media example reflects an expectation of reciprocity based on a prior interaction, where a past act of support established an implicit social obligation that was later violated (Gouldner, 1960). However, example 8 (see Chapter 5, section 5.6) highlights a different type of reciprocity expectation, one that is not based on prior relationships or interaction but on immediate, 'here and now' reciprocity expectation (Tantucci,Wang, and Culpeper, 2022). In this case, the participant extended help to a stranger in real-time, anticipating acknowledgement or gratitude in return. The offence arose when this expectation was met with hostility instead of recognition, violating an assumed norm of immediate reciprocity in social exchanges (Gouldner, 1960; Trivers, 1971). This demonstrates that reciprocity violations do not only emerge from past relational histories but also from momentary interactions where individuals expect their act to be reciprocated within the same exchange rather than future repayment (Culpeper & Tantucci, 2021; Tantucci,Wang, and Culpeper, 2022).

8.4 Power and the perception of incivility and offence

The analysis in chapter 7 (see examples 14,15,16,17,18 & 19). demonstrated that incivility is particularly salient when power is exercised in ways that violate equity norms. While impoliteness can be legitimised within certain power structures, people do not necessarily render it socially acceptable (Bousfield, 2008; Locher & Watts, 2005, Culpeper, 2011). Many participants in the study evaluated certain interactions as uncivil when they perceived a misuse of power that disregarded fundamental expectations of fairness and consideration (Spencer-Oatey, 2002,2005), particularly in

encounters between Omanis and foreign workers. These perceptions were especially pronounced in interactions between customers and service employees in coffee shops and supermarkets, as well as between students and instructors during driving lessons. All of these interactions come with inherent power imbalance (e.g. worker/employee). Beyond the focal event, Omanis occupied a structurally advantaged position, not only due to their unequal role relations in the immediate interaction (Spencer-Oatey, 2000), but also because of broader socioeconomic factors, such as citizenship status, economic stability, and societal privilege (Goodwin and Duranti, 1992). In contrast, foreign workers often held lower social standing, occupying subordinate positions with limited agency in day-to-day life. This broader context shaped how participants evaluated the act as uncivil and inappropriate. One participant acknowledged the difficult conditions of foreign workers, remarking that ‘they came from their country and work hard to earn a living’. Such a comment reflects an awareness of systemic inequalities, which in turn influenced how participants judged acts of unfairness or inconsideration. Although the power imbalance was rarely made explicit, it was often assumed rather than explicitly acknowledged, yet it structured the interactions and shaped participants’ judgements of incivility (Locher & Watts, 2005).

This was evident in various incidents where customers and driving instructors mistreated the foreign worker by yelling at them, speaking to them harshly, or even resorting to physical violence (see chapter 7, examples 14,15,16,17,18 & 19). Participants reacted with anger, frustration, and moral condemnation, emphasising the unfairness of such treatment, particularly given the disadvantages faced by foreign workers. Wartenberg (1990) maintains that power is exercised when one social agent strategically constrains another’s action-environment. However, as the examples illustrated, such constraints are not always deliberate but instead emerge through established power structures. These structural limitations restrict foreign workers’ ability to challenge mistreatment, while simultaneously granting those in privileged positions greater freedom to exercise their power over them (Locher & Watts, 2005). Incivility is therefore most likely to be manifested by the powerful to the powerless, because it has few consequences (Lakoff, 2005). This asymmetry in these interactions reinforced an unspoken power imbalance, limiting the ability of foreign workers to respond to mistreatment.

Participants’ reactions suggest an awareness of these implicit constraints, particularly when power was used in ways that violated expectations of fairness and respectful treatment. In response to such incidents, participants articulated what they believed an instructor or customer *ought to do* in interactions with foreign workers (Spencer-Oatey, Kádár, 2021), for example, one participant said,

'you should help him and extend a helping hand and respect him'. By articulating what ought to be done, the participants implicitly acknowledged the power asymmetry in these interactions. Their responses suggest that considerate treatment, fairness and respect are obligations expected from those in dominant positions.

In addition to the ways power dynamics involving people in vulnerable positions shaped participant's evaluation, judgements of offence and incivility were also shaped by a broader social context in which men hold greater power in the society. In Oman, as in much of the region, men have historically held more power in the society, and this influenced how some male participants judged what they considered offensive or inappropriate. This context is particularly relevant in this study given that the online dataset was predominantly contributed by men, which inevitably shaped the evaluative patterns observed. Within this gendered power structure, taking offence can intertwine with questions of authority, where what is perceived as offensive may in fact signal a perceived challenge to one's position of power. For instance, when male participants expressed feeling offended by women's dress or public conduct, their reactions may be understood not only as violation to sociocultural norms such as breach of modesty expectations, but also as an indication that their sense of authority and power felt undermined. In this sense offence or incivility function as response to a perceived threat to one's social authority. Acknowledging these gendered dynamics is important in this research, as they shape how participants interpret and evaluate behaviour, and therefore influence the patterns that emerge in the findings. These insights also point to the need for future research that examines taking offence and incivility from the perspective of women and marginalised groups in the society, whose experiences may bring different evaluative patterns.

8.5 Conclusion

This chapter has brought together findings from both phases of the study along with findings from other studies to provide an integrated discussion of the sociocultural norms and expectations that ground the people's judgement of offence and incivility in the Omani society. It highlighted the central role of social identity face in shaping the judgement, particularly in response to behaviour that threatens the image of Omanis. The discussion showed that taking offence in X was mainly tied to group identity, while the diary reports revealed that offence was often rooted in personal expectations. Whereas incivility in both X data and diary reports was tied to breach of public norms that are tied to religion, social identity face, and shared responsibility. It also discussed incivility and taking offence in relation to power, showing that many behaviours perceived as uncivil were evaluated through the lens of structural and interactional asymmetries.

CHAPTER 9: CONCLUSION

9.1 Introduction

This study offered an in-depth investigation into what causes Omani people to take offence and the norms that govern the perception of incivility within Omani society. By focusing on norms and expectations perceived to be violated, the research examined how individuals evaluate behaviour as offensive and uncivil in both X (previously known as Twitter) and diary reports.

The current chapter aims to revisit the key findings in relation to the two research questions (see Section 8.2). It then reflects on the study's limitations (see Section 8.5) and proposes directions for future research.

9.2 Key Findings of the Research

Having presented the findings in detail in Chapters 4, 5, 6, and 7, this section synthesises the key insights that emerged from both phases of the study. It draws together the results of the corpus-based analysis and thematic analysis of X data and the diary report narratives. The findings are organised in relation to the two central research questions, which focus on the role of violated norms and expectations in shaping Omani individuals' evaluations.

9.2.1 Understanding what causes Omani people to take offence in Omani society

The first research question aimed to explore what causes people in the Omani society to take offence. As outlined in earlier chapters (see Chapters 1, 2, and 4), this study adopts an expectation and norm-based approach to offence. It draws on Parvaresh's (2022) definition of taking offence, which was adapted from Culpeper (2011) and Haugh (2015). Parvaresh defines offence as "emotionally bad feeling created by what is perceived to be a transgression of (social) expectations and (moral) norms" (p.62). In this study, I adopt Parvaresh's definition but focus specifically on social expectations and norms rather than (moral) norms. As argued earlier in Chapter 1, Section 1.2, recent research on impoliteness has increasingly highlighted morality-anchored evaluations of offence. However, the data in this study show that even when morality is evoked, it is based on locally shared values tied to Omani culture and identity, rather than universal moral principles. In other words, participants' references to morality were tied to what it means to be Omani, that is, to the shared sociocultural norms that shape expectations of appropriate behaviour.

Taking offence is therefore not simply "a bad feeling" but a socially grounded judgement involving

both emotional expression and evaluative justification. This was evident across the corpus and thematic analyses of X data, as well as the thematic analysis of the diary report narratives, which consistently demonstrated that offence involved both registering and sanctioning (Culpeper, 2011; Haugh, 2015). Registering offence refers to the expression of a negative emotional response, such as when respondents said, 'I felt bad' and 'I felt embarrassed' when a transgression is perceived. Sanctioning offence, on the other hand, is "a process by which interactants ground their moral claim of prior transgression, affront or misdeed" (Haugh, 2015, p.38). In other words, while registering reflects how participants felt, sanctioning reflects why they believed their feelings were justified. Based on the data, both processes were often present, but not always equally explicit. In some cases, particularly in the diary reports, participants registered taking offence without clearly sanctioning the behaviour. The emotional reaction was evident, but the specific social or cultural norm being violated was left implicit or assumed rather than directly stated.

In the X data, offence was often framed as a group concern, with users employing inclusive terms such as everyone, Omanis, or citizens to suggest that the offence impacted the wider social group, not just the individual. This collective framing was reinforced through emotionally charged language that registered offence on behalf of the group. Phrases like 'Isn't this an insult to the country and its people' and 'This is the greatest insult to the Omani people' illustrate this pattern. Most of the expressions of registering offence in X data were accompanied by sanctioning, where the users justified their reaction by referring to violated norms and expectations. These norms were closely tied to concerns about how Omanis and their national and regional identity were portrayed in public discourse. A recurring pattern in the data showed that users expressed offence when representations of Oman and Omanis were seen as inaccurate, disrespectful, or undermining the image of the country. This included not only portrayals by outsiders but also instances where fellow Omanis were perceived as behaving in ways that misrepresented the group. This concern reflected what Spencer-Oatey (2002, 2005) refers to as social identity face, where individuals are concerned with how their group is represented and evaluated in public discourse. In this context, taking offence functioned as a form of public sanctioning, used to call out behaviour or discourse that contradicted how Omanis believe their group should be portrayed.

While X data demonstrated how offence was constructed as a collective judgement tied to public portrayals of group identity face (Spencer-Oatey 2002 and 2005), the diary report narratives revealed how individuals took offence in more personal and relational contexts, often grounded in implicit social expectations. Participants registered offence using phrases such as 'I felt sad', 'I was angry',

'I was frustrated', and 'I felt ashamed and embarrassed'. These emotional responses were triggered by perceived violations of a range of expectations, such as the expectation to be treated fairly and with consideration, to be recognised for one's competence, and to have one's act of 'favour' appreciated, to be included and allowed to express oneself, to receive appropriate behaviour from others based on one's institutional role and to be treated in ways that align with expectations typically associated with close relationships. These expectations shaped how participants judged the situations they found offensive, functioning as implicit norms against which behaviour was evaluated as offensive.

9.2.2 Understanding the norms that govern the perceptions of incivility

The second research question aimed to explore the norms that govern how incivility is perceived and evaluated in Omani society. As with the analysis of taking offence, the study of incivility adopts an evaluative perspective, focusing on how participants interpret certain behaviours as uncivil in light of shared sociocultural norms and expectations. Drawing on insights from a range of disciplines (see Chapter 3, Section 2.7) including criminology, organisational psychology, and political science, and especially sociological studies (Phillips & Smith, 2006; Horgan, 2020, 2024) and (im)politeness research (Sifianou, 2019; Haugh, 2022), this study defined incivility as a perceived transgression of sociocultural norms that govern appropriate conduct in public places, often marked by emotionally charged reactions.

From this perspective, incivility is not understood as a set of behaviours that are inherently inappropriate or uncivil but as actions that are interpreted as violating implicit or explicit rules that structure everyday life in public settings. What constitutes incivility, therefore, is not the act itself, but the meaning assigned to it by the participants within a specific context. This was evident in the commenters' evaluations. To explain, the commenters across the two corpora, those built using the hashtags #uncivil and # inappropriate, often referred to the same set of behaviours as uncivil. However, the grounds they appealed to in order to legitimise their claims differed, reflecting a variety of sociocultural norms individuals drew on. For instance, the act of 'throwing rubbish' was one of the most mentioned behaviours, but the basis for judging it as uncivil varied across the comments. Some participants, for example, drew on religious grounds, referencing Islamic teachings such as 'cleanliness is part of faith' and 'we are people of religion and cleanliness to argue that such behaviour reflected a failure to uphold religious obligations. Others evaluated it based on how the behaviour affected the public image of the area, particularly in contexts that involve outsiders such as 'tourists' or 'visitors. This was apparent when some X users used phrases like 'it reflects negatively on the

place' and 'why are we conveying an uncivilised image of the region?' framing it as threatening the social identity face of the community. Furthermore, some participants based their evaluations on an assumed shared societal obligation for individuals within a group to maintain the cleanliness of public spaces. This perspective positioned incivility as a failure to uphold communal responsibility for maintaining cleanliness. It was evident in the use of phrases like 'weak societal reasonability' and "this is not an excuse to litter in the area. Be responsible". The analysis thus highlights how a single behaviour can give rise to multiple interpretations depending on the normative lens through which it is assessed.

Additionally, 'inappropriate dress' was also frequently mentioned as uncivil and inappropriate. However, as with the 'littering', the grounds on which X users based their evaluation varied. To explain, in some instances, the judgements were rooted in context-specific conventions. For example, some commenters criticised individuals for wearing casual clothing in formal settings such as 'government departments' where wearing formal attire, specifically the 'dishdasha' is explicitly prescribed. Nevertheless, evaluations based on explicit norms were not the only basis for judging attire as uncivil. In other cases, the participants evaluated the attire in relation to implicit sociocultural norms that are not codified. For example, some commenters criticised individuals for 'wearing pyjamas' in mosques and shopping malls. While there are no formal dress codes in these contexts, such attire was perceived as inappropriate because it conflicted with widely shared expectations about how one should present oneself in public. In both cases, the attire was not inherently inappropriate but became so through its perceived misalignment with the explicit and implicit norms governing appropriate appearance in particular public settings.

Beyond the norms tied to specific settings, certain behaviours were evaluated as uncivil because they were performed by individuals who were visibly marked as Omani, either through national dress or other cultural symbols. To explain, acts such as eating during Ramadan and dancing in a video, or producing content perceived as inappropriate were frequently labelled 'inappropriate' when performed by individuals identified as 'Omani', or visibly wearing attire that represented Omanis. In all these cases, the judgement was based on the perceived mismatch between the identity signalled by the individual's appearance and the behaviour they engaged in. X users alluded to visible identity markers such as the 'dishdasha' or 'khanjar' as part of the grounds for their evaluations, suggesting that those who display such identity-related symbols are expected to uphold the sociocultural norms associated with them. In other words, wearing these symbols, 'dishdasha' or 'khanjar', carries an obligation to behave in ways that align with behavioural norms tied to Omani identity. Consequently, when the behaviour failed to meet the expectations tied to this

identity, it was seen as a violation that threatens the image of the wider community. Incivility in this context was constructed not just through behavioural transgression, but through the social meaning assigned to the actor's identity and the symbolic significance of their appearance.

In addition to insights drawn from X data, the diary report findings confirmed the central argument of this study that incivility is not defined by the act itself, but by how individuals' evaluated behaviours as transgressions of shared sociocultural norms. They also expanded the scope of analysis by introducing behaviours that are not present in the X data, such as beating expatriate workers, harassing women, taking up more than one parking space, among several others. At the same time, some of the concerns raised in the diary report echoed those seen in the X data, such as littering and attire-related concerns. However, despite these differences in the types of acts described by participants across both datasets, X and diary report consistently anchored their evaluations in similar sociocultural norms. Most notably, many judgements were underpinned by concerns for social identity face, which refers in this context to the desire for individuals within a group to see their collective identity positively represented (Spencer-Oatey, 2000). This concern was evident across a wide range of behaviours, such as littering, dressing immodestly, or 'disrespecting the seller'. The evaluations of the participants in all of these behaviours centered around the failure to act in accordance with how Omanis view themselves to be, and how they want others to view them. For example, littering in tourist areas was said to give a negative image of the area to outsiders. Likewise, women's immodest attire was said not to "reflect a good image of Omani society", and disrespecting expatriate workers was said to give a negative impression of Omanis.

While the evaluation of the previously mentioned behaviour was often grounded in concerns for social identity face, the same behaviours were also interpreted through a different sociocultural norm. For instance, the mistreatment of expatriate workers was evaluated by some participants as a violation of equity rights, that is, the expectation to treat others with fairness and consideration, particularly, in this context, those in vulnerable positions such as 'being away from their country' and 'not understanding Arabic'. Moreover, dressing immodestly was also framed as a failure to uphold religious norms. These examples demonstrate that behaviours judged as uncivil and/or inappropriate were not judged solely based on the act itself, but on the underlying sociocultural norms and expectations that participants drew on to make sense of and evaluate the behaviour. These norms guided what was seen as uncivil or inappropriate and varied depending on what each participant prioritised.

To sum up, the findings from both X data and diary reports clearly demonstrate that perceptions of incivility in the Omani context are grounded in sociocultural norms and expectations. Across both datasets, participants consistently evaluated the behaviour based on whether it aligned with what they believed to be acceptable conduct in a given context. These evaluations were informed by perceived breaches of shared norms. Based on the findings, acts such as littering, dressing immodestly, shouting at service workers, or eating during Ramadan, and more were among the behaviours they considered uncivil. Nevertheless, the judgement of the exact behaviour on many occasions differed among participants depending on which sociocultural norms they perceived to be violated. The norms they alluded in legitimising their claims ranged from religious obligations, communal responsibility, and fairness, to most dominantly, appeals to social identity face. This underscores that incivility, as perceived, is shaped by the sociocultural norms and expectations it is seen to violate.

Having summarised the key findings for the two research questions, the following section discusses the contribution of this research

9.3 Contribution of the study

This study has significantly contributed to the field of (im)politeness empirically, theoretically and methodologically. Empirically, it broadens our understanding of taking offence and incivility by investigating the sociocultural norms and expectations that underlie their evaluations. By focusing on Omani society, this research offers valuable insights from a context that has received limited scholarly attention within (im)politeness studies. Thus, it contributes to broadening the empirical base of the field by extending its focus beyond its traditional emphasis on Western and East Asian contexts. In addition to broadening the geographical scope of (im)politeness research, this study sheds light on the specific norms and expectations that shape the evaluation of offence and incivility within Omani society, particularly the central role of social identity face in informing the judgements about inappropriate and/or offensive behaviour. In line with this dominant finding, the study demonstrated that responses to perceived offence and incivility function as acts of defending collective identity and reaffirming the shared cultural ideals that define what it means to be Omani.

Furthermore, this study moves beyond the emerging trend in both (im)politeness research and sociological studies of incivility, which frames the evaluation of offence and incivility as moral transgressions. It demonstrates that in the Omani context, the evaluation of these two phenomena is heavily grounded in sociocultural norms and expectations. It has also shown that while a moral lens

was occasionally evoked in the evaluation of both taking offence and incivility, it was framed through culturally embedded expectations, specifically, tied to ideals of how an Omani should act.

Additionally, this research brings into the foreground incivility, an underexplored concept and phenomenon in impoliteness studies. Until now, incivility has not been a central focus within (im)politeness research. This research has demonstrated that incivility warrants the same level of scholarly attention as any other social phenomenon on which impoliteness research has focused. It has been shown that the evaluations of incivility are grounded in perceived transgressions of the moral order, that is, in the violation of shared sociocultural norms and expectations that structure social life. Moreover, this study also demonstrated that when individuals post online about perceived acts of incivility, whether through pictures, video, or descriptions, they are not merely reporting incidents but are actively framing these behaviours as violations of the shared moral order.

This study also makes a theoretical contribution by extending the application of the rapport management framework to the analysis of offence and incivility within the Omani context (Spencer-Oatey, 2000 & 2008). While this framework has been previously applied to studies of taking offence (e.g., Culpeper et al., 2010), earlier applications focused only on interpersonal interactions within specific cultural contexts. Moreover, an element of this framework has been applied briefly in the Omani context by Spencer-Oatey & Kadar (2021), who illustrated an instance of sociality rights and obligations through an example involving dress code expectations in a professional governmental setting. However, their use of the framework remained illustrative and focused only on one interactional incident. Therefore, this is the first study that applies this framework systematically in the Omani context.

Moreover, another novel contribution in this study is the use of this framework to investigate incivility. To the best of my knowledge, no study to date has systematically applied rapport management rapport model to the investigation of incivility. This application extends the framework beyond its traditional usage to the evaluation of breaches of public conduct in public places.

This study has also contributed methodologically to the field by employing two distinct but complementary data collection methods: online data from X and diary report narratives. These two methods worked together to give a comprehensive understanding of taking offence and incivility in Oman. While recent research on taking offence has relied heavily on online available data such as social media posts, as I demonstrated in the literature review, it has often overlooked methods that allow for deeper engagement with how individuals make sense of offensive encounters in their

everyday lives. In response to this gap, this study combined discourse drawn from online public platforms and personal narratives captured through diary reports, a combination that is rarely used in (im)politeness research. The findings revealed a key insight in the expression of taking offence; the way offence is articulated and evaluated publicly in X differs significantly from how it is described and evaluated in private accounts of diary reports. To explain briefly, offence in X was framed as a collective concern shaped by unmet expectations related to group identity face. In contrast, the diary report narratives revealed offence as a more personal experience tied to unmet expectations of deference based on social role, and reciprocity shaped by either long-term relational history or momentary social exchanges. This contrast highlights how the expression and evaluation of offence shift depending on the tool used to collect data. This finding has important implications for the study of taking offence and broader research on impoliteness. It highlights the limitations of relying only on social media data to understand how taking offence is expressed and evaluated, as such platforms have been shown to reflect only part of the overall picture. For (im)politeness research more broadly, the findings emphasise the importance of using both publicly available sources of data alongside more private forms of data collection, such as diary reports or interviews, when studying any social phenomenon, since the medium of communication can influence or even shape the kinds of narratives individuals share.

While this study has made several significant empirical, theoretical, and methodological contributions to the field of impoliteness, it is important to acknowledge its limitations. Nevertheless, the presence of limitations does not undermine the value of this research but rather highlights areas where future research is needed to build upon and extend the insights developed in this research. The following section outlines the limitations of the study and suggests directions for future research.

9.4 Limitations of the study and future development

This study has tackled two areas that remain underexplored, not only within the Omani context but also within the broader field of (Im)politeness research: taking offence and incivility. It investigated these two topics not only as concepts but also as lived experiences. Drawing on both X data and diary report data, the study offers an in-depth account of how individuals in Omani society interpret and judge behaviours that they perceive as offensive or uncivil. While this study offers important contributions, several limitations must be acknowledged.

The first limitation is in terms of the methods used to collect data. The study used both social media posts and diary reports to explore the perceptions of offence and incivility; each method presented certain limitations. The social media data collected from X offered access to large volumes of

naturally occurring discourse; however, it only reflected the views of specific segments of the population, mainly those who use X and are accustomed to engaging in public discourse. X is not among the widely used platforms in Oman; therefore, using X might have limited the diversity of perspectives represented in the data. This limitation was addressed through the inclusion of diary reports, which captured a wider range of voices and experiences, particularly from individuals who may not typically participate on the online platform. Nevertheless, future research could still make use of social media as a data source. It is recommended, however, to consider more widely adopted platforms such as Instagram, which are used across different age groups in Oman and across different social backgrounds.

A further limitation in this research is the demographic composition of the social media dataset. Existing research on social media usage in Oman indicates that X is predominantly used by males which means that the online data largely reflected male perspectives. Although the diary reports broadened the range of voices included in the study, future research using social media should consider platforms with more a more gender-balanced user base to obtain a better picture of public evaluations.

Moreover, due to the predominance of male voices in the online data, and the fact that this study only focused on Omani nationals, it does not capture how other less represented groups such as women, expatriate workers or less advantaged members of the community, experience and evaluate offence and incivility. Therefore, future research should explore what these marginalised groups evaluate as offensive or uncivil, and how their experiences may differ.

While the previously mentioned limitations above relate to both the X dataset, and the overall focus of the study, the diary reports introduced a different set of methodological constraints. The diary reports provided valuable insights into participants' personal experiences but relied on participants' memory and willingness to share information that might be considered uncomfortable. This may have influenced how much detail participants chose to disclose, especially when describing sensitive or emotionally charged situations. In some cases, as I highlighted in the methodology chapter (see Chapter 3, Section 3.8.4), the participants skipped the open-ended 'why' questions, which were central to understanding the reasons behind their evaluation of offence or incivility. As a result, some responses lacked sufficient explanation, making it difficult to identify the underlying norms and expectations that shaped participants' judgements. Furthermore, the nature of the diary report, being a written form of data collection, does not allow for real-time follow-up, which naturally limits the ability to explore participants' responses in greater depth. Further research could consider using

focus groups or interviews to allow for deeper exploration, especially to better understand the reasoning behind their judgements.

A further limitation of this study was posed by the lack of literature on incivility within the (im)politeness field. While the study aimed to investigate incivility as a socially and culturally situated judgement, it was challenging to ground the analysis of incivility in a well-established body of work within (im)politeness research. This was due to the fact that only a small number of studies in this field have addressed incivility directly, which limited the extent to which the findings could be situated within existing work. Nevertheless, the study was able to draw on a small number of relevant contributions, such as Zhang et al.'s (2021) work on Chinese tourists' reflections on uncivil behaviour. Although this study is not situated within (im)politeness research, it offered useful insights into how incivility is evaluated through the lens of social identity and collective image, both of which were central to the findings of the present study. Future research could contribute to addressing this gap by more fully integrating incivility into the scope of (im)politeness studies. This includes examining incivility as a transgression of sociocultural norms or moral norms or a combination of both, depending on the reasoning evoked by the participants. Moreover, future research should expand the evaluative-based approach that I adopted in this study, which focuses on how individuals interpret and judge behaviours as uncivil or inappropriate based on sociocultural norms and expectations, rather than treating the behaviours themselves as inherently uncivil.

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APPENDICES

Appendix A – Arabic Version Questionnaire

استبانة

العنوان: التصرفات الغير لائقة في المجتمع العماني

القسم الأول: المشروع البحثي

١- الغرض من الدراسة وأهميتها؟

يهدف هذا البحث عن كشف النقاب عن قواعد الأدب والتصرفات غير اللائقة في المجتمع العماني.

٢- من ينظم البحث؟

باحثة دراسات عليا في جامعة أنجليا رسكن في كامبريدج، تحت اشراف د. وحيد بارفاريش و د. سابستيان

٣- هل حصلت هذه الدراسة على الموافقة؟

تم النظر في هذه الدراسة ومنحها الموافقة من قبل لجنة أخلاقيات البحث بالكلية في جامعة أنجليا رسكن

٤- طريقة التواصل مع الباحث

إذا كانت لديك بعض الأسئلة عن الدراسة يمكنك التواصل مع الباحث عن طريق البريد الإلكتروني

القسم الثاني: مشاركتك في مشروع البحث

١- ما الذي سيطلب مني القيام به؟

سيطلب منك اكمال استبيان يستمر حوالي ١٠ دقائق ويحتوي على اسئلة تتعلق بتجربتك كمواطن عماني يتعرض للإساءة في حياته اليومية

٢- ما الذي سيحدث لأية معلومات / بيانات يتم جمعها منك؟

سيتم تخزين البيانات في ملف آمن وستوافق مع القانون العام لحماية البيانات (٢٠١٨). لن يتمكن أحد من الوصول إلي البيانات سواي. سيتم حذف البيانات بعد تقديم الرسالة واجتياز الاختبار النهائي.

القسم الثالث: الموافقة على المشاركة في البحث

ضع علامه (✓) امام اختيارك

هل توافق على المشاركة في هذه الدراسة، واستخدام بياناتك في بحث الدكتوراه هذا؟

() نعم، أُنح موافقتي

() لا أُنح موافقتي

الاستبانة



العنوان: التصرفات الغير لائقة في المجتمع العماني

القسم الأول:

أ- في حياتك اليومية، هل سبق لك أن تعرضت أو شاهدت سلوك تعتبره غير لائق أو غير مقبول في الأماكن العامة؟

() نعم

() لا

القسم الثاني:

يمكنك استخدام اللهجة العامية للإجابة على الأسئلة

أخبرنا أكثر اين وماذا حدث بالضبط؟-أ

[illegible]

ب- كيف شعرت في تلك اللحظة؟ ولماذا؟

استبانة

العنوان: الإساءة في المجتمع العماني القسم

الأول: المشروع البحثي

١- الغرض من الدراسة وأهميتها؟

يهدف هذا البحث عن كشف النقاب عن قواعد الأدب والتصرفات غير اللائقة في المجتمع العماني.

٢- من ينظم البحث؟

باحثة دراسات عليا في جامعة أنجليا رسكن في كامبريدج، تحت إشراف د. وحيد بارفاريش و د. سابستيان

٣- هل حصلت هذه الدراسة على الموافقة؟

تم النظر في هذه الدراسة ومنحها الموافقة من قبل لجنة أخلاقيات البحث بالكلية في جامعة أنجليا رسكن

٤- طريقة التواصل مع الباحث

إذا كانت لديك بعض الأسئلة عن الدراسة يمكنك التواصل مع الباحث عن طريق البريد الإلكتروني

القسم الثاني: مشاركتك في مشروع البحث

١- ما الذي سيطلب مني القيام به؟

سيطلب منك اكمال استبيان يستمر حوالي ١٠ دقائق ويحتوي على اسئلة تتعلق بتجربتك كمواطن عماني يتعرض للإساءة في حياته اليومية

٢- ما الذي سيحدث لأية معلومات / بيانات يتم جمعها منك؟

سيتم تخزين البيانات في ملف آمن وستتوافق مع القانون العام لحماية البيانات (٢٠١٨). لن يتمكن أحد من الوصول إلى البيانات سوى. سيتم حذف البيانات بعد تقديم الرسالة واجتياز الاختبار النهائي.

القسم الثالث: الموافقة على المشاركة في البحث

ضع علامه (√) امام اختيارك

هل توافق على المشاركة في هذه الدراسة، واستخدام بياناتك في بحث الدكتوراه هذا؟

() نعم، أمنح موافقتي

() لا أمنح موافقتي

الاستبانة



العنوان: الإساءة في المجتمع العماني القسم الأول:

ت- هل تعرضت * للإساءة من قبل /او أي شخص تعرفه؟
*كل فعل أو قول يشعر الشخص بنوع من الأذى أو الاستياء

() نعم

() لا

القسم الثاني:

يمكنك استخدام اللهجة العامية للإجابة على الأسئلة
أ- أخبرنا أكثر اين وماذا حدث بالضبط؟

ب- كيف جعلك هذه الموقف تشعر؟ ولماذا؟

شكراً على مشاركتك في هذه الدراسة

Appendix B – Participation Information

Section A: The Research Project

14. Title of project

Taking offence and incivility in the Omani society

15. Brief summary of research.

This research aims to unveil the norms of impoliteness and incivility in the Omani society.

16. Name of your Supervisor

Dr.Vahid Parvaresh

17. Why have I been asked to participate?

You have been invited to take part in this study because you are an Omani citizen and because you have a good knowledge of the Omani society .

18. How many people will be asked to participate?

200 participants

19. What are the likely benefits of taking part?

There is no direct benefit to you as a participant, but it has potential to contribute to the study field by uncovering the various social, interpersonal and cognitive norms governing perceptions of incivility and offensiveness in Oman.

20. Can I refuse to take part?

Yes, you can refuse, but this has to be done before the thesis has been submitted

21. Has the study got ethical approval?

This study has been looked at and granted ethical approval by the Faculty Research Ethics Panel at Anglia Ruskin University to protect your interest.

22. Has the organisation where you are carrying out the research given permission?

Not relevant

23. If your research falls under specific legislation e.g. the Human Tissue Act (2004), you

Not relevant

24. Source of funding for the research, if applicable.

Not relevant

25. What will happen to the results of the study?

The anonymised version of the result will be used in my dissertation, and after the submission as well as passing the viva, data will be removed.

26. Contact for further information

Muhja Saif Al-hadi,

Email: muhja.al-hadi@pgr.aru.ac.uk

Dr.Vahid Parvaresh

Email: vahid.parvaresh@anglia.ac.uk.

Section B: Your Participation in the Research Project (Diary report)

1. What will I be asked to do?

You will be asked to complete an online diary report which last around 10 minutes and contain an open-ended question related to your experience as an Omani citizen with taking offence and incivility.

2. Will my participation in the study be kept confidential?

Yes, it will be confidential and anonymised. The result will also be written up in anonymised format and no names will be mentioned. All anonymous data will be stored in a password protected computer and will comply with GDPR and Data Protection Act (2018).

3. Use of quotes.

Yes, they will be used, but they will be anonymised, and no personal information will be made available.

4. Use of recording equipment

No, it won't be used for the diary reports

5. Will I be reimbursed travel expenses?

The research does not require you to travel.

6. Are there any possible disadvantages or risks to taking part?

Since this research is about taking offence, you might find it inconvenient so you may withdraw at any time.

7. Whether I can withdraw at any time, and how.

If you do not wish to take part in the study, you are under no obligation to do so. You can withdraw any time, but you should inform me before the submission of the thesis is made.

8. What will happen to any information/data/samples (delete as applicable) that are collected from you?

Data will be stored in secure file and will comply with GDPR and Data Protection Act (2018). Nobody will have access to the data except me. The data will be deleted after the submission of the thesis and passing the viva.

9. Summary of research findings

I can send you a summary of the findings upon request.

10. Contact details for complaints.

If you have any complaints about the study, in the first instance, you should be encouraged to speak to me or my Supervisor Dr.Vahid vahid.parvaresh@anglia.ac.uk. Alternatively, please contact Anglia Ruskin University's complaints at: Email address: complaints@anglia.ac.uk

Postal address: Office of the Secretary and Clerk, Anglia Ruskin University, Bishop Hall Lane, Chelmsford, Essex, CM1 1SQ

Date 24.10.16, V1.0

Section C : Your Participation in the Research Project (Diary report 2)

1. What will I be asked to do?

You will be asked to complete an online diary report which last around 10 minutes and contain open-ended questions related to specific experiences concerning taking offence and incivility.

2. Will my participation in the study be kept confidential?

Yes, it will be confidential and anonymised. The result will also be written up in anonymised format and no names will be mentioned. All anonymous data will be stored in a password protected computer and will comply with GDPR and Data Protection Act (2018).

3. Use of quotes.

Yes, they will be used, but they will be anonymised, and no personal information will be made available.

4. Use of recording equipment

No, it won't be used for the diary reports.

5. Will I be reimbursed travel expenses?

The research does not require you to travel.

6. Are there any possible disadvantages or risks to taking part?

Since this research is about taking offence, you might find it inconvenient so you may withdraw at any time.

7. Whether I can withdraw at any time, and how.

If you do not wish to take part in the study, you are under no obligation to do so. You can withdraw any time, but you should inform me before the submission of the thesis is made.

8. What will happen to any information/data/samples (delete as applicable) that are collected from you?

Data will be stored in secure file and will comply with GDPR and Data Protection Act (2018). Nobody will have access to the data except me. The data will be deleted after the submission of the thesis and passing the viva.

9. Summary of research findings

I can send you a summary of the findings upon request.

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If you have any complaints about the study, in the first instance, you should be encouraged to speak to me or my Supervisor Dr.Vahid vahid.parvaresh@anglia.ac.uk. Alternatively, please contact Anglia Ruskin University's complaints at: Email address: complaints@anglia.ac.uk

Postal address: Office of the Secretary and Clerk, Anglia Ruskin University, Bishop Hall Lane, Chelmsford, Essex, CM1 1SQ

Date 24.10.16

V1.0

Appendix C – Ethics Application

19 Oct 2023

Dear Muhja Saif

Principal Investigator: Muhja Saif Al-Hadi

Research ethics application number: ETH2324-0428

Project Title: Incivility and the taking of offence in the Omani society

Risk Level: Yellow (medium)

Notification of ethical approval

I am pleased to inform you that your ethics application has been approved by the School Research Ethics Panel (SREP) under the terms of ARU's Research Ethics Policy (available on the research ethics website at www.aru.ac.uk/researchethics).

Ethical approval is given for a period of 3 years for PGR students and staff from the date of this letter.

If your research will extend beyond this period, it is your responsibility to apply for an extension before your approval expires.

It is your responsibility to ensure that you comply with ARU's Research Ethics Policy and the Code of Practice for Applying for Ethical Approval available at www.aru.ac.uk/researchethics, including the following:

- Following the procedure for submitting amendments to the panel, should there be any substantial change to your research. You cannot implement substantial amendments to your research prior to receiving approval from the SREP.
- Following the procedure for reporting accidents, adverse events and incidents.
- Complying with the General Data Protection Requirement and Data Protection Act (2018).
- Complying with any other legislation relevant to your research. You must also ensure that you are aware of any emerging legislation related to your research and that you make all relevant changes of legal compliance to your study (for which you will need to obtain ethical approval).
- Obtaining any further ethical approval required from the organisation or country (if not carrying out research in the UK) where you will be carrying out the research. This includes other Higher Education Institutions, if you intend to carry out any research involving their students, staff or premises. Please ensure that you send copies of this

documentation to the SREP Secretary, if required, prior to starting your research.

- Complying with any laws of the country where you are carrying out the research and obtaining any other approvals or permissions that are required.
- Abiding by any professional codes of conduct relating to your research or requirements from your funding body (please note that for externally funded research, where the funding has been obtained via ARU, a Project Risk Assessment must have been carried out prior to starting the research).
- Completing a Risk Assessment (Health and Safety), if required, and updating this annually or whenever any aspects of your study change which might affect this.
- Notifying the SREP Secretary when your study has ended.

Please also note that your research may be

subject to monitoring. Should you have any

queries, please do not hesitate to contact me. I

wish you an interesting and successful research

experience.

Yours

sincerely, Dr

Bettina

Beinhoff

Humanities and Social Sciences SREP

ARU Cambridge, East Road, Cambridge, CB1 1PT 01245 493 131

Appendix D – Transliteration

Arabic Script	IPA symbol	Symbols used in IVAr
Consonants		
أ - الهمزة	ʔ	2
ب	b	b
ت	t	t
ث	θ	th
ج	ʒ	j
ح	ħ	H
خ	x	x
د	d	d
ذ	ð	dh
ر	r	r
ز	z	z
س	s	s
ش	ʃ	sh
ص	tʃ	ch
ض	sʕ	S
ط	tʕ	T
ظ	dʕ	D
ع	ðʕ, zʕ	DH, Z
غ	ɣ	3
ف	ɣ	gh
ق	f	f
ك	q	q
گ	k	k
ل	g	g
م	l	l
ن	m	m
ه	n	n
و	h	h

و	w	w
ي	j	y
v	v	v

Vowels		
ا	a:	a:
ي	i:, e:	i:, e:
و	u:, o:	u:, o:
أَ، إَ، عَ	a	a
إِ، كَسْرَ	i	i
أُ، ضَمَ	u	u

Other symbols:

gemination	double the letter (e.g. 2a ll a:h)
al-	assimilate the l- when it is assimilated e.g. lwalad TT awi:l
attach prepositions to nouns	Examples: minil madi:na (من المدينة) fil be:t (في البيت) b3ishri: (بِعثَرين) fiTTari:g (في الطريق)

Appendix E – Diary Report for Taking Offence Study (English Version)

Section one

A. Have you (or someone you know) ever been *offended before?

Any action or statement that causes a person to feel hurt or upset

() Yes

() No

Section Two:

You may use colloquial language to answer the following questions.

A. Tell us more about it, where and what happened exactly?

B. How did this situation make you feel ?and why?

Appendix F – Diary Report for Incivility Study (English Version)

Section one

- A. In your daily life, have you ever encountered or witnessed a behaviour that you consider inappropriate or unacceptable in a public space ?

() Yes

() No

Section Two:

You may use colloquial language to answer the following questions.

- A. Tell us more about it, where did it happen, and what happened exactly?

- B. How did you feel at that moment, and why?
